

in too deep
KENNY WRIGHT *part two*

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IN TOO DEEP, BOOK 3

I carefully applied the ink, tracing it along Amanda's lower back, following the swirls and eddies of her existing tattoo. It reminded me of my younger years. I used to love painting and art. Even thought—very briefly—of going to school for it. "How often do you have to do this?" I asked.

The ink that I was applying was barely darker than the tattoo itself, just wetter looking.

"Once a week. It should last up to three, but it'll start to fade."

"Julia usually do it?"

Despite my mixed feelings about Amanda's handler, I still felt a twinge in my gut just mentioning her name. Part of that had to do with the memory of her lips wrapped around my cock. Part of it was the thought of watching her hands delicately trace my wife's lower back.

"Yeah. Only Julia. She seemed to delight in marking me."

"For someone whose job it is to keep you alive, she sure doesn't seem to like you. But it's more than that. I don't just get 'dislike of Amanda' from her. Even as she bangs the 'against procedure' drum left, right, and center, it clearly feels that at times she's just making it up as she goes along. Why?"

"It's an excellent question. One that I've been wrestling with a lot lately. *Why* did she involve you—a civilian— so heavily in this operation? There have been some other red flags, too, ones that I've been ignoring, too wrapped up in the rest of the case."

In her identity as Raven, she didn't need to say. In her cover as a stripper and a whore and the girlfriend to the still at-large Nikolai Kozlov.

"Like, I get why she sent you the video, but it seems like a risky thing to do, right? And then she brought you to the apartment, just as the case was close to the end, and things got complicated after that."

This was my own red flag. As I finished the last point on the beak of the raven, I said, "Now there's a statement that feels good to hear."

My work completed, I carefully capped the applicator. Then I heaved a sigh as I unkinked my shoulders and sat back. I said, "Sorry that I'm just a complication in your plan."

Amanda started to twist towards me, but stopped. The ink took an hour to dry, and she was immobilized for most of that. "That came out wrong. You were never just a complication—"

"But I wasn't much of a consideration, either. Why? What's so important about *this case* that made you justify becoming a whore?"

Amanda winced, but didn't back down. Even lying as she was, head resting on the sofa, naked other than for a black thong, she was poised and in control. As upset as I was with her, that was hot as hell.

"This is bigger than a lab for some designer drug, or a local drug distributor. There is more behind Nick—Nikolai Kozlov—and his operation. He's just the speartip of something new and bigger. There will be more Kozlovs and more jazz epidemics. I want to shut all of it down. I want to dig it out by the roots."

There was fire in her voice. Her body tensed and her skin tightened. Then she saw me again, sitting there, my own face no doubt resembling a thundercloud, and my shoulders slumped.

She said, "And yet none of that justifies any of what I did. I know I'll be earning back your trust for the rest of my life, but I'm ready to do that."

She reached out for my hand. I looked from her outstretched palm, up to meet her gaze, and then back to her palm. I made no move to take it.

"Are you sure about that?"

She did not drop her hand. Looking me dead in the eye, she said, "Having second thoughts already?"

I crossed my arms. "Answer the question."

She stared me down for a number of heartbeats.

Then, she blinked. "David, I'm always gonna want you. Moreso now than ever. At this very moment it feels like you're too far away. You're both under my skin and not close enough." She paused for effect. "Of *course* I'm sure."

I pursed my lips for a moment. She continued to hold her hand out to me.

"Have you considered," I said, "that your determination to set things right with me might also be partially driving your compulsion to crack the case-within-a-case that no one else seems to see?"

She cocked her head in that way she had when analyzing fresh data. Knowing her as I did, the fact that she didn't immediately dismiss the question told me she had likely already considered it herself.

She sighed and dropped her hand. "That thought has occurred to me, yes. I don't know. Maybe getting to the bottom of this whole thing, bringing in every last one of the motherfuckers who made it feel necessary to gradually compromise my values and betray you and *us* over and over again might help right the scales. You know. Make all of this, everything I've put us both through, count for something."

I nodded. "Fair enough. And *of course* I'm having second thoughts. And third thoughts. And sixty-fifth thoughts. Jesus Christ, you say you know what you did and yeah, you feel awful about it—and I don't doubt that.

"But stop and think for a minute, see it from my point of view. For days at a time I was tortured by all these fucked up internal dialogues and crippling doubt. I questioned my own sanity at a couple of points."

It was her turn to slump, her body sinking into the sofa. She averted her eyes and blinked several times, then swallowed hard.

I went on before I lost my nerve. "So you're damned right you're gonna need to reassure me for a good long while. One minute, I'm fine, and the next, I'm not."

And then I reached out my hand for hers. "So you're stuck with me. No place else I can get all that coming reassurance. But taking the rest of your life? Nah. I intend to make sure you live a good, looooooong time, far longer than the time it will take to get my trust all the way back."

She brightened at my words, and reached out her hand and took mine, entwining our fingers. I wasn't ready to completely forgive her, but it was nice to understand a little more what was going on in her head, and just as importantly, to let her know what was going on in mine. And that was likely how it was going to go, at least for a while. Communicating constantly. Relentless checking in. Ruthless honesty. Rebuilding our trust and deepening our bond one conversation, hell, some days one *second* at a time.

"You know," I said, glancing at the drying tattoo on her girlspot. "I think the tattoo is really sexy."

She actually flushed. "Me too," she whispered. "Don't tell the old me."

My dick hardened. This was the epitome of my contradiction—I was upset at her for what she'd done, yet so profoundly turned on by it.

"You always hated women who got tattoos there," I pointed out.

"I did, yeah. I've reconsidered a lot of things lately. My outlook on life is a lot less black-and-white these days."

"That's quite an understatement."

"It actually started with you, believe it or not." She squeezed my hand. "I never intended to fall in love, and you helped me realize that I can't plan for everything in life." She was quick to add, "Not that I'm justifying any of what I've done because of you."

"I know, I know." I moved up to sit by her head, stroking her silky, dark hair. "So tell me about the first man you fucked." A hit of adrenaline rippled through me at the word. "Was he that client that you went home with?"

"No." From her angle, she couldn't quite see me, although she could raise up onto her elbows and trace her hands along the seat of my pants. "He worked at the Gold Club. You saw him. Or part of him in that video."

"The hiring manager," I said.

Amanda laughed. "Not his official title, but maybe an unofficial one. All the dancers go through Mark."

I wondered if the other agent undercover, Misty/Mia Moore, had to as well. "They all slept with him?"

"They all sucked his dick." She was so matter-of-fact about it. "I took things further."

"Just like that?" I asked.

"No, not quite. There was a time when I thought that I could get away without sleeping with anyone. Pretty naive, in retrospect."

"Tell me how it happened." I was torn between horror and arousal, but the more comfortable I got with what she'd done, the more things tipped in the direction of excitement. "I I want to know."

Amanda twisted just enough to look me in the eyes. I smiled down at her, stroking her cheek. I could see her smile in return, even from this awkward angle. It wasn't a cruel one, but one of relief and more than a little delight. Still smiling, she started to work my pants open. My cock had only stiffened.

"For the first few weeks, I did everything that I could to get his attention without crossing any lines. When I was dancing and he was there, I paid special attention to him. When he wasn't, I danced even harder because I knew there were cameras. I danced my ass off. When I wasn't in the club, I was in a private gym we had, practicing even harder. When I was working, I tried flirting. I offered him dances, but none of it worked."

She took a deep breath, blew it out teasingly along my cock, then looked me in the eye, and continued.

"We knew early on that Kozlov was a voyeur," she said. I noted how she stumbled over his name, like she had to retrain herself from calling him Nick. "It wasn't a secret, and all the girls there knew how he liked to watch. Even that video that you saw was for him. So I knew that the best way to catch his eye was to perform."

She wrapped her hand around my cock and started pumping me, resting her cheek on my thigh. I gently stroked her hair.

"And I realized, after a week of getting nowhere, what kind of performance it needed to be."

"And here's where you could have drawn a line," I said. "Like Mia."

Amanda nodded. "I could have. A huge part of me should have. But let's be clear here, the only lines Mia was drawing were made of white powder. She's no innocent, here. If anything, she helped normalize everything that followed. She was already turning tricks when I got there. I knew that to capture the attention of the boss, I needed to be splashy."

I reeled from the revelation. *What kind of operation was this?!*

"I didn't have the best shifts at the time, but that worked out for me. It was a Monday night when I was working until closing. It was slow, so we were able to close down a little before 4 am. Mark, the manager, was closing up the register. Everyone else had gone home. I waited for him, sitting on the stage, knowing that the cameras were still on and that hopefully Kozlov would eventually watch."

"You seduced Mark," I said. My mouth was dry and my cock was hard in her hands. She seemed to take comfort in that, squeezing me, leaning forward to nuzzle me, a playful lick, and a sigh along the wet trail she left on my cock.

"Yes. I remember calling over to him. Telling him that I was still grateful for getting me the job, and that I wanted to give him an extra special thanks."

I wasn't angry with her. I could have been. Many probably would think that I *should* have been. That feeling of betrayal was still there. It would be for a long time. But right now, as she described the moment when she turned into an adulteress, I was literally shaking with excitement.

"What?" I stopped myself, embarrassed by what I was about to ask.

"Hm?"

"Nevermind."

"No, what, David? You can ask me anything."

She was right. If I couldn't be honest and open, how could I expect this to work? "I was just wondering what were you wearing?"

She beamed at me. "I wore this short tennis skirt and a half shirt that hung off one shoulder. Oh, and a red bra."

I swallowed hard. "No panties?"

"I knew what I needed to do, and I had to make sure that I didn't chicken out." Amanda shifted some in my lap, wrapping her lips around my cock and swirling my dick once. My corresponding sharp intake of breath only seemed to delight her further. "Going commando felt so wrong, yet also so " She searched for the right word. I helped.

"So different from who you thought you were," I said. "More like something Raven did."

"Yes!" she said.

"So how did you do it?"

"It was pretty easy. Mark wasn't exactly resistant to being seduced. I knew where the cameras were positioned, though, and the hardest part was to perform *for* them without ever looking at them."

"Sounds like a pornstar problem," I said. Even in the moment, I wondered what Ty would think of *this*. Would he say, *'You have a pornstar for a wife!'* "Keep going."

Amanda sucked my dick a few more times, getting me nice and wet, before returning to her slippery handjob. "We kissed a lot. I took his hand in mine and pulled it under my skirt. He took the hint and started fingering me."

My stomach lurched at the intimacy of the *kissing*. Amanda didn't seem to notice. I swelled in her capable hands. She was in the zone,, reliving that moment.

"I pulled my top off and opened my bra. He started sucking my nipples, nibbling on them. It hurt, but I liked it. When I told him that I did, he started to get even more rough."

"Oh, Amanda," I groaned, feeling my balls tighten. I took a deep breath, staving off the inevitable. She took the hint, slowing her handjob.

"Are you sure you want to hear this?" she asked.

I appreciated that she checked in.

"Are you sure you're okay telling it?"

She didn't hesitate. "'No secrets.' Meant it. 'Earning trust.' Meant that."

"In that case, yes, I do. Tell me."

"Right. So he pulled out a condom. It's crazy, I know, because I knew where this was going to end, but seeing him tear open that foil, smelling the spermicide, watching him roll it down his thick cock it made it all so real." Her hand had basically stopped at the base of my dick. "And I *wanted* it, David. I'm so sorry, but I was so fucking turned on. I climbed up onto the stage and spread my legs. He grabbed my ankles, held them high, and drove into me hard. I flopped back on the stage, grabbing the stripper pole, and held on as he fucked me."

She blinked up at me. I stroked her hair. Her skin was burning up. "It turns you on," I said. "Thinking about fucking your manager."

"Yes," she whispered.

"Touch yourself," I ordered.

Her turn to gasp.

"Remember, you said it was going to be different," I reminded. "Let's make this ours."

I could not recall her ever giving me a wider smile.

It took some careful shifting not to smudge the drying ink, but she got her free hand beneath her, down between her legs, as she started to pump me.

"The sex was exciting, but you know what turned me on more than anything else?" She answered her own question. "Knowing that there were cameras. Knowing that I had an audience. By that time, I was used to stripping, and went back to the apartment every night turned on by the attention. This took things even further."

I noted how she called her place 'the apartment,' rather than 'home.' *This*, our time together, was our true home.

This confession actually aligned with the Amanda I'd fallen for. The first time I really noticed her was during a formal debate in one of our classes. I remember how composed she was, how confident. That confidence was hot as hell, and she seemed to revel in all that attention.

"He ended up fucking me bent over the stage, squeezing my ass so hard that I swear he left an impression the next day. I could feel him coming in the condom and it set me on fire. I screamed, backing into him hard enough that he actually fell back on his ass with a curse. I crawled over to him, ripped the condom off, and lapped up all that come."

"Jesus," I groaned.

Amanda looked up at me as she jerked me off. No more holding off. She finished me, and I spurted all over my shirt tails.

"The next day, Nikolai Kozlov looked at me differently. I had my in."

With my excitement cooling on my stomach, the angst was back, although it was less powerful than the last few weeks. After all, I'd watched her get DP'ed by two dicks.

"So by my count, that's three guys you were with—Kozlov, Mark, and that first rich fuck you had a threesome with. Leaves nine more men in about six weeks."

"Yeah," Amanda admitted. "That sounds bad."

It did. And that's all I should have thought, but it wasn't. "It also turns me on. Sorry."

"Hey, don't apologize, baby. Are you kidding me? And the number could have been much higher, but I was selective because I knew that I could be. Unless Nick ordered me to fuck someone."

He was 'Nick' again. "He liked doing that."

"Yes. He gets off on control as much as he does on watching."

"Maybe we can use that to our advantage," I offered.

"I was thinking the same thing, but you'd be okay with that? You know what that would mean."

Sex with other men, *for* another man. I actually started to get hard again at the idea. "I do," I said. I slipped off the sofa. "Are you okay with it?"

She watched me, her head propped up under her elbow. "I can be. And Baby," she said as she leaned forward and nuzzled my nose with the tip of her own, "I am gonna make this so good for you."

A banging came from the door that led into the bedroom, followed shortly by Ty's booming voice. "You two done fucking in there or whatever?"

"No," we said in unison, then started laughing.

"Well, hurry up. I've got some ideas and am sure as shit not gonna yell through the door."

We'd needed a safe place to talk, and Ty's place was the most convenient and least conspicuous.

I looked down at Amanda's naked form, then at the mess that was my shirt. "Give us a second."

It was good to laugh together again.

FOREWORD

If you've picked this book up, I really hope that you've already read *In Too Deep: Part 1*. This isn't one of those sequels that can be read independently of the other. It will not make any sense.

That said, there just *may* be a sequel to this whole saga that could, theoretically, be independent, the way Rian Johnson's *Glass Onion* can be enjoyed without having seen *Knives Out*. As I wrote in the foreword to the first book, *In Too Deep* has been one of the hardest things that I've written, but also one of the most rewarding. Judging from the volume of comments I've received on it on Patreon, along with the sales for part one, I'd say that you all have enjoyed it as well.

Well, enough blather. Go now and see how this one concludes. The road is still quite windy, so buckle up!

BOOK 3

PLANNING

“Okay, so let me get this straight,” Ty said. “You have known who the drug lord of the current jazz epidemic is this whole time and didn’t pick him up. Why not?”

We were sitting around the kitchen table in Ty’s apartment, beers cracked open despite the fact that it was only 11. The pretense was easy—we were old friends with him from Columbia, back when they called us the Three Musketeers. This visit had nothing to do with Ty being LAPD, even though it kind of did.

“You know better than anyone how this works,” Amanda said. She was back in casual clothing—leggings, a loose blouse—but something had changed about her. There was an alluring quality in everything that she did now, and as I watched my old friend and my wife discuss shop, I couldn’t help but think about them fucking. And it turned me on.

Amanda was going on with analogies of roots and weeds and infections, and Ty countered with ones that involved beheading snakes and hot irons.

“Okay, I get it,” Ty finally conceded. “If you’d picked him up, someone else would have filled the vacuum that he’d left. But there’s more going on here. You know where he is *now*.”

“Not exactly,” Amanda said. “But sure, we could probably figure it out.”

We’d been in contact with him since last night, when he sent his message.

I must see you, solntse. I can’t trust anyone else.

But he had yet to reveal where he was actually hiding—if he could be believed at all.

“So what’s the whole story here?” Ty pressed. He regarded the two of us together, his expression as eager as a hungry lion’s.

Amanda looked at me, so I answered. “She thinks there’s something going on in the FBI. There have been some red flags.”

“Like what?” he asked, leaning in.

I checked on Amanda, who was actually blushing. When our eyes met, she shrugged. “Go ahead. You’ve already told him some of it.”

There was a little anger there, but in the end she understood why I'd confided in Ty about her stripper assignment. She was mostly embarrassed.

"It seems like everything about it was set up to fail," I said, piecing together some of what we'd talked about earlier this morning, on the way over here. "They sent her home to me after I saw her dancing at the club."

"Yeah, that doesn't seem normal," Ty agreed.

"Exactly," I said. "Not normal. There's a shocking lack of protocol all over the place. Julia being somehow both Amanda's handler and establishing her own cover that *involves going to the club*. And then there's the way the operation was run." I turned to Amanda for help with that one.

"There was never a 'command post.' When we were running the Miami show, we had a base of operations. Here, it kind of moves around. Feels very impromptu. All of our traffic reports—if they could be called that—were written out by Julia first for us to sign. She didn't really make anything up, but she left a lot out. It was for our protection, she explained, since a lot of what was going on was pretty "

"Incriminating," I helped her out. Amanda winced. "That's probably the real kicker there. This operation went way beyond the pale."

"I went way beyond the pale, he means," Amanda said.

"And I get it now," I said, squeezing her hand. "But they should have pulled you out either way."

"The weirdest thing was that Hirsch has always been a real stickler for procedure. It was almost like Julia was shielding him from the truth."

"The few conversations that *were* being logged were in other languages. Russian or Ukrainian or Chechen," Amanda said. "Some Uzbek, I think. And we had no direct translator on the team."

"Huh," Ty said, scratching his beard. "Literally 'off the books.'"

"So you can see why we're hesitant to take this to them," I said.

"Okay," Ty said. "So it seems like you've got several things going on here. You may have a bad actor inside the FBI, who may or may not be working with Kozlov. And then you've got the network behind Kozlov, waiting in the wings, ready to fill the vacuum. This brings up a lot of questions."

He ticked them off, raising a finger after each. "First, does Kozlov know that you're FBI, and if he does, is that text a trap? Second, if there's a bad actor trying to sabotage the operation, why? Third, provided that he doesn't know Amanda's FBI, why isn't Kozlov contacting his network if he's in trouble rather than his stripper girlfriend?" Ty couldn't hide the grin before asking the next question. "Fourth, if I help, do I get a free lap dance?"

Amanda chuckled and shook her head. "Good to know that you haven't changed at all, Ty."

I looked between them, wondering if I was just imagining the sexual tension. They'd always played this game, but now that I knew they'd slept with one another, it changed my perspective. And again, I found my pants tightening.

"And of course my fifth question—what do we do first?"

"First," Amanda said, "we need to establish whether Nikolai Kozlov is working with someone in the FBI. Then we go from there."

"How do you propose we do that?"

Amanda set the burner phone on the table. "We've been chatting. He's paranoid and alone, laying low. Says that I'm the only one that he trusts, but I can't imagine that could possibly be true."

"Okay," Ty said. "Not much to go on there."

"He wants her to get him some coke," I said.

Ty chuckled. "Yeah, that'll help with the paranoia."

"I think it's a test," I said, rubbing Amanda's back reassuringly.

"Or a trap," Ty said.

Amanda turned the burner phone in her fingers. "Either way, we have to check this out, and we could use some backup."

"You've got a plan, I take it?"

"Sort of."

"Let's hear it."

Amanda and I exchanged looks. She nodded at me, then turned to Ty. "Well, it's time to be Raven again."

MUSCLE

“You doing okay, buddy?” Ty asked me.

“You know ” I said vaguely. We weren’t the only white guys at the bar, but we were definitely in the minority. Not that anyone paid us much mind.

“I’m actually pretty sure that I *don’t* know,” Ty said with a good natured smile. “Last I checked, you were torn between being disgusted by what your wife was up to, and turned on by it.”

“Still torn,” I said. “But doing better now. We’ve had a few heart-to-hearts, and we’re learning more and more about one another.”

“Turns out she’s not the girl you thought you were marrying?” Ty asked.

I shook my head. “More like she’s a lot more complex than that girl. Also, a lot wilder.”

It was at that moment that Amanda made her entrance as Raven. The lounge was crowded enough that I could see the ripple of attention she created as she slithered through it.

“I’m piecing that together,” Ty said as he checked her out. “Never thought I’d see her in a dress like that.”

The dress was a brownish, snake-skin bodycon, short, extremely tight, and cut so low in front that her big breasts were exposed nearly to her nipples. She wore a garrish amount of eyeliner and had the left side of her head braided in tight cornrows. The rest of her dark hair flowed freely.

As she settled into an open spot at the bar and waved the bartender over, I said, “Take right now. If she were forced to do this—to put that dress on and do what she may need to do later,” my heart and my dick leapt as I glided past that thought; “if she had to do it all and was just acting, it’s a fucked-up situation.”

“Made worse because you’re kind of into it,” Ty said.

“Yeah. One of my many existential struggles.”

The bartender went right to Amanda, who leaned over the bar to whisper something to him. He nodded, his eyes unable to escape the draw of her chest,

and poured her something fruity looking. She thanked him, brushing her fingers over his hand as she took the drink.

"But she's *not* just acting," I went on. "There is a part of her that *is* Raven. She enjoys the way men look at her, the way they objectify her. She likes getting to be bad. And that kind of gives me permission to enjoy it, too."

"You are so funny, David. You didn't need permission, you needed an excuse. But I'm glad that you found it."

All around her, guys were sizing her up, working up the courage to move in. I could see them eyeing one another, as if determining who was the most alpha.

The bar was something between a club and lounge. Hip hop had people bouncing and grinding on a dance floor, and booths around the perimeter featured bottle service, pretty women, and young, tough looking men.

The man who finally did approach was the one we were hoping for—Sammy, one of the guys from the Living Room. It was a little hard to recognize him with his clothes on—a lighter skinned black man with closely cropped hair and a mustache-less goatee—but Amanda immediately did, throwing her arms around him.

I could imagine how that must have felt, for Amanda to push those pillowy tits into him. Ty actually grunted, obviously imagining the same.

The jackals around them retreated. Sammy, it turned out, really was some big shot. Amanda and Sammy fell into a flirty conversation as Ty turned back to me.

"Don't want to be too obvious staring. She's been claimed, friend. Staring will only offend."

"Right. Got it." I gave them one last look, felt that tight excitement, and turned away. "You know him?"

"I do, actually. Samuel Leondrŭ Bates, A.K.A. Sammy 9Pole, as in 'stripper pole,' not as in 'Dude can pull,' yeah?" He grinned at me.

I'd seen Sammy's equipment. "Subtle," I said.

"Double entendre," Ty said. "Guy lives for 'em. 'Pole' is what the corner boys call a gun these days. '9' refers to a Glock 9mm, Sammy's preferred tool of the trade."

"Quite a connected guy. Guns, mostly, but enough drugs to get Narco's attention. I get why our buddy Nick was cultivating a relationship here." He patted my shoulder. "You better get in position. This is heating up quickly."

Across the room, Sammy was whispering something in Amanda's ear that made her laugh as his hand crawled up her thigh.

My breath caught.

"I'll be eyes in here should something go sideways. Unless you want me to be the driver. Happy to—"

"No, I've got it."

Ty grinned. "Don't forget the hat."

"Right."

I exited the bar on legs that felt like they were entirely constructed of rubber. I swore I drew more than a few glances at my herky-jerky gait before I was back out on the street, headed for a black Lincoln Navigator that Ty had "borrowed" from the LAPD impound lot. We'd already fixed a Lyft light on the back window.

I climbed into the driver seat and grabbed the “hat.” I think Ty and Amanda just wanted me to wear this ridiculous thing, even though we all agreed that Sammy probably wouldn’t remember me. It was a black hat with long, fake hair streaming out below it. I looked ridiculous in it, like I should be driving a truck rather than a Premium Rideshare vehicle. Amanda had done her best to hide her laugh. Ty didn’t bother. I could still hear his booming laugh as I fitted the hat on and slipped a bud into my ear. At least the wig covered that.

“Okay, I’m in position,” I said.

Ty’s voice cut through the clamor of the club. *“Check. I can hear you.”* Then, just before the mic cut out, I heard him say, *“Damn, that’s hot—”*

“What?” I pressed. It was awfully quiet in the car. I switched it on and drove a few blocks away, so that I could simulate a pickup.

“Just that I keep waiting for your wife to drop kick this guy or something. His hands are all over her.”

I stiffened, suddenly wishing that I had switched roles with Ty. “Jealous?” I asked.

“Hell, yeah, I am. You?”

“Always. But I’m also good.”

I swapped over to the audio coming from Amanda’s purse bug, just in time to pick up the thread.

‘Why you here, Raven.’ Their voices were even harder to hear than Ty’s. I turned up the audio, wincing at the hiss of feedback.

‘Nicky sent me.’

‘Did he? Why’s that?’

‘Said he needs a favor.’

‘How big a favor?’

‘He wants some coke, and he needs some muscle.’

‘And what do I get?’

‘For the blow, you get me. For the muscle, he said something about stakes in his next enterprise.’

‘Yes to the first. Baby, you so fine. For number two, I need to speak with my colleagues.’

‘Of course.’

Ty came in over top of them.

“Get ready,” he said. *“They’re coming out.”*

My phone blipped. It was Amanda, summoning a fake Lyft ride, along with an address. It wasn’t a sophisticated setup, but it would be enough for something cobbled together in less than a day.

As I pulled the SUV up in front of the bar, Amanda was there, draped all over Sammy. They were deep in a kiss as I pulled up. My heart sang. I adjusted myself, took a deep breath, and got out of the car to open the door.

Sammy broke the kiss as Amanda climbed in, flashing me a mischievous smile. Now I actually *could* see the top half of her nipples as she ducked low. She didn’t bother fixing the dress. Sammy followed, eyes on her ass, not even acknowledging me.

I shut the door, took yet another deep breath, and went back to the driver’s seat.

Sammy was laughing at something Amanda said as I pulled the door shut. "He's generous, you right about that," Sammy said. "Although I think he gets off on sharing his sluts, rather than having a warm and open heart."

"And you know I *love* being shared."

"Hell yeah, I do."

I pulled the car out and began to follow the directions on the GPS. It was hard to keep my focus on that little screen and the road in front of me. The sounds of kissing, of the rich leather seats crunching, of my wife sighing with pleasure, were all too distracting. But it was the unmistakable sound of Sammy's zipper that drew me back.

"Time to start earning it," he said as he pulled his very large dick out. He grabbed Amanda's head and pushed her into his lap. She didn't need to be forced, but seemed to get off on it.

With her hair braided on one side, there was nothing to obstruct the view of Amanda's lips wrapped around that thick dick. Despite Sammy's hand in her hair, guiding her bobbing head, she seemed to be the one in control. She pumped him with both hands, her slender white fingers wringing and jerking his dark girth, as she throatied his head.

Sammy's other hand ran down her body, pulling up the snakeskin dress to reveal a black g-string. He plunged his fingers along her ass crack and down between her legs. She moaned as his fingers entered her, each digit fatter and no doubt rougher than mine.

Sammy lounged back in the spacious interior of the Lincoln, a contented smile on his face as my hot wife worked his lap. "You've got a nice booty for a white girl," he said. "Although if you worked for me, you'd need a li'l bit more meat."

Amanda's blowjob intensified as Sammy fingered her. He started to thrust up, forcing her to gag and choke on his meat. Amanda was rolling her hips back into his hand, close to coming herself, her moans leaking out around all that dick flesh.

I saw it all in vibrant, raunchy bursts, stolen in the rearview mirror, the street lamps strobing over their undulating bodies. Once, as the lights blazed across her face, I saw Amanda staring right at me, alight and full of lust in the reflection. I choked. I was so hard, my chest so tight. I had to make myself breathe as I drove, and nearly missed my turn.

Sammy noticed. "Our driver's lookin'," he chuckled. To me, he said, "This one's for real."

Amanda slurped free of his dick long enough to say, "You know I love an audience."

"Then get the fuck up here and give him a better show," he said. "I know you want my black cock." He removed a condom wrapper from his pocket. "But put this on, first. With a boyfriend like yours, I have no fuckin' idea where you've been."

She tore it open and started to roll it on with her hands when he stopped her. "Do it with your mouth."

Amanda didn't balk, and her grin was devilish. She looked one last time at me as she lifted the condom to her lips and bit the nipple at one end. Holding it hands-free in her mouth, she dipped back down into Sammy's lap and slowly rolled the latex down his shaft.

"Now *this* is the sign of a true pro," he said to me. "You better get driving, though, before someone honks at us."

Finished with the condom, Amanda said, "Do you want to watch me fuck this guy's big fucking dick?"

"Get the fuck up here," Sammy said. "He wants it, I can tell. Don't waste your words."

I nodded to her anyway, watching as she slipped out of her panties and crawled into Sammy's lap, facing forward—facing me.

We were at a light when she positioned his cock against her smoothly shaven mound. Her hand looked so small, gripping him, and when she started to sink over him, I gunned the engine. The two groaned as the momentum drove him all the way into her.

"This fucker knows what's what!" Sammy crooned as he started fucking her. He pulled her dress down, baring her breasts and erect nipples. "Look at these titties, man. Watch as they bounce as I fuck the shit out of her."

I did watch. I couldn't stop myself from watching. It wasn't tender or sweet. It was a hard fuck in the backseat. Amanda squeezed her eyes shut as an orgasm rolled through her. She leaned forward, gripping the headrests of the seats to stabilize herself as she churned her hips against Sammy's like the stripper that she'd been. Secretly, she played her fingers along the back of my neck, under my fake wig of hair. She was still Amanda, despite this, and we were still together.

"Fuck! Fuck! Your dick is so so fucking big, Baby!"

"For a cuck drug-dealer's bitch, you're so fuckin' tight!" He fucked her harder. "I love this shit."

We arrived at the destination—an upscale coffee shop named Perk. It was the kind of place that sold pour-over coffees that made Starbucks seem like a bargain. I wondered if I'd gotten the address wrong when Sammy said, "Pull around to the back. Quieter back there."

The two were still fucking. I did as I was told, navigating to the back alley of the stripmall. Much less glamorous back here. Such was life. I found the door labeled Perk and idled the car as the two in the back neared their finish. Now I was free to watch openly.

Seeing me turned all the way around, Sammy pulled Amanda against him to give me a full and unadulterated view of her bucking body. Her tiny dress was no more than a wide belt, pushed up around her waist and down beneath her tits. Sammy's dick drove like a dark spike into her smooth slit, stretching her as she bounced again and again on it. Nearing the end, she reached down and started rubbing her clit as Sammy kneaded her tits and pinched her nipples.

"Ngh!" she cried. "Oh, fuck me!"

"You got it, baby."

"I'm so haaa so fuuuuuck!"

She wasn't faking it. This was a real orgasm, given to her by a real man, and I was there to watch it first hand. I couldn't resist touching my own dick, rubbing myself through my pants as she arched back, shoving her tits to the ceiling, and screamed out her orgasm.

Sammy joined her, holding her by the hips and ramming his dick home. "Oh, hell yeah!" he grunted. "Hell, fuckin' yeah. Ride it, baby. Ride my dick!"

It ended abruptly. This was all business for Sammy, and he practically shoved her off of him. Plucking the condom off, he dumped it on the floor of the Navigator and stuffed his softening dick into his pants. "You need to leave your old man. Come on back to the crib and see if we can do a whole lot more. I can even make sure Deion's around."

Amanda fixed her dress. "Tempting, but I'm spoken for."

"For now," he said without explanation. "Come on, let's get you that stash. It's inside."

Amanda looked at me before slipping out to follow him. "Stay here. I'll be right back." And then, because Sammy was out of sight, she mouthed, *'I love you.'*

I watched them go through the back door of Perk, where there was both a security code *and* a key card for entry—more security than your typical coffee shop.

I toggled over to Ty's line. "Okay, we're here. They're they're going inside."

"Everything okay?" he asked. I heard the concern.

That wasn't an easy question to answer. Everything was and everything wasn't, much like before. Only this time, I could shut my eyes and remember the way she'd touched my neck in secret. She wasn't doing this on her own anymore.

"Yeah, everything's okay," I said.

Inside, I could hear Amanda and Sammy through her hidden mic again.

"You're hiding your coke in a place called Perk?" Amanda giggled.

I heard them start kissing again.

"Please tell me," she said between kisses, *"you make a special frapp  and sprinkle this stuff in it."*

Sammy chuckled. *"I'm sure it would be a hit with all the uppity LA moms, but no. We just stash it here. Employees have no fucking clue. Neither do the cops."*

Until now, I thought.

"Here's enough blow for you and your man to find oblivion," he said. *"And here's my number. Call me when when things change with your man."*

"Sounds ominous." Amanda did a good job sounding impressed with a hint of ditziness.

"Don't worry your pretty little head," Sammy said. *"As for the muscle, we gonna have to decline that one for now. Landscape's changed. We're entertaining other offers."*

Other offers? I wanted to ask it, and I know Amanda did, too, but she knew her role.

"Too bad. I was looking forward to working " I heard her kiss him. *"...closer "* Another smack. *"...with you."* This time, a groan from Sammy, and a giggle from Amanda. *"Bye now."*

Amanda emerged a moment later, a spring in her step that she took all the way to the car. Slipping in, she put a hand on my shoulder, her grip urgent. "Drive somewhere secluded. I need to fuck you right now."

"Going dark for a bit," I told Ty. "We'll regroup back at your place."

My friend chuckled. *"You don't have to cut off the mics. I don't mind listen—"*

I switched things off. "Okay," I said to Amanda as she crawled into the front seat. "Let's go."

NUMBER SEVEN

“You should leave the wig on,” Amanda giggled as I drove somewhere—anywhere—secluded enough for me to reclaim her. “It’s pretty damn sexy.”

I flipped my long, rock-and-roll hair like a model frolicking in the sun. “You think I should grow mine out?”

Amanda laughed at the gesture. “Maybe,” she said. “Keep it on for now and we can try it out.” Her hand strayed down between my legs, and she traced my cock.

“But what would the partners at the law firm say?”

“Do you really care about those douchebags? Didn’t they tell you that you *had* to bring a client to a *strip club*?”

“Okay, that’s—FAIR! What are you doing?”

Amanda unzipped my pants and pulled my cock out, even as I continued to drive. Lowering her head into my lap, she smiled up at me. “Encouraging you to find us a secluded place.”

I swerved the whole SUV as Amanda wrapped her lips around my cock, scanning the upscale neighborhood for somewhere—anywhere—to park us. I spotted an actual park which wasn’t terribly secluded, but at this time of night, it would have to do.

Amanda had done this before. I remembered watching Nikolai Kozlov’s car come careening into his own driveway, and how when he’d gotten out of the car, he was zipping up his pants. That memory only added fuel to my passion.

I parked at an off angle, shut off the car, and rolled the seat back as far as it could go. Amanda slurped free of my dick and crawled into my lap, wedging herself between me and the steering wheel. Lifting the snake print dress up, she guided my cock right into her wet pussy.

“Fuck,” she hissed. “This is yes this is what I need.”

“Sammy 9Pole didn’t give it to you hard enough?” I challenged as I ran my palms over her. Her body felt like fire beneath my hands, even through the thin dress.

"He was the foreplay," she said. "This is the main event." She brushed my fake wig-hair over my ears and kissed me hard. "I've actually never been with a man with long hair."

A month ago, I wouldn't have known how to process that. It would have been so out of character for Amanda. Now, my mind was leaping forward, wondering if we could make it happen. Her undulating body, though, made it all too hard to focus. Especially not when Amanda pulled down the front of her dress, freeing her full tits. Her nipples were swollen and too tempting to resist. I leaned forward and wrapped my lips around them, enjoying the gasp and squeal from my wife.

"So you weren't tempted for round two in the backroom?" I asked.

Amanda didn't answer immediately, continuing to bounce in my lap, and I thought that maybe she hadn't heard. Then, opening her eyes to find me staring up at her, she said, "Oh, I was tempted. But if I'd stayed, it wouldn't have been a quickie."

I shuddered at that thought, despite myself. There was something intimidatingly erotic at how matter-of-fact she was about it. She felt it, too, and started fucking me faster. She ran her fingers up under my jacket, and when that didn't seem to be enough, she pushed them beneath my shirt, nearly ripping off a button.

"God, David, you're so hot," she said as she traced my pecs and braced herself on my shoulders.

I thought of all the time I'd spent at the gym, filling the hours between work and sleep when she was off on assignment. I hadn't noticed it, but I was more fit than I'd ever been in my life. "You like a man with muscles and long hair, huh?"

She ground her hips faster, squeezing my dick with the walls of her pussy, trying to milk the orgasm right out of me. I groaned, getting close. "I like all types," she whispered. "But I guess I do like the fit."

"What's been the best fuck that you've had since this whole thing started?"

She slowed the pace of her fucking as she thought, shifting into a more loving, more nurturing rhythm.

"There are two answers to that question," she said.

"Sammy and Deion?" I probed.

Amanda laughed. "No, but that would have been a clever answer. No, I mean I can think of two fucks that stand out. The first was guy number seven, I guess."

There was no guessing for Amanda. She was meticulous in how she cataloged everything.

I kissed her, running my hands down her body and cupping her fine ass. We'd all but stopped fucking, although I was still hard as steel inside of her.

"This was just after I'd started " She hesitated for only a beat. " hooking up with Nick. We went out to this Russian club that he liked, the Red Lounge. It was a place to be seen, if you know what I mean. Plenty of men with money and power. We had the place surveilled for months, but everyone was very careful there."

"Sure," I said, trying to move this along.

"So I go as Nick's arm candy. He picked the dress out—tight, red, short. You'd like it."

"Mmm, yes please."

"We get there, he buys us a round of vodka, and just after the toast, he leans in and asks me to point out the hottest guy in the club. Of course, I told him it was him, and he laughed, but told me to try again." Lost in her story, Amanda started to ride me again, slow at first, but picking up speed as she got into it. "I look around and spot this young guy by the bar. Tightly cropped hair—like military buzz—five o'clock shadow, fit, but not super muscular."

She ran her fingers once again over my shoulders, feeling my deltoids. "Kind of like you," she said, her eyes dripping with lust.

"You sure you want me to keep the wig on?"

Amanda snorted. "I love you however, baby."

"Okay, so what happens next?"

"Nick told me that he wanted me to fuck the guy, and he wanted to watch it."

She went quiet, recalling the night, eyes closed, but judging by how she started to fuck me faster, it must have been some night. Before I could ask for more details, though, she found her voice again.

"This is going to sound awful, but it was one of the most electric things that I've ever heard. When he ordered me to do that " Amanda didn't even have to explain further. I felt her excitement in her hips, in the way her pussy rippled around my cock, in the bite of her fingers into my shoulders.

"So you did it?" I asked, surprised at how hoarse I sounded.

"Yeah." She fucked me faster, running her hands up my neck, like she was so turned on that she wanted to choke me. "It was easy to take him home and he was cool with another man watching mmm, oh David "

She grabbed me, kissed me hard, gyrating in my lap like the trained stripper that she was.

"And he was that good?" I asked.

"He was good, powerful, knew how to use his cock, but that wasn't what made the fuck the best." Faster she fucked. She was close. I could practically hear her pulse banging away in my ears, a crescendo of eager lust. "It was his eyes it was Nick's eyes on us. The way he was so into it. The way I'd look over and see him watching with this intensity "

She came with a gasp, pushing up off of me for a second before driving down hard. She pressed her hands into the ceiling of the cab and rocked her voluptuous body back, shuddering and moaning.

I saw what she was imagining, if only a glimpse. I'd been in the room when she'd fucked those two guys in front of everyone, and could still remember the intensity of Kozlov's eyes on her. He didn't join in. He didn't even jerk off. He just watched, a true voyeur.

I came with her, my balls emptying all the angst that had been building as I'd watched her with Sammy and listened to this story. That drove her own climax to loftier heights. She pulled me into her lush bosom, and now I really could hear her racing heart.

We came down from our orgasms together, catching our breaths.

"God, just thinking about it is still so intense. It was the first time for something like that. I already knew how much I enjoyed the attention that I got stripping—although the old me was still trying to come to terms with it. But this

was the first time performing like that for another man, and my first real experience with a cuckold, and it was revelatory."

This was revelatory for me, too, helping to explain why she had been so callous with me early on. She was used to this man getting off on that. She'd just assumed that I was like him.

She seemed to see me again, and smiled. Her kiss was sweeter, softer, more loving.

"That was a wild story," I said.

"Too much?"

"Ask me that a month ago, and probably yes? Now, it's all part of who you are, and I want to know all of her." I kissed her. "Also, I'm a little jealous of Nikolai Kozlov."

"You shouldn't be. He may have unlocked that part of me, but you get to have me for the rest of my life. *If* you'll have me."

"How about if I pulled that stunt? Us going to a bar and me telling you to fuck a man?"

"I'd have smacked you," she laughed. "But now now, if it's something you'd like to try " She finished the statement by squeezing her pussy around my now-limp dick. Incredibly, I started to harden again.

Amanda climbed off of me, though, stretching her legs.

"And the other best sex?" I asked as I turned the car back on. "That night at the Living Room?"

"No, silly," she said. "It was when you came to me at the Raven apartment, and we fucked after finally getting the truth out in the open. And if I'm honest with myself, that ultimate reclamation was the most intense sex I've ever had. So much emotion that it hurt."

Hearing those words, I felt like a drowning man breaking the surface of the water. Breathing had never felt so sweet, and everything seemed alive and exhilarating around me. I entwined my fingers in hers, squeezing her hands as I kissed her. I wanted to laugh and cry all at once, and when I pulled away from her, I saw that same emotion on her face.

"God, I love you," I said.

I couldn't wipe the smile from my face the whole drive back to our meeting place. It was still there when we got back together with Ty.

"What are you grinning at?" he started to ask, then waved it off. "Never mind. I think I have a pretty good idea."

If only he knew the half of it.

SOLNTSE

“I don’t like it,” Ty said.

We were back at Ty’s, where we did most of our planning to avoid any unwanted surveillance. “I’ve done what he’s asked,” Amanda said. “And now he wants to see me.”

“It could be a trap,” he said. “Or, I don’t know he could harm you somehow.”

“I’ll have the two of you there on surveillance.”

Ty was adamant. “And what if he moves? What if we can’t follow? No, it’s a bad idea.”

Amanda set her jaw. We both knew her well enough to know when she was digging in. Ty turned to me. “David, you think it’s a bad idea too, right?”

“Probably, but there aren’t many good ones left.” We also both knew that there was no talking her out of something when she set her mind to it.

“See? David gets it,” Amanda said.

“But you can’t go alone,” I added before she could run with it. “He’s too erratic, and Ty’s right. What if he moves locations? What if we can’t tail you?”

“I can take care of myself.”

“I know, honey, but it’s okay to get help, too. I know Julia’s not always been there to have your back, but we aren’t Julia.”

Ty gave me an appreciative nod as he watched me navigate Amanda’s stubbornness in a way that he couldn’t. “I’ll go,” he offered. “I can be your bodyguard. Maybe a bouncer from a previous club.”

It made sense. Ty had the experience and the training. Ty also had the alpha male cockiness to pull off that story. But I was tired of being the man that things happen *to*. Kozlov may love being the voyeur, but *I* was over being sidelined. My heart started to race before I even realized what I was going to say.

“No, I’ll go.” Amanda turned to me, lifting a brow at my offer, even as a smile tugged at her lips. “I *have* to go.”

Ty frowned as he looked between the two of us, hands on his hips. “Now this,” he declared, “I *really* don’t like.”

"Should I get the wig out again?" I asked Amanda, ignoring Ty entirely.

Amanda's smile broadened. "Actually, I was thinking we cut it all the way down."

"Like a military buzz? Never done that, either."

Amanda was already touching my thick, dark hair. "Yeah, I think it could be really sexy." Her fingers drifted down to my cheek, where I hadn't shaved in a couple of days. "Leave this, though. Goes with the backstory."

She leaned in and kissed me.

Ty said, "You know he's more of a liability right?"

"That's one way to look at it," she said, her eyes never leaving mine. "Or his presence is exactly what I need." At last, she looked at Ty. "This makes sense. This is how it needs to be."

Ty looked between us, ready to continue to object, then shrugged. "Fine. But let the record show that I object."

"Noted. Now," she turned to me, "let's transform you one more time."

"OKAY, HERE GOES." Amanda squeezed my knee before she slipped out of the car. I followed right behind her, taking in my surroundings the way a bodyguard would.

Amanda really could use a bodyguard in a place like this. A weathered sign on the edge of the L-shaped parking lot read, "Del Ray's Motor Lodge," just above another that advertised, "Cash accepted." The two-story motel looked like the kind of place that didn't ask questions. Unfortunate, since we had so many.

Amanda looked the part of a drug-dealing mobster's stripper girlfriend. She wore a tiny pair of cheerleader shorts, tall red high heels, and a tight, red half-shirt that left her stomach bare and clung to her large tits. As she ascended the outdoor stairs to the second landing, I couldn't help checking out her ass in those shorts—gray with white piping and so short that her ass cheeks hung out of the bottoms.

If things went south, I reminded myself, or if I felt uncomfortable, I could use the safeword—"Columbia". Ty, who was listening in on us through the wire that was hidden in Amanda's purse, would rush in. Amanda would spring into action.

But that wasn't going to be necessary, I told myself. This was all going to be fine, just perfectly fine.

I had some kind of pistol, a sleek semi-automatic—with the serial numbers filed off and the handle tightly wrapped in masking tape—and which of course I'd never fired before—one of Ty's back-up pieces that he'd given to me to further my disguise as a bodyguard. It wasn't lost on me, though, that I would be the one needing guarding here. I was a prop.

We moved up to the door of the room that Nikolai Kozlov had told Amanda he was hiding out in. I glanced up and down the rows of windows as she knocked. All of the rooms had their curtains drawn against the high, California sun.

No one answered, and Amanda glanced over at me, her expression masked behind a pair of large, dark sunglasses. Still, I knew the signs—the way she tapped her heeled foot on the concrete landing, the way she rocked her head from side to side like she was listening to music that wasn't there. She was nervous.

Ty was right. We didn't know what waited behind this door. We didn't know if this was a trap. We didn't know if Amanda's cover was blown. All we knew was that the man was still at-large, his network smashed, allies run to ground or also in hiding, and he needed help.

"Nick?" she called, leaning close to the door. "Nicky, you there?"

She knocked again. No one answered.

I swallowed, getting more nervous. I looked around again, searching the storefronts on the other side of the street. There was a coin op laundromat, a shuttered body shop, and a Dollar General. It wasn't a neighborhood that we came to often. I'm not sure what I expected to find—a sniper on the rooftop, a gang of angry Russians pouring out of one of those doors? Instead, I saw nothing but the ripple of heat rising off the broken asphalt of the street.

Amanda kept her composure, turning her back to the door and looking at me. She pulled out her phone and narrated-as-she-typed. "Okay, if you're not going to answer the door, I'll just text you."

The monologue was mostly for Ty, but I appreciated it, too. I was freaking out inside and doing everything I could to hold it in.

Amanda knocked at the door one more time, shrugged, and said to me, "Guess he's not home."

I nodded, and she went over to the railing that looked out over the cracked parking lot. With her phone out, leaning over the railing, she thumbed away at her phone—pretending to call an Uber, when really she was texting Ty. A moment later, he arrived in a fake, black rideshare car.

We started for the stairs. A part of me was relieved that this hadn't worked out. Between girding myself for the explosive reunion of these two and worrying about fucking the whole operation up, I was a basketcase. I started to relax as each curtained window passed by.

Before we reached the stairs, though, *another* door, separate from the one that she'd been knocking at, opened. Someone stepped out, grabbed me by the arm, and wrenched me inside. Pain screamed through my shoulder as I was flung into the dark room.

"What the—?" I grunted as I felt something cold and hard press against the back of my head.

"Nicky, no! He's a friend!" screamed Amanda.

"I do not know this man," came the cold, accented voice of Nikolai Kozlov.

In the very back of my head, I thought, *Okay, that's good, at least he doesn't recognize me.* The rest of my mind was screaming, *OH FUCK OH FUCK!*

Amanda shut the door behind her, going to his side. "Honey, baby, it's okay. I brought him because I was worried. He's—"

"Armed," Nikolai said, pulling my gun from its shoulder holster.

"He's my protection," Amanda said, speaking to him the way an animal trainer speaks to an angry dog. "Trust me, baby. You trust me, right?"

Mercifully, I felt him lower the gun. I didn't stop tensing though.

"You can lower your arms, Dave," Amanda said. I hadn't even realized that I had them in the air on either side of me. "And Nicky, what happened to your beautiful hair, baby?"

I began to turn. Slowly, tentatively, still ready to feel a bullet in my skull. I needn't have worried. Amanda had his full attention now, running her hands over his cleanly shaven head and smooth cheeks. Despite the darkness, he was wearing sunglasses, and she pulled them up so that she could look him in the eyes.

"I had to cut it off," he said. "I was too recognizable."

"I don't hate the look," she said, pulling him close. When they kissed, I felt the now very familiar mixture of angst and excitement. "It's kind of sexy."

He nodded, going back to the motel room's door and latching the chains. He pulled the curtains aside to scan the parking lot before nodding in satisfaction. "You come alone, yes?"

"Just the two of us," Amanda said.

Kozlov nodded. Now that I was mostly over freaking out, I could really take in the scene. It wasn't good. Kozlov's eyes were sunken. He wore a white button down that looked slept in, and was barefooted in his slacks.

"Did you bring it?" he asked, licking his lips.

"As requested," Amanda said, reaching into her purse. She retrieved the large baggy of white powder and passed it over to him. "This came at a cost."

"Of course it did," he said, opening the bag to dip a fingernail in. He huffed a small pile off of his fingertip, let his head loll backward, eyes closed, and sighed. "I bet you enjoyed paying it, too, yes?"

"You know me so well, baby."

After another snort, he seemed to relax more, falling back into the controlled persona that I'd watched in the clubs. "You are divine, my *solntse*," he said, pulling her close and kissing her again. I stood there, uncertain what to do, shifting from foot to foot and trying my best not to touch my tightening pants.

"Did I go to the wrong room?" she asked. "Oh, shit, speaking of, I need to cancel my Uber."

"Let him wait. Fuck him," Nikolai Kozlov said.

"You'd like me to do that, wouldn't you?"

Kozlov chuckled. "I have missed you."

"What's going on, baby?" Amanda said. "You gonna tell me?"

Kozlov looked at me warily. Amanda headed off the conversation by floating over to me. "This is Dave. You can trust him, baby," she said, running a hand along my shoulder. There was no missing the twinge of aroused jealousy that tightened in Kozlov's face. I recognized it, because I'd just felt it myself. "He used to work the front door at the Spearmint Rhino."

"And why is he here?"

It was a good question. Amanda had her response ready to go. "You said you needed muscle, and Dave's got plenty of those." She squeezed my bicep and batted her lashes at me.

Kozlov looked skeptical. "I need Sammy 9Pole and his crew, not a man who can be disarmed by my *babushka*."

"But Dave has other skills," she said, sidling closer to me. Kozlov licked his lips, just as much addicted to being cuckolded as he was to the coke. "And he can

look quite intimidating, don't you think?" She trailed her hand up my chest and across my scruffy cheek. "Besides, Sammy said that things had changed, and that he was exploring other offers. What's he mean, honey?"

Kozlov spat something in Russian. I didn't need to speak the language to recognize a string of curse words. "It means Chechen *kozy* get to him." And even with my limited Russian, I recognized the word for "goats": prison slang for a combination of "asshole/motherfucker." The things you pick up working as a contract lawyer in L.A. these days.

Kozlov plopped down into a chair, dipped two fingers into his baggie again, and this time began to use them to scrub his gums, as if they were a makeshift toothbrush, and the coke on them was Crest. After another long sigh, he reclined and stared at the ceiling in thought. While his mind was elsewhere, Amanda slipped the AirTag into my hand and went to him. "We'll get through this, honey. What can I do to help you? I can deliver a message to someone."

She slipped into his lap, blocking his line of sight to me. With my hands shaking, I looked around, found his duffle bag, and slipped the small tracker into a side pocket. It wasn't sophisticated, but it was the best we could do with the resources and time that we had.

He tapped some coke out onto the back of his hand and offered it to Amanda. She shook her head. "I may have sampled some before meeting up with you."

"Naughty girl," he said before sniffing it up. "I have lost my people," he lamented with a sigh.. "But I have not lost my power. They will pay. This is not the first time I have had to fight." He sounded a lot more alive now, pumped up. "And look at you, my *solntse*, my sunshine, bringing me my manna from heaven."

Amanda giggled. "Poor Nicky. Have you been hiding in this shithole, all alone, and totally sober?"

"It has been a nightmare," he chuckled. "But now, I think that will change. You will help me change it."

"What can I do?"

"We need to be careful," he said. "It is not safe here. Your government wants me dead. They nearly got their wish when they came to arrest me."

"What?"

"They just opened up. No warning. And it was one of my own dancers, too! That *suka* Misty. She was playing me. I do not know who else was." Misty, or Agent Mia Moore, although even I knew it was weird that they'd send her to pick up Kozlov.

"Misty was 5-0?" Amanda sounded so convincing.

"Or something. Maybe FBI? DEA? I do not know."

"And she tried to kill you?"

"Her partner did. Not very professional, but Nikolai is strong. I have many lives."

Amanda couldn't resist glancing at me at this revelation. That did address one outstanding question: Kozlov definitely wasn't working with a mole inside of the FBI.

"You know you can trust me, right?" Amanda said.

"You are all that I have left."

"So what can I do to help?" Amanda kissed him gently. "We should bail, right? You must have contacts outside of LA."

"I do, yes. But first, I want payback." He squeezed the bag of cocaine. "No one betrays Nikolai Kozlov and lives."

"You're going to need more help than an out-of-work stripper and an ex-bouncer." I could see the hunger in Amanda's eyes, and silently cautioned her not to lead him too strongly. She was practically licking her lips as she suggested, "Maybe these contacts can help?"

"Oh yes, my sweet. They will, they will." If he still had his beard, he'd be stroking it, his eyes far off as he imagined his revenge. Instead, he poured some more coke out onto his hand and ratcheted his high up even more. When he refocused on Amanda, his eyes were wild with fire. "And you will help me, my *solntse*." He kissed her neck. "But first, we fuck."

"UHH! UHH!" Amanda's moans gathered steam. I could hear the creaking springs of the cheap motel mattress as Kozlov drove into her. It wasn't a large room. There wasn't a separate bedroom for them to get privacy in, so I made due by standing close to the curtains near the front, peeking out, feeling the LA heat radiate through them as I listened to my wife fuck another man.

I thought that I was prepared for this moment. It wasn't the first time that I'd watched her take another cock, and this was far from the most extreme of scenarios. But this was Nikolai Kozlov, a man that she still referred to as "Nick" and who'd ostensibly been her boyfriend while she was apart from me.

The kissing had been the hardest thing to listen to, deep and intimate and voracious. I now knew what reclamation sex felt like, and what was going on behind me was definitely that.

"Fuck, fuck!" Kozlov started to groan. It took me a moment to realize that he was frustrated, not aroused. I turned to look, worried that he was about to get violent. "This fucking coke," he barked.

He was only semi-erect as he rolled off of her. "It's okay, baby," Amanda reassured, wrapping her hand around his dick. "Just relax. You've had a hard week."

Kozlov saw me looking, and terror rolled through me. He wasn't the kind of man who liked to show weakness, and ED was the ultimate failing for a man like this.

But that wasn't why he was looking at me. Staring right at me, but addressing Amanda, he said. "I do not want you to suck my cock. I want you to suck *his*."

Amanda swung her attention to me, her eyes sparkling at the offer. "Oh, I don't know. Won't you get jealous?"

"Yes. That is the point. Now suck him."

Amanda hopped off of the bed, tits bouncing, nude body rising before me. If she wasn't my wife, I would have been intimidated enough to flee. Even still, my

heart rate kicked up as I took her in—tits, hips, shaved pussy, tanning bed complexion.

"I seem to recall Dave had a nice dick," she said, dropping to her knees in front of me.

"You have history," Kozlov stated.

Amanda unzipped my trousers. I was so hard. She looked up at me with laughing eyes. "Oh yes, we have a little history." She wrapped a hand around my cock, stroking it slowly, maintaining that epic eye contact. "You know how much I love strong men with big cocks."

I wasn't sure if that was directed at me or Kozlov. It didn't matter. A moment later, her lips were wrapped around me and it was all I could do not to blast down her throat. I'd had many blowjobs over the years from Amanda—more recently than usual—but this one topped them all. It was like being cuckolded by myself—I was not me, but I was also definitely me. It helped that Amanda sucked my dick like Raven, taking me deep, gagging on me as she stroked my cockhead with her throat muscles. This was a live version of her blowjob video.

"Yes," Kozlov encouraged. "Yes, this is it. This is what I need."

The sloppier the blowjob, the harder Kozlov got. I looked up, seeing him beating off, his dick once again hard. To my surprise, despite his larger-than-life presence, I was actually bigger than the man. I felt a surge of something that I hadn't felt in a long time—confidence. I became someone else, I became the kind of guy who got blowjobs from hot women in front of other men.

I grabbed Amanda's head with both hands and started to use her. Her eyes widened, but she didn't pull back or complain. If anything, she redoubled her efforts, even as I began to pump her head.

"Yes, yes," Kozlov said. "Use her. She loves it. She loves getting skull-fucked. Trust. Trust."

My fist tightened in her dark hair—something that I'd *never* done before. I thrust forward until my pubes touched her lips and she choked. First instinct was to apologize. Second was to double down on the aggressive face fuck. I thought of all the men she'd been with while she was away, and how easily she'd slipped into that role. Apparently I was capable of the same.

Ungh, ungh, ungh, she gagged as I used her. She never looked away or closed her eyes, even as they watered, mascara tracking dark streaks down her cheeks.

"Is that true?" I asked, yanking her back by the hair. It was like someone else was speaking through me. "You like a rough BJ?"

"I like a rough *everything*," she said without missing a beat.

I pulled her to her feet and turned her around, pushing her over to the bed. Kozlov was there, shifting back, making room as she crawled on. "Someone can't wait to see me get fucked," she said as she wrapped her hand around Kozlov's dick. Over her shoulder, to me, "Condoms in my purse."

It was an odd thing to wear a condom when fucking my wife. We'd talked about it before coming here and knew that this was a possibility. Even still, as I rolled the latex onto my dick, it was kind of like putting on yet another mask.

A burst of adrenaline raced through me as I shucked off my clothes, watching as my wife sucked the Russian off. And it hit me: the realization that *I* was the one in control here.

Kozlov may have been the man with the criminal background, but I had the power now. Nothing flexed that power more than when I unshouldered my pistol rig and tossed it onto the chair before peeling my shirt off.

I'd never considered myself a gym rat or a stud. I wasn't a bro. I was a bookish nerd. But there was no doubt that I was in good shape now, and when Kozlov looked at me, he didn't see the lawyer with a specialization in government contracts, but a man who could plausibly work as a bouncer.

Taking that energy, I moved into place behind Amanda, who was still on all fours, lined my dick up, and rammed forward.

"Oh, yes!" Amanda cried as her face squished up against Kozlov's belly, his dick popping free of her mouth. "He feels so big!"

"Just the way you like it," I shocked myself by saying. Then, I shocked myself again by spanking her. She hissed with excitement. "Don't you?"

"I've always loved your cock, baby."

"Don't leave your man hanging," I said, staring as her raven tattoo danced. "Start sucking him, Ray."

Amanda's pussy tightened around my cock as she gasped and obeyed. Such a bad girl. Such a slut. I spanked her again, this time leaving a red mark on her right ass cheek. I fucked her like I was trying to drive Kozlov's dick through her neck, and like a thoroughbred whore, she took it all.

Kozlov was the first of us to yield, blasting his come down Amanda's throat. I didn't relent, didn't let up even as she choked and swallowed down the man's come. Before she was fully recovered, I yanked out of her, flipped her onto her back, and mounted her as Kozlov watched, prostrate and spent.

He wanted to see Amanda get fucked? I could do that.

Amanda watched, delighted, as I opened up her legs, sinking her teeth into her bottom lip as she nodded at me. Raven and Dave fell away. We were Amanda and David again, partners, lovers, and now performers.

"Yes, give me that dick," my wife sighed as I pushed back into her. I leaned forward, needing to feel the contact of her tits and torso against my chest. She welcomed my touch, clawing at my back as I drove into her again and again. She hissed, her moans loud in my ear. "Fuck me," she cried. "Fuck, you feel so fucking good."

My abs and thighs burned as I fucked her, but I wasn't going to stop or relent. I could feel Kozlov's eyes boring into us, his jealousy as obvious and oppressive as an open furnace. *After you cum while watching, that's when the insecurities come rushing back.* The thought, Kozlov's palpable angst and jealousy, all of it, only spurred me on, driving me to go harder and longer. Amanda's orgasms were real. The way she twisted and writhed beneath me was authentic. He knew it, and deep down, he knew that he couldn't do this for her.

It was a risk. A random bouncer from her past shouldn't have this much chemistry with her, but fuck all that. I couldn't help myself. *We* couldn't help ourselves.

"Ngh! AH!"

I started kissing her as we neared the end of our torrid run. She kissed me back, desperate and wet. We maintained as long as we could, right up until the moment where I pressed forward and started pumping my balls into that condom.

Amanda felt it, breaking the kiss to rock her head back and come like a volcano going off.

When it was over, the world around us returned—the dingy motel room, the drawn curtains, a wanted criminal staring at us hard. For the first time he looked at me with murder in his eyes, as if seeing me as an actual threat. My heart jumped as I realized just how far we'd pushed things.

Amanda defused the situation with a smile. "Told you he was a good bodyguard, Nicky, and a good partner to have. Now, how can we help?"

"There are some things that I need you to take care of for me," he said to Amanda. "And while you do, leave him with me."

TRUST AND ILLUSION

There were moments in my life when I knew that I shouldn't do something, did it anyway, and got away with it. Asking Amanda out back in law school, for example. Going to the Gold Club for a second time, for sure. I'd done these things despite everything in my body telling me not to, and was rewarded for it.

As I was left alone with Kozlov, watching as he sent my wife away to run errands for him, I began to wonder if maybe this wasn't one of those times. I'd been brave. I'd stepped up to take on this role. I was still electrified from the wild sex we'd just had. But now I was in the room with a coked-up killer. Not a great feeling.

"Ray is correct," Kozlov said as he eyed me. "At least you *look* tough."

It's funny, but that's not something anyone has ever said about me before. Ever.

Kozlov rubbed his nose, shaking his head out like a wet dog shaking off water, before adding, "And I know that if you do anything weird, I can just kill you."

I did my best not to fumble or yelp as I got dressed, strapping the shoulder holster back on. How did a man make that threat as if he was talking about the weather?

"You can use that, yes?" he asked, nodding towards the gun.

I gave him a flat stare, meant to say, *Of fucking course I can*. Seemed easier than lying and risk having my voice crack like a teenager's.

"I do not expect you to use it, but I did not expect to be running for my life right now, either." He chuckled.

"Where are we going?"

Kozlov looked around the dingy interior of the motel. "To stop living like sewer rat. All I needed was a car and a driver, and now here you are."

I watched him pack up his meager life here. It was so small now, fitting entirely inside a single duffle bag, and I might have felt bad for the guy had I not

known better. He also did nothing to ingratiate himself to me, handing me his bag and making me carry it like his manservant.

I lugged it down to the car that we'd brought along, which was actually Amanda's own black Jeep Wrangler. We figured it was a more appropriate vehicle for "Dave" to drive than my Camry, although I also never anticipated having to drive Kozlov *anywhere*.

The Russian seemed a bit put out when he realized that the back seat of the Jeep was very small, and with his duffle taking up most of the back seat, he'd have to ride up front beside me. He slipped on a pair of sunglasses and slammed the door shut beside me.

"Where to, boss?" I asked.

He gave me the address without looking at me, his eyes seeming to scan the blank motel windows. "I cannot believe I lived here for so long. What a shithole."

I didn't respond. He didn't seem like the kind of guy who enjoyed smalltalk. So instead, I plugged the address the Russian had given me into my phone's GPS and started to drive. Ty must've been somewhere behind us, although he had plenty of experience on tail jobs and it showed, because I never saw him. I clung to that lifeline, real or not, and drove.

I thought that we'd spend the whole ride in silence. I was good with that. The less we talked, the less likely he was to figure out what a fraud I was. My biggest fear was that he'd ask *anything* about my personal life or my job at the strip club that I could no longer name, or any of it. That welcome initial silence lasted all of the first ten minutes.

The snarled traffic on I-5 must have gotten to him, because he finally spoke. "Do you know what is important in my world?" He still wasn't looking at me, instead staring out the window at all the other drivers in their cars. "Having a solid understanding of the people I surround myself with. Everything else flows out of that understanding—who to trust, who to watch carefully, how far I can push someone before they break."

This didn't sound like a good line of conversation for me. This sounded like one that ended with him turning to me and saying, "*And I now know who you are, David, husband of Amanda.*" I kept my mouth shut and tried my best to keep my pulse slow and even. I was glad he wasn't seated right behind me, though. That would have felt even more menacing.

"I thought I knew those around me. I thought I knew my friends. I was a victim of my own hubris." He grumbled something in Russian. "In truth, trust is an illusion. It is only good as long as everyone believes it. The key is to not be the last to believe, yes?"

I didn't respond beyond a nod. Not that it mattered. Kozlov was too wrapped up in his own grievances to even see me.

"I will not make that mistake again." He had his baggie of coke out, and took a long, loud bump before continuing. The man had a real problem. "You know what I mean. You must anticipate the problem before it becomes real trouble. You must anticipate it before you even let them into the front door."

Right. I was a bouncer, better act the part. "And when they become a problem," I ventured to say, "they leave violently out the same front door."

My heart was in my throat as I played up my role. How the hell did Amanda do this every day?

"Yes! Yes, you get it. They will all leave. Violently."

I didn't like the way he chuckled.

I wondered where we were going as the GPS led us into a nondescript stripmall in Garden Grove—the kind of urban sprawl that was invented in LA, and as a result blanketed the city. Specifically, we pulled up to a FedEx store. I gave Kozlov a questioning look as he reached into the back, unzipped his duffel bag and retrieved a package.

"Go in there and give this to Yuri. No one else. If he is not there, bring it back. Understood?"

"Yuri. Yes." I took the package from him. It was surprisingly light. "It's not a bomb or something, is it?"

Probably not a good question to ask a coked up crime boss, but I also didn't want to be an accomplice to terrorism. Kozlov's laugh had an edge to it, but nothing more. He rubbed his nose and shook his head. "Yuri," he repeated. "No one else."

I sighed and got out of the car, pushing into the narrow shipping store. There was only one man, a younger guy with a ponytail and glasses, serving an elderly woman. He greeted me, then went right back to helping the woman. I got close enough to read his name tag. This was the guy.

I examined the package while I waited. Something about the address didn't add up. At first glance, it looked legitimate—a business address in Phoenix, some place called CrimsonLeaf Solutions. It was the care-of that made me reconsider. A single word in Cyrillic script—which I assumed was Russian. I couldn't even read, let alone pronounce it. I wanted to take a photo of it, but by that time Yuri was done with the woman and turned to me.

"Can I help you?" His Russian accent was nearly imperceptible.

"Yes. A friend asked me to drop this off to you."

I watched Yuri closely as I handed him the package, and there it was—the widening of the eyes, the quick intake of breath. He adjusted his glasses and nodded. "One moment," he said, going into the back.

It was all I could do to keep from bolting. I half-expected him to return, guns blazing. Or maybe not return at all. But when he did, he was the same nervous attendant as before. The package was gone, but in his hand was a key.

"Here you are, sir. And tell tell our friend that I will take care of the package right away."

I grinned with a confidence that I didn't feel. My hand didn't even shake as I took the key. "Do that. He will be pleased to hear it."

"Right." His smile was forced. He was afraid.

I knocked on the counter, turned, and left.

Getting back into the Jeep, I turned to Kozlov. "Done. He gave me this." I handed him the key.

"Very good. Very helpful. Now, we go south. Towards Newport Beach. I'm upgrading from Del Ray's Motor Lodge."

He laughed. I drove. I was getting over the fear that I'd be shot in the back, but with Kozlov, I just couldn't be sure. The trip was beautiful, Kozlov directing

me through the affluent neighborhoods of Orange County. We went to the docks, where Kozlov bade me goodbye.

"I need you to do one more favor for me," he said before getting out of the car. "This Saturday, bring Ray back here. We will have the party to end all parties, yes?"

"Sounds fun. Need some extra muscle?"

"Oh, do not worry about that." I didn't love the way he chuckled. "I'm counting on having all the muscle I could possibly desire there in one place, but you would like to come, yes? Sure, why not. I'm feeling generous."

With that, he got out of the car, slung his duffle bag over his shoulder, and walked towards the line of yachts.

"THAT COULDN'T HAVE GONE BETTER, man," Ty said, holding up his pint of beer in celebration.

He had, indeed, been tailing me, and as soon as we'd cleared the immediate neighborhood of the marina, he accelerated up beside me and signaled for me to pull over. We parked along a side street and settled into a dive bar off Newport Boulevard.

"I think I almost crapped my pants three times during that exchange alone," I said.

"But you're not dead, eh? And now we know a lot more than we did before."

I nodded, guzzling half of my own pint before setting it down. Only then did my nerves begin to untangle. "We know that Kozlov's definitely not working with someone inside the FBI," I said. "We know generally where he's hiding out."

"We know precisely," said Ty, "Thanks to that AirTag you planted. Slip number 69. We also know that there's something big planned for Saturday night at the marina."

"Something about Chechens," I added. "I didn't quite follow that. And that stop we made in Garden Grove? That FedEx? His contact in there is a Russian kid named Yuri, who is scared shitless of him."

Ty leaned in. "Mostly, though, Kozlov is a paranoid cokehead who's acting more like a trapped animal than some criminal mastermind."

"So what happens next?" I asked. "Wait to see what happens Saturday?"

"Jesus, man, you really are bad at this, aren't you?"

"Misty." It was Amanda who answered, joining us at the table. Gone was the stripper girlfriend attire. She'd changed into a long sundress that looked a lot more at home here in Orange County. "Agent Mia Moore is the key to unlocking the final piece of this puzzle."

Ty nodded, like it was obvious. When I didn't follow, he explained. "While Kozlov isn't working with the FBI, that doesn't mean that they're all above board. There's some sort of rogue element behind this operation. Could be one person. Could be a whole faction. They tried to assassinate him rather than arrest him. My guess is that someone in the L.A. field office is aligned with the Chechens."

Amanda nodded.

"And Agent Mia Moore " He paused, looked at Amanda and wagged his eyebrows. "Really?"

Amanda shrugged. "I mean, that's her name."

Ty laughed. "Okay, so anyway, Agent Moore didn't seem on board with the murder attempt, which means one of two things: either she isn't part of this conspiracy, or she is, but isn't totally happy with it."

"Either way," Amanda said, squeezing up next to me. "She's who we target next. Hi there, by the way. You did so well." She kissed me softly before picking up my beer. Then she said to Ty, "And I've got some ideas on how to do that."

I savored the kiss as she took a big slug of my beer. "Just what did Kozlov have you up to while I played bellman and chauffeur?"

Amanda sighed. "Would you believe he had me raiding his stashes all over SoCal?"

"Jazz?" Ty asked. "Weed?"

Amanda snorted. "Worse. Cash."

"You know, he went on and on about trust and how he couldn't trust anyone anymore while I was driving him down to Newport Beach," I said.

"Guess there's at least *one* person he still trusts," Ty said.

"To go clean out mailboxes in every FedEx from Los Alamitos to Santa Anita," Amanda said drily. "And fuck some lowlife to score him some blow." She made a face.

"That's where he stashes his cash?" Ty said.

"Yep," she held up a ring of at least a dozen mailbox keys. "Mails it to himself and leaves it there until he needs it."

I told her about the Garden Grove FedEx and Yuri, and how fearful Yuri looked when I mentioned Kozlov by name.

"Why wouldn't he just farm that one out to you, as well?" Ty said it as if he already knew the answer.

"I guess there are still some things 'My Nicky' doesn't trust me with, after all."

MISTY

“Guy number one was the hiring manager, and number two was the client you had the threesome with.” Just saying that aloud still sent an anxious thrill through me.

“He was actually number three,” Amanda corrected. We were sitting in the far backseat of Ty’s Chevy Tahoe, parked down the street from a Manhattan Beach establishment known as Giggles, waiting for Ty to make contact with Mia Moore. We knew that she frequented this bar, a known meat market, and when our plan came together, Ty was more than happy to volunteer to serve as the bait. Not surprisingly, he knew the bar, too.

This wasn’t a surveillance thing. We weren’t set up to listen. There were no wires. We were just waiting for Ty to do his thing, and in the dark, it gave Amanda and I the opportunity to revisit some more of the past few months. Even cast in shadow, I could see that Amanda’s face was flushed as we veered back into talk of her twelve hookups. “Number two was a bouncer. Griff.”

I remembered the huge man who’d patted Brandon down and confiscated his jazz. The image of my slender wife with him jumped to mind, along with my erection.

“It kind of just happened. After doing it with Mark, it was easier to fall into that role—”

“Of promiscuous stripper slut.”

“Sure, yeah. After Mark, I realized that I was just free, I guess.” She winced and reached for my hand. “God, I hate how that makes it all sound. I know that I wasn’t really. I had you back home—”

“It’s okay,” I said. And it was. “We’ve gone over this ground now. You got caught up in it.”

“I did, and after Mark, I started looking at all the guys around me as potential. I told myself that I was doing it to catch the eye of the boss, but honestly, I was just curious about a guy like like Griff.”

“I remember him. He was a big guy.”

"In more ways than one," she said, flustered, batting her lashes. My cock throbbed in response. "But that was a one-time thing. And honestly, he was just too big to be that great."

I moved closer to her, slipping my hand between her thighs, which were squeezed shut. "Okay, so we know numbers one through three. Kozlov was?"

"Six. Four and five were other patrons. One I did in the backroom, during a private dance. The other was another threesome. Honestly, neither were all that special."

Funny that she could now say that a threesome wasn't that special. I pushed my hand higher up her thigh. She was wearing an all black catsuit for the occasion, and I could feel her warmth beneath the thin material. "So tell me about one of the special ones."

Amanda's breath caught as I pressed my hand up against her mound. She took a moment to collect her thoughts, her eyes fluttering shut. "Number nine was my first experience with anal sex."

Now it was my turn to catch my breath. "The one that turned you into a believer?"

Amanda's laughter felt like a release valve for both of us. "Yeah, it was almost like a religious experience."

"Did you do it for Kozlov?"

"Everyone and everything I did after I first slept with Nick was *for* Nick."

It was a heart-stopping confession. I shouldn't have been so turned on by it, but we were past the point of denial now. "Go on," I said, pushing my fingers against her sex. "Tell me how you found religion."

"You really do like hearing this." She said it with wonder rather than judgment, shifting closer to me and licking my earlobe. "You like hearing that Nick had started prepping me ahead of time, getting me to wear larger and larger butt plugs?"

"Yes," I murmured. She ran a hand over the crotch of my pants, tracing my dick.

"I got used to the pressure back there, and it was so sexy walking around with that secret nestled between my cheeks, but even sexier because I knew what came next. I just didn't know when."

"When did it happen?" By now my pulse sounded so loud in my own ears that I could barely even hear my own question.

"Nick came over to my apartment with an associate. I never caught his name and I never saw him again, despite trying to dig up who he was. American guy, late 50s, but built like an action figure. Can't quite explain it, but he was hot, and he barely spoke the whole time he was there."

Amanda shivered, her hand slow and steady on my cock as she pressed her hips against my fingertips.

"This wasn't a seduction, unlike the other men. There was very little foreplay. This man, he came in and he he bound me to the bed. My hands were tied up behind my head, and my legs were spread way open and pulled back, tied to the posts. I have never felt so exposed—and this was about six weeks into my job as a stripper."

Two weeks give or take before I turned up at the Gold Club. I eased my hand into her pants as she talked, finding her drenched.

"He shoved a ball gag into my mouth, too, so I couldn't complain. All I could do was stare as this man stripped out of his clothes, folding them neatly on the bed before climbing aboard. Like I said, he was a tall man, lean, yet muscular, like an old panther or something. He made me watch him as he rubbed lube on his dick, just as meticulously as he'd folded his clothes. The fact that he barely spoke to me charged the whole situation. The only thing I remember him saying was when he was over me, his cock pressed against my asshole. He said, 'Nod if this is what you want.' I nodded without hesitation."

"What would have happened if you hadn't?" I asked.

"I have no idea. But in that moment, after all the prep, splayed open like that, I would have begged for it if I wasn't gagged."

"I take it he was good?"

"It was intense. He was pretty big, for one, but also knew how to use it. He edged me so many times, getting me more and more comfortable with a harder fuck. By the time I finally did come, I was covered in sweat, my abs screamed at me, and I swear I nearly passed out. But he wasn't done. He took a break. He and Nick went out into the living room to chat and laugh. They left me tied up, there to wait.

"Then he came back and fucked my ass again, this time a lot harder. And this time, he didn't let me come. He seemed to already have a read on me. The way he matched his thrusts with his fingers on my clit " Amanda shivered. "By the time he left, I felt totally strung out, despite never touching Nick's stash or having a drop to drink. I played with myself for days after that, recalling how that felt."

Amanda blinked, suddenly back in the present, there with me in a car. "So that was number nine."

"You think he's connected to all of this? Or just a random anal sex stud?"

Amanda giggled. "I honestly don't know. Like I said, I went looking as best as I could. I let Julia know about him, but she couldn't find anything."

"Or maybe she didn't want you to know," I offered.

"Maybe."

Both of our phones buzzed at once. Ty had made contact.

Coming out. Be prepared.

Amanda looked at me, and I nodded. "It's show time." Without another word, my special agent wife slipped out of the car and faded into the darkness. In the far back seat of the Tahoe, I crouched down and pulled a blanket over myself. Heat was trapped beneath my shirt, and my ears were still ringing with Amanda's latest confession.

The wait was longer than I'd anticipated, and for a second, I wondered if maybe they weren't coming at all. I almost pushed the blanket off to look when I felt the Tahoe shift. I risked a look anyway, wondering if they were already fighting.

Female laughter pealed through the night, and there, just a few feet away, I saw a woman's back pressed up against the window. "Mmm, big boy," she said playfully. I knew that voice—Mia.

Ty chuckled, kissing her, his hands trapping her against the car. "Some say 'too big,'" Ty said.

"I don't believe that's possible, personally," Mia said. "And I've had some experience."

"Get on in, then, and let's see."

I held my breath as the back passenger side door opened. The smell of booze and Mia's perfume filled the cab. Ty climbed in right after her, shutting the door. "Now, where were we?"

"Right about here," she said, a moment before they started kissing again. Hearing the loud smacks and soft sighs on the heels of Amanda's story was torture. "But honestly," Mia went on. "This is where I'd like to take it." Before things could progress, though, the door on the other side of Mia opened. "What the—?" Mia said before she could react.

"Hey, Misty," Amanda said, pulling the door shut. "Am I interrupting something?"

"Amanda, what's going—"

"Uh, uh, uh," my wife said.

I pulled the blanket off and rose back into the seat behind them, my thighs aching. I was covered in sweat. "We have a few questions to ask you."

"You couldn't have waited a few more minutes?" Ty said. "I was just about to get a blowjob."

"You?!" Mia said, shooting a look at our old friend.

"I'm sorry, it's nothing personal. And everything I said in there was true. Maybe after, you and I could—"

Mia elbowed Ty hard in the chest, so swiftly that we almost lost control of the situation. She was already squirming halfway out of the car when Amanda put her in an arm lock and yanked her back, immobilizing her between herself and Ty in a single practiced move. "We're not going to hurt you," she said, straining. "Just calm down."

Mia seemed to quickly take in the situation and slumped back into the seat. "You're making a mistake, Amanda," Mia said, but the fight was gone. "They will not like this."

Okay, now we were getting somewhere. I slipped out of the back seat of the Tahoe and circled around to the driver's seat, turning it on and pulling us away from the bar. "I'm willing to take that risk," Amanda said. "Let's start with who 'they' is."

"I don't know."

"Come on, Mia," Amanda said. "I'm trying to be nice here."

"Seriously, I don't know! I swear. I just receive orders, and I carry them out."

"What kind of orders?"

"Mostly it's gathering intel. Sending along the whereabouts of our targets. Stuff that I'm already doing for the Bureau anyway." Mia seemed resigned.

"And maybe kill Nikolai Kozlov?"

"Oh, is that what this is about?" Mia said with a gruff laugh. "You really did fall for him, didn't you?"

"Misty's accusation ran through me like a lightning bolt. For her own part Amanda reacted as if slapped. "No," she hissed. "What I take issue with is extra-

judicial actions, especially ones taken against our only connection to a wider drug network."

"Well, I didn't actually know that was going to happen. I was just detailed as part of the arrest team. We went ahead, me and Aguilar. He's the one who started shooting."

"Mike Aguilar?" Amanda said, obviously surprised to hear the name.

Mia nodded.

"Was he provoked?" Amanda asked.

Mia shook her head. "No. He radioed in that the suspect was armed, but as far as I could tell, Kozlov had no clue we were even there. Surprise!" Mia said with forced glee. "Yeah, Aguilar's in on it. They've got dirt on him, too. They've got something on all of us." She glanced at Amanda, looking pitying. "They've got a lot on you now, too, honey. I'm surprised they haven't reached out to you yet."

"What?"

"Not a good look for an FBI agent to have a coke habit. Especially one who works specifically to take those cases down, and they've got plenty of video of you using."

"Working the cover," Amanda said briskly. Her voice was neutral, but knowing her like I did, I thought I heard a note of defensiveness in her reply. Ty probably did, too.

"You could have talked your way out of it. But it doesn't matter. None of it was ever reported to Hirsch or the other higher ups, and it would look really bad for that surveillance video to come to light now."

Amanda sat processing that. Then she said, "Is Julia behind this?"

"She's certainly involved. My guess is that she's just another fly like the rest of us, caught in the web."

Amanda nodded, going back to weighing the options when Mia volunteered something. "Look, it's not so bad. There are perks. We mostly get left alone. We get compensated within reason. Most of what's asked isn't much different than what we're doing anyways—"

"Other than murder," Amanda said. "Acting as an accomplice in drug trafficking, human trafficking, money laundering, and God only knows what else. And all of this working with a network with clear ties to terror cells—bonafide enemies of the state—the very institution that we are sworn to defend." She shook her head. "I'm sorry, Mia. I can't. I just can't."

"You think you'll have a choice?" Mia said. "They will come. And when they do, you'll follow."

My shoulders sagged as I listened to this. She was right. This was much worse than we'd thought. It wasn't just that Misty was involved. We all were now.

Amanda, however, was already thinking ahead. "Maybe." She took a deep breath in through her mouth, held it, and released it slowly. "Okay," she repeated. Then she cocked her head at Misty, and the woman that I knew well and had always loved, said, "I can work with that. So, Mia, want to get your life back?"

CRACKS

“So what’s the deal between you and ‘Nick’?” I deliberately used the more familiar version of the name—the one Amanda herself used most often. I somehow kept my voice level, not easy, because I was too nervous to even really look at my wife.

We’d gone back to our apartment the night before, leaving Mia at Ty’s house for the time being, and were getting ready for the day. I had burned through my vacation time and had half-a-dozen contracts that needed vetting, so it was time for me to show my face back in the office, which seemed absurd, what with the feeling that everything around me was crumbling.

Amanda turned around, leaned against the counter, holding her coffee in both hands. She was still on leave and waiting for her next orders, although her loungewear had gone from yoga pants and loose tops to small athletic shorts and tight t-shirts that hugged her healthy breasts.

She raised a brow at me. “What do you mean, ‘the deal’? There *is* no ‘deal.’”

I wasn’t crazy about having yet another confrontation with my wife. This one had to happen for all kinds of reasons, though, and it had to happen right at that moment. I sighed and rubbed my sweaty palms on my trousers as I sat at the kitchen table.

“No ‘deal’? Really? One: You fucked the guy for weeks.”

“I fucked a *lot* of guys, and we have been clear about that. I thought we had gotten past—”

“Two,” I went on as if she hadn’t spoken, and began to tick the points off on my fingers. “You two *lived together*. Three: the sunburst on your hip, ‘*Solntse*.’”

“I was playing a *role*.”

I could see from her expression that she was struggling to not be defensive. I fought the impulse to just drop it and just try to hug her. I stuck to the script. “Four: your fellow UC Misty herself independently jumped to the conclusion you had ‘fallen for him.’ So even the other agents in your own investigation had this in the back of their minds.”

Amanda set her coffee cup down, wincing. Now it was her turn to avoid eye contact.

"No 'deal'?" I repeated.

She took a deep breath. And then another. And when she looked up and made eye contact, I saw that mix of resolve and vulnerability she had first shown me in Raven's apartment on that day a few weeks back when we had begun the tough work of saving our marriage.

"I've said it before. I was playing a role," she said slowly, deliberately. "And if I weren't convincing, everything we did, all of the planning, logistics, manpower allocation, all the heavy lifting, would have been beside the point."

I bit the inside of my cheek. I wasn't the only one in this relationship who was great at reading the other one's facial expressions. She said, "Thank you for not chiming in with a sex joke."

"Putting it in the bank for later."

She snorted. "This is *serious*!"

"I *said* 'for later.'"

She pursed her lips at me, then said, "Anyway. All of it needed to happen. Otherwise, every line that I crossed, everything that I did, would have meant shit if I couldn't get and hold that skeezy bastard's attention."

"Did you notice that you're still calling him 'Nick', rather than something less intimate, like 'Kozlov' or even 'Nikolai.'"

"I I guess it's just a habit." Her eyes didn't waver as she studied me. I felt naked, pinned down by those bright blue eyes. "Again, I *needed* to play a role with him, and I needed him to believe that I really had feelings for him."

"And maybe, at some point, you started to actually develop feelings?" I offered. Her resolve faltered, and when I saw the hesitation, mine did, too. "It's only human—"

"No," she said abruptly. "I may have learned some things about myself, done things I never thought I'd do, but falling for Nikolai Kozlov is not one of them."

"We're not talking about love, but we are talking about an emotional connection. Some form of Stockholm Syndrome—"

"Is not what's happening here, David."

"He did push you to do things that you've ended up enjoying."

"Yes, but he also made me fuck a VIP patron who must have weighed three hundred and fifty pounds and reeked of a mix of Axe, onions and week-old cheese. And Nick—*Kozlov*—knew that it disgusted me, but told me to convince this man that I wanted him. It was one of the few times that I actually didn't mind ripping a few lines just to get through it. That guy was number ten, by the way, and a stark reminder of who 'Nick' is." This time, she used the familiar name like it tasted bad in her mouth.

"I'm sorry you had to go through that." She looked so vulnerable, something I wasn't used to seeing from her. But I couldn't let it go entirely. "But despite that, there was still a number eleven and twelve. And that only catches us up to when I saw you at your apartment. I'm sure there were more."

"Yes, there were more," Amanda said, her jaw clenching. "And yes, I kept going. And no, they weren't all disgusting experiences. But they weren't all like

jumping into the sack for a threesome with Channing Tatum and Ryan Gosling, either."

We stared mutely at one another, feeling a gulf widening between us—a gulf that we'd slowly been trying to close over the last week. Worry creased in her brow, but she held her chin aloft.

At last, Amanda broke the silence. "After I saw you after I confessed to you everything changed."

"And yet, kind of nothing did at all." It felt good to say it. It felt good to admit outloud. "You were blowing and fucking guys before coming clean to me, and that continued after. Only thing that changed was that you didn't have to hide it."

"Oh, David " Seeing the tears start to well up in her eyes broke me.

I sighed and went to her, wrapping my arms around her. "I'm ready for work now," I whispered, kissing her head.

She nodded, and together we exited the apartment.

In her Wrangler, after some silence, we returned to the conversation, working gingerly around the edges. "So tell me honestly, Amanda. *Do* you have feelings for Nick—"

"Kozlov," she said. "*Kozlov*," she repeated for emphasis.

"But he *is* Nick to you, in a way. What you two have is complicated."

Amanda's fingers tightened on the wheel and she shook her head. "Complicated, yes. But I don't have *feelings* for him. When it comes time, I won't have any problem doing whatever needs to be done to bring him to justice." She glanced at me. Her tears had dried, but the hurt was still there. "Seriously, okay?"

She turned the car on and pulled us out. Things felt awkward, and I didn't love that, despite the heavy conversation. "So, uh, you really had to fuck a 350 pound client?"

Amanda kept her eyes on the road. I could see her working her jaw. "Not everything was fun and games." Then, glancing at me, she added, "And please don't fucking tell me that you've got a fetish for that, too."

"I mean, only if I start putting on the pounds." I patted my stomach, which was now solid from all the hours spent in the gym.

The tense mood broke as Amanda laughed. "If you put on that much weight, then we'll need to have some even more serious 'conversations.'"

I was more than happy to put the weight of the apartment conversation behind us. "It's always about the body with you, isn't it? I thought you loved me for my mind."

Amanda's laughter grew louder. She reached over and squeezed my thigh. "I certainly don't *mind* a nice body."

A text came in on her phone, the notification popping up on the CarPlay, the message from "Aunt Maisie." I looked at her questioningly. "Julia," she says, tapping the message to have the car dictate it outloud. She shows no hesitation.

Club's reopening tonight. Raven is back on. We're almost done here. Just a few days more. Will be in touch tonight after your shift.

We looked at one another. "This change anything?" I asked.

"It shouldn't." I could see her working through the implications of this. "Actually, it could work out in our favor but "

“But?”

“I’ve got a plan ”

I CONTINUED to wrestle with Amanda’s plan during the drive over to Ty’s place. I was still wrestling with it as we walked into Ty’s apartment. I was so lost in the cloud of my thoughts that I didn’t snap out of it until I heard the sounds of sex.

“Uh, uh! Ohhh fuck!” The female moans filtered out of the bedroom, the door of which was only half-closed. Amanda glanced back at me, eyes wide and filled with amusement.

“Fuck, fuck me!”

“Take it!” Ty barked.

“Give it to me, right uh fuck!”

I stood frozen to the spot. Amanda was the one to take me by the hand and guide me along, a finger pressed to her lips for silence.

The sounds of sex started to grow more heated. As we drew closer, I could make out the creak of the bed beneath their shifting weight. Amanda pulled us right up to the door and glanced inside. I couldn’t resist, moving into place behind her.

My breath caught as I looked inside. Mia was on her back, long legs splayed open, her body covered in sweat. In many ways, she looked a lot like Amanda—same dark hair and voluptuous body, hewn and tightened from hours of dancing. I’d seen her nearly naked before, dancing at the club, but I’d never seen the small brush of pubic hair above her pussy, and I’d certainly never seen her quite like this.

Amanda reached behind me, groping for my dick, as she watched, too. Ty had put on a few pounds over the years, but it seemed like most of that weight was muscle. His biceps strained as he held Mia’s legs open and pounded into her. From the door, we had the perfect angle to see him driving deep into her pussy.

Because of the two women’s close resemblance, I could almost imagine it was Ty fucking my wife, which image in turn bubbled up the reminder that they *had* done it. The angst was real. So was my excitement.

Mia cupped her full tits, lifting one to her mouth so she could lick her own nipple. The sight was apparently too much for Ty, who pulled out of her pussy, ripped his condom off, and pumped a massive load all over her stomach.

Amanda squeezed my dick hard, like she was imagining what it was like to be in Mia’s spot. I nearly came myself as I imagined the exact same thing.

For his part Ty was all over Mia, seeming to not care about the come he’d splashed on her body as he crawled over her and started kissing her.

“I see you two have gotten close,” Amanda announced from the door.

Neither of them jumped. Ty broke the kiss and looked over his shoulder as Mia peeked around him. “Did you enjoy the show?” she asked.

They knew we were there?

Amanda didn't answer, instead saying, "I take it this means you've considered our offer?"

"I'm in," Mia said. "Took a little negotiating, though."

Amanda rolled her eyes, but she was smiling the whole time. She retrieved a new burner phone from her purse and handed it to Mia. "Excellent. We've already begun the next phase of the plan. I'm going to take David to work. I'll be in touch on that line. It's got our numbers programmed in—"

"Yes, Amanda, I know the drill." She was caressing Ty's back as she spoke. "If I hear something first, I'll alert you all."

"Speaking of, you got the message about the Gold Club reopening yet?"

Mia shook her head. "I haven't been checking messages this morning." And with that she looked slyly in Ty's direction.

"I guess you'd better check in, then, hmm?"

BACK IN THE Wrangler and on the way to my office, I had to ask. "Do you think that was the start of something or just another meaningless hookup?"

Amanda hazarded a glance away from the road and in my direction. "For Ty, or for Mia?"

"Either?" I shrugged. "Both?"

She thought for a moment. "Well, on the one hand, it's Ty, so, you know. Man-whore."

I laughed.

"And from what I know of Mia, well is 'whore-whore' a thing?"

This time we both laughed.

I said, "Don't look now, but another thing, aside from the obvious, that those two seem to share, is—"

"Some sort of kinky fetish that's gonna gross me, right?"

"I'm not sure that there is such a thing anymore?" I teased.

"Asshole."

I laughed and said, "Believe it or not, each of them is envious."

"Of?"

I pointed back and forth between us. "This."

"Us?"

"Us."

And I quickly recapped my two conversations, first with Ty, wherein he went on about my "stripper wife," and then the one with Mia the night I met her in Julia's SUV, where, upon learning that Amanda's escapades with other men aroused me, also said something about being envious.

"What night was this, again?"

"The night we listened to you blow Kozlov at his house."

She shook her head and suppressed a grin. "Wish I'd known you were listening when that all went down."

"You knew *someone* was listening, right?"

She grinned again. "*Sacculus meus, cimex meus.*"

"Latin? Really?"

"All this Russian is making me dizzy. And how often do I get to trot out my college Latin?"

I snorted. "My purse, my bug," I translated.

"Anyway, so yes, I knew *someone* was listening, and that made it all hot, but had I known it was *you*?" She clenched right hand, then snapped her fingers open, accompanying it with a "POOSH!" sound. "Fireworks, Baby. Fireworks."

I beamed at her. "See? That right there. That's what Mia was saying she envied. What she'd love to have for herself."

Amanda chewed on that for a bit as she drove. At length I asked the other question that had been on my mind. "Do you think we can really trust her?"

She cocked her head to one side and sighed. "I hope so, because we're going to need her help."

"Or we could just run away from all of this. You still have all of Kozlov's cash, right?"

Amanda looked over at me as we pulled up before my work. I read her expression, she didn't need to say it. I nodded. "Yeah, no running away. I wonder why he hasn't contacted you to bring him the cash "

"He actually wants me to drop some off in some park later today. Not for him, but someone else."

"Who?"

"I don't know. Hopefully I will later."

I nodded, pulling out my own burner phone. "Let me know if you find out anything. I'll do the same."

I kissed her goodbye, but before I could slip out, she held me close. "I love you, David. I love you so much. Understand?"

I nodded against the side of her neck, inhaling her scent, holding it in my lungs as if trying to commit it to memory. "I love you, too, Amanda."

BRANDON CRUISE

“Where the fuck have you been, man? And what the fuck happened to your hair?”

I touched my shorn scalp, brushing my palm up the back of my head, still shocked at how soft and light my skin was. “Summer cut.”

In a weird way, it was nice to see Brandon Cruise again. I’d never cared for him. He was, after all, my polar opposite—undeservedly cocky, entitled, crude, the kind of guy who took lunch at strip clubs because of the steak special and then bragged about it with a wink. After the last week, though, the sheer consistency of his douchery felt like exactly what I needed.

“I’ve been on leave. Dealing with some personal shit.” See, that’s the kind of influence Brandon had on me. I’d normally never say something like that, instead ending the sentence with a ‘matters’. Brandon kind of forced the S-bomb, even when not called for.

“Did the ball-and-chain finally ditch you for another man?” He was also completely unempathetic. “And is that why you cut your hair to look like a monk?”

“Not quite. And fuck you, you know that?”

“Sorry, sorry.” He showed me his palms as he sauntered into my office and flopped uninvited into one of my client chairs.. “I just missed you, that’s all. Fucking with you is my way of saying I care.”

“I don’t believe you.” I chuckled.

Brandon shrugged. “I think we make a good team. I bring them in, and you lock them down with paperwork. Turns out, I hate fucking paperwork.”

Shocker. “Well, you may need to get used to it. Truth is, I’m not sure how much longer I’m here.”

“Yeah? No shit. Where are you going?”

I shrugged. “Not sure. Just not LA.”

Brandon leaned further back in his chair, clasping his hands behind his head and staring up at the ceiling. He let out a long “Fuuuuuck.” Then, turning to look

at me, he said, "We should give you a proper send-off, then."

Sure. 'Great excuse to go rent some time with naked tits,' more like.

"I'm not interested in whatever you have planned," I said. "You have no idea how much trouble your trip to The Gold Club caused me." Understatement of the year.

"Gold Club's closed. Got shut down. Drugs or some shit."

"Not what I heard," I said. "But I'm not going there. I'm going to go home after work, get some dinner, maybe go to the gym, and have a quiet night in."

Brandon wasn't listening. He was already on his phone, checking to see if the "rumors" I'd heard were true. "Fuck, you're right! They're reopening tonight. We have to go, man."

I shook my head. "You have fun, Brandon. Now get out. I have about 500 emails that I need to get through."

"Suit yourself, bruh." He wandered out, still on his phone, no doubt trying to learn if "Raven" was working tonight. It brought up all kinds of mixed emotions in me. There had been a time when I really did think that he'd hooked up with my wife as Raven. That felt like another lifetime, and a true testament to how far we'd come.

Still, even with my newfound openness, I squirmed in my chair, thinking of Brandon returning to the club and making another play for her. I sighed, glanced back at my computer, and dove into those 500 emails that really were waiting for me.

I WORKED a bit later than normal, but I was only half into the work. Amanda and I didn't have fully formed plans for the future beyond our quest to root out those profiting on jazz in SoCal, but we both knew that we couldn't stay in this city. It was too fraught, and there were too many opportunities for awkward encounters. But where we went next, I wasn't sure. It all hung on how we got out of our current mess.

Mia didn't know how many bent agents there were, but she didn't think there were that many. Most of the people on the Gold Club operation were like Amanda—they thought that they were doing legitimate, if unconventional, work. The only certainty was that Julia was definitely involved, intercepting all mission traffic and making sure it got sanitized before routing it up to Mr. FBI himself, Bradley Hirsch.

We were counting in large part on Hirsch's by-the-book attitude to get us out of this mess. We just needed to get the evidence packaged up in a way that he would find useful.

Amanda wasn't there when I got home, but since she was only making an appearance as Raven, she was free to come back home to sleep. Still, the club didn't close until 4 in the morning, and would probably be rocking on its reopening. As I told Brandon I would, I killed time after dinner working out,

pushing myself harder than I intended. Exhausted, both in mind and body, I crashed back home after a cool shower.

Brandon texted some time in the night, the rumble of his phone waking me out of my light sleep.

[Brandon]: Okay, yeah. Love this place, man! And Raven's back.

[Me]: Good luck. Fifth times's a charm?

[Brandon]: Go fuck yourself. I'm going to go fuck a hot stripper.

I didn't actually hear anything for the rest of the night, although my sleep was broken and restless until I heard the front door open. Amanda crept in, as quietly as she could. I heard her open the fridge, the rattle of ice in a glass, the water dispenser on the door of the fridge come on. I heard her stumble into the chairs around the kitchen table and curse.

When she finally slipped into the bedroom, I was wide awake. "How was your grand return?"

"Jesus, fuck!" she hissed, jumping. "You're awake."

"I am."

The ambient light coming through the bedroom doorway outlined her silhouette in the otherwise darkened room. She wore a tight, glossy black dress that barely covered her legs and presented a lot of cleavage. Her hair spilled around her shoulders, loose and wavy, and as she crawled onto the bed, I could smell her perfume over the sweat from dancing, and the bite of vodka on her breath.

"Good," she said, leaning forward and kissing me. "Because I'm so fucking horny."

She was demanding as she kissed me, her body thrumming with excitement. I ran my hands all over her as she straddled my cock and rolled her hips against mine. Just wondering what had her so worked up had *me* worked up.

"You enjoyed having all those men stare at you again?"

Amanda bit her lip, nodding. "Awful, isn't it?"

"It's all for the cover," I said. We both smiled at the paper thin excuse.

"Oh yes, the cover." She lifted up on her knees enough for me to push my boxers down my thighs, freeing my erection. As I did so, she peeled herself out of the tight dress. Beneath, she wore nothing but a thong.

"Did you give anyone private dances?" I asked.

"Mmm hmm," she groaned, pulling the thong to the side so she could sink onto me.

"You know, my coworker was there. Did you dance for someone named Brandon?"

I felt her pussy tighten around my dick. Her eyes opened, meeting mine in the dark as she started to ride me. "Yes, Brandon was there."

My heart skipped. I gripped her hips. "Did you dance for him?"

She bit her lip, riding me faster. "Would you be upset if I did?"

"I don't like him."

She nodded.

"But you did dance for him."

"I did." She bounced harder. "He wanted a private dance. He came with a lot of cash."

My breath caught. "Did you fuck him?"

Amanda started to rub her pussy as she fucked me, her eyes fluttering shut. Bracing one hand on my shoulder, she bounced as I held her hips, urging her to fuck faster. She felt amazing. She sounded amazing. I dragged my eyes over her, seeing her the way guys like Brandon Cruise did. She still wore the makeup from her shift, heavy eyeliner and blush. She still smelled amazing beneath the booze. Even the alcohol added to the wrongness of this moment.

Her nipples were hard, capping those wondrous breasts pressed together between her arms, full, soft, bouncing. Did Brandon see her like this? Did Brandon make her come?

"Oh, Amanda " I was close.

"Fuck me! Fuck me!" She was somewhere else, reliving the night, or the last weeks, or the last months. But she was also *with* me. I knew somehow, without knowing how. She was being reclaimed. She needed to be reclaimed.

"Uhn! Uhn!" Grinding down into me, she started to come, and I was right on her tail, exploding inside of her, making her mine all over again.

She collapsed over me, her soft breasts and feverishly hot body blanketing my skin. I held her, running my fingers through her hair as my cock continued to leak out the remains of my climax. She squeezed my dick with her pussy, milking me.

"God, I needed that," she said.

"You should have come home every night you worked this case. Could have been like this a long time ago."

"Yeah, that would have been nice," she hummed happily.

"So Brandon Cruise," I ventured. "Did you did you take all of his cash?"

"Are you asking if I fucked your coworker?"

Said like that it hit me hard. "Yeah. Did you?"

"No," she said. "He's a lot more fun to mess with."

"Okay, good," I said. "I really don't like that guy."

"Oh, trust me, he's got a reputation around the club."

I didn't ask about that. Instead I let sleep finally take me.

AMANDA WAS STILL SLEEPING when I got up the next morning, showered, and got ready for work. I took my Camry to work this time, waking her only long enough to kiss her goodbye. "You work again tonight?" I asked.

"Afternoon shift, actually, but yeah."

I nodded. "I'll pick you up?"

"That would be great."

Heading into work felt good. Brandon called out today, which was both no surprise and a welcome reprieve from yesterday. I didn't want to have to deal with him, and while I wasn't planning on sticking with this job, when I *did* go, I needed to leave on good terms. We still had a life to live after this debacle, and if I wanted it to be a comfortable one, I'd need to have some good references.

Just after lunch, the receptionist called me. *"There's someone here to see you,"* she said. *"Says she has a one o'clock?"*

I had to check my calendar, suddenly worried that I'd forgotten about something. My calendar showed nothing planned. "Okay, sure," I responded, curious to see where this was going. "Did you get a name?"

"She says her name's Gillian Downing."

A shiver ran up my spine at the mention of Julia's alias. "I'll be right out."

Sure enough, standing in the lobby was my wife's handler and most likely the woman at the center of the shadow network blackmailing Mia and Amanda. She was all cleaned up, blonde hair down, her pencil skirt of modest length, paired almost conservatively with her blouse and matching jacket. The glasses were a nice touch, although like so much of her, certainly not real. Still, I had to admit, she looked good.

"David, sorry I'm a bit early," Julia said, as if I was expecting her. "Traffic was lighter than expected."

"Of course, not a problem at all." I turned to the receptionist, asking if she could reserve the Magnolia Room.

"Of course, sir. Pretty sure that's open all day."

"Thanks. Right this way, Gillian. The Magnolia Room's actually a floor up." And way in the corner of the firm's office complex, an under-used room due to its remote location, coupled with its lack of any windows. Perfect for whatever it was that Julia had in mind.

"So how have you been?" I asked once we were alone in the elevator.

"It's been an interesting few days, for sure."

A sizzle of nervousness coursed through me. How much did she know? Were we busted already? Julia seemed to pick up on it. "You okay, David?"

"I just want this case to end. Amanda's back in there again."

"Oh, yes, she sure is." There was the evil Julia smile that I hated.

"Why are you saying it like that?" I asked. The elevator doors opened. We got out, and I led her towards the meeting room on legs that felt like rubber. Julia didn't respond until I'd closed the door behind us.

"You should lock it, if there's a lock," she suggested.

"Why?"

She was already removing a laptop from her bag.

"Wouldn't want anyone walking in on us," she said, smiling. "Or what you're about to witness."

I locked the door, asking, "Which is?"

Julia connected her computer up to the conference room television—a huge screen that was too large for the smaller room. "Why, your wife's grand reprise of her role as Raven," she said, taking obvious joy in my discomfort.

I swallowed hard, shuffling over to the chair beside Julia as a video feed came up on the room's monitor. My mouth was dry as the image resolved. There was Amanda, her back to the camera, wearing a sequined thong and a silver tube top, swaying her hips in front of a man seated before her. It was clearly a private dance, and the man was clearly Brandon Cruise.

THE VIDEO, REDUX

“What the fuck is this?” I asked Julia.

On the large, mounted screen, the video was crystal clear and amazingly high definition despite the low lighting of the room being recorded. Brandon was seated in a love seat, watching Amanda sway before him to the throbbing beat of the club.

“This is what your wife gets up to when you’re not around,” Julia said. She hopped up onto the conference table, crossing her legs and twisting around to watch the screen. “This is from just last night.”

“No ”

“Oh, yes.”

Amanda’s voice carried over the speakers, as clear as the video quality. *“I’ve seen you in here before,”* She turned away from him, watching him over her shoulder, much as Julia was doing in the room. *“I danced for you before. You had a friend.”*

“You remembered.” Brandon sounded tickled.

“Of course. I never forget the hottest guys I dance for.”

Julia snorted at that. “She’s good. Hard to believe she’s not been doing this longer, don’t you think?”

“Why are you doing this?” I groaned.

“Don’t you think it’s important to know what your sweet Amanda’s been up to?” Julia kicked off her pumps and ran her stocking-clad foot up the inside of my thigh. “Does it make you jealous? Or does it turn you on?”

“You’re fucking evil.”

“I’m fucking *practical*.”

“What do you want, Julia?”

On the screen, Amanda’s back still to Brandon and facing the camera, she pulled off her tube top, saying, *“I heard you showed my friend, Baylor, a good time that night.”*

“You should have come,” Brandon said. *“You looked like you wanted to.”*

"Oh, I did " She turned towards Brandon, her hands covering her tits, teasing him. *"But I already had commitments that night."*

Instead of answering my question, Julia said, "You guys are too fucking easy. Just look at how easily she got you back into her good graces."

"What is *wrong* with you?"

"I'm just trying to keep your eyes open, David. Now watch."

"This is just this is all for her cover."

"Is it? Or is it one last hurrah?" Julia nodded towards the screen. "Or is this just who she is now?"

On screen, Amanda crawled up into Brandon's lap, wearing nothing but the sequined thong, her large tits ripe and real, her dark nipples hard. She gathered them into her hands, squeezing them together as she stared right at Brandon. *"You like my titties?"* She lifted one high, tipped her head down, and licked her own nipple. *"They love to be licked."*

"I'll uhh lick them for you."

"How generous." Amanda drew back as Brandon leaned forward. *"Unfortunately, I'm not quite as generous."* Taking his hands, she moved them back to the armrest when he tried to touch her. *"Club's got rules."*

"How much?"

"To get a taste? A hundred and you can suck."

Julia laughed. "She's so good at this."

Brandon didn't hesitate. He forked over five bills. *"Just start a stack there,"* Amanda said, pointing to the side table. *"Easier that way. Now come "* She pulled his face right up to a hard nipple. He eagerly latched on. Amanda cooed happily.

"I was married once," Julia said. She moved off of the table and, to my surprise, right into my lap. Her dress rode up her thighs, baring the lacy tops of her stockings and the garters that held them up. "But he couldn't handle my job, so he left."

On the screen, Brandon's hands didn't remain on the armrests. Neither did mine. "So that's why you're so bitter?"

"He knew what I needed to do. My cover was as a fucking prostitute. What the fuck did he expect?"

I watched as my coworker's hands roamed over Amanda's bare back and down across her exposed ass. She didn't correct him this time. *"That's it,"* she hissed. *"Suck my titties. Get your money's worth."*

"Maybe he expected faithfulness?" I offered. "Maybe he expected that you'd prioritize him over your job?"

Amanda on the recording complicated my objections, moaning huskily, *"I can feel your big dick. That's nice."*

Brandon wasn't gentle as he groped Amanda, grabbing at her ass, pulling her down against him.

Julia gave me a flat look. "Maybe it's not just about the job?"

"How much to fuck?" Brandon asked.

"We're not there yet. But for five hundred, I'll sit on your face."

Brandon scrambled to set a second wad of bills on top of his first offering even as my *stripper wife* slinked out of his lap again and started to toy with her thong.

"This job will wear anyone down, David," Julia continued, carefully unbuttoning her blouse. "At some point, it's best to just accept that what happens undercover should stay undercover."

On screen, Amanda guided Brandon onto his back on the loveseat. *"You're a lot dirtier than I thought,"* Brandon said as he grasped her thong, pulling it off. Amanda started to climb over him.

"Actually, I'm always very clean," she said, rubbing her bald pussy. *"Need to be prepared for kinky sex at all times."*

With that, she climbed onto his face and lowered herself onto Brandon's mouth. She started grinding her hips once again to the throbbing beat of the music. *"Take out your cock and play with yourself."*

Julia didn't turn to look at the screen. She seemed to already know what was happening on screen behind her. I wondered how many times she had watched it through to the end before bringing it my way. Her focus was on me. She wore a black bra beneath her now open blouse, her full breasts practically spilling out of the plunging cups. "Why don't you take it out," she suggested, echoing Amanda. "Play with yourself."

While it was clear that what I was watching was getting to me, I made no move to so much as touch myself. Julia took matters into her own hands, reaching down between us to rub my dick.

Behind her, Brandon fished his dick out. He was about my size, stiff and erect as he started to stroke it. Amanda purred as she rode his face, biting her lower lip in pleasure. *"I knew you'd have a nice, big dick,"* she sighed. *"That's it that's it eat me eat my pussy and make me scream "*

I barely noticed as Julia unzipped me and pulled out my cock. I was so enraptured by the porn playing out in front of me. I tried to decipher whether Amanda was actually climaxing or not as she shuddered. Was she faking it, or was Brandon really that good?

"Your jealousy makes you so hard," Julia teased.

"Fuck you," I said to her. "You're an evil bitch."

"So punish me," she said, lifting a brow in challenge.

Amanda's voice haunted me as I stared Julia down: *"You've got a really nice dick, Brandon. Baylor wasn't exaggerating."*

"You want a taste, don't you?" Brandon's bravado was back. *"Maybe I should be charging you!"*

"I do love a big cock," Amanda said, and Julia mouthed the words right along with her.

I had to glance at the monitor, just in time to see Amanda wrap a hand around Brandon's shaft. She slid down his body, until she was level with his dick, and stared at it. *"I really love big cocks."* She pumped it slowly in both hands. *"I love choking on them. I love feeling them streeetch me out."* She dipped down, like she was about to suck on it. Instead, she pressed it against his tummy, her lips hovering centimeters from his hard flesh as she surveyed his manhood. *"I love how a big cock can touch me in places no other man can "*

Brandon licked his lips, entranced by her.

"But no one gets me for free."

"Five hundred?"

"I'll suck your beautiful dick for that." She licked his shaved ball sac. *"Triple it and you can fuck me."*

"Fuck, you drive a hard bargain."

"See how well she controls him?" Julia giggled cruelly.

Amanda rose off of her feet, somehow producing the square foil of a condom wrapper from nowhere. *"I know what this pussy is worth."* She rubbed her smooth mound, which was visibly wet. *"Trust me, you're going to love stretching me out."*

"Fine. Yes. Take my money!" He fumbled to count out most of the rest of his money as Amanda tore the condom wrapper open with her teeth.

"Once a whore," Julia said, "always a WHORE!"

"Were those your husband's last words to you when he kicked you to the curb, you sadistic cunt?"

That surprised her. Her eyes flared, but not only with surprise. She slapped me. Once. Hard.

"That's it!"

And with that, I pushed her onto her back. Enough was enough. Rising above her, I yanked her legs open until her skirt rode up around her waist. I saw the garters disappear. I also discovered that she wasn't wearing panties at all, her gash as smooth as Amanda's. Without thought beyond the red haze of rage and pain, I rammed my dick into Julia.

"Uh, fuck!"

"Fuck, you're big."

"Whore " I hissed against her neck.

I couldn't tell who was talking, Amanda or Julia. I couldn't even tell if that was me groaning as I started to fuck, or if it was Brandon enjoying my wife.

"You're soo big."

"That's it, fuck me. Punish me. Use me!"

"Whore!" This time I said it louder.

I glanced up at the monitor as I pounded into Julia, watching Amanda ride Brandon, her arms around his neck, her tits in his face. Reading my mind and knowing the scene by heart, Julia pulled me down to her in a gross reflection of the strip club scene and hissed, "She really loves it. She really loves riding that dick."

"You are evil "

"She loves how illicit it is."

"Judging by how wet you are," I gritted, "we both sure as shit know *you* do "

"She's addicted to the danger, the thrill. You'll never get that girl you married back. This is who she is!"

Julia's head lolled back. I didn't realize how hard I was fucking her until she started to come. Amanda was also moaning on camera.

"Come, fucking come," someone urged. A woman. Amanda to Brandon. Julia to me? Amanda through time and space, giving me the go ahead to fuck this slut and put her in her place?

I rose up onto my toes, finding a higher purchase to fuck Julia. I pressed her knees back, opening her as I hammered yet another shuddering orgasm through her body. I wanted her to remember me. I wanted her to crave me when she was alone.

"Yes, David! Fuck yes!"

Julia reached up and grabbed me by the back of the head, pulling me down into a searing kiss just as I heard Brandon come. The kiss was so intense that our teeth clicked and clattered. If I could kill with a kiss, Julia would be dust. I bit her lower lip, in hopes of drawing blood.

I was there, exploding deep inside of her, filling her with my heat, again and again. She gasped, relinquishing my head as she accepted my come and arched her back. Her tits had worked their way free of her bra, her nipples hard and high, ready for her to pinch and twist.

I staggered back and slumped into the swiveling conference chair, breathing ragged, pulse racing, aghast at what I'd just done. The room was suddenly silent.

I glanced back at the monitor. The video had ended. The show was over.

Julia slowly came down from her high, but didn't bother to cover herself. She just laid there, supine and heaving. She was so comfortable that she didn't even bother opening her eyes. She was in control.

"Why did you come here?" I asked as I started to get myself back in order. I was still at work, after all, and my ears burned at the thought that maybe someone had wandered back into this remote part of the office. The mailroom was back here, after all. It wasn't like it was abandoned.

"To make sure you know the truth." At last, Julia sat up. My come had already begun to leak down her thigh, and she dabbed it with a tissue before pulling her skirt down.

"How magnanimous of you."

She hopped off the conference table. "Also to seduce you and record us doing it." She patted her laptop before shutting it. "Probably best to keep this little encounter between us, yeah?"

She started to redo the buttons of her blouse as I stewed. I started to speak, then hesitated.

"What?" Julia asked. "Spit it out."

"Could you send me that video? I want to make sure it's real."

"Oh, you are so cute, aren't you. I've already shared the link. Enjoy it. Limited time only." She made to kiss me. I flinched away. "But I have *so* much more if you're interested." Sliding her laptop into her bag, she said, "I can see myself out." And like that she was out the door.

Relief exploded through me. I reached into my pocket and removed my phone, ending my own secret recording. Scrubbing back, I made sure that our audio came through relatively clearly, despite the layers of fabric.

"Okay," I murmured, grounding myself. Then I stood, paced back to the doors, and peeked out. The hallway was just as empty as always. No one had come to gawk, and Julia was gone. Shutting it quietly, I relocked the door and went back to my laptop.

There it was, an email from an unknown sender with nothing but a link. It was the kind of email that our cyber security team always told us never to open. I opened it, clicking the link and muting the video.

As the scene played out once again, I copied the address and sent it off to my contact.

My next call was to Amanda, from my burner phone to hers. She picked up on the second ring. "Hey," she whispered. I could hear the sounds of the club in the background. I wasn't sure if she was alone.

"You were right," I said. Adrenaline raced through me. Was this what it felt like for Amanda every day she was undercover? Was this how it felt to run a successful mission? "She fell for it."

"Yes!" Amanda said with a sigh of relief. "Pick me up at 4. We'll talk then, and and I need a ride to the marina."

I ended the call and sank back into the conference chair, watching the soundless image of Amanda swaying to the music as she taunted Brandon. We'd talked about Brandon yesterday in Amanda's Wrangler. She'd explained the plan, but wouldn't do it if I wasn't on board.

As I watched the video for the second time, my heart raced and my dick was definitely hard. I didn't like the plan. I didn't like Brandon at all. But it was thrilling all the same—maybe because it was so wrong.

I felt something else, too. Something that I hadn't felt in a long time—relief.

BOOK 4

THE CUCK AND THE CUCKQUEAN

I picked Amanda up in the back lot of The Gold Club after her late afternoon shift. Wednesday afternoons were quiet, and there was no one around to notice Amanda as she slipped into my Camry. She wore a red crop tank with USC letters across her chest, and a tiny pair of white shorts that barely covered her asscheeks. She tossed her shoulder bag into the back seat and sidled close to me, giving me a kiss.

She smelled the way Raven did, a mixture of perfume and makeup and alcohol. She smelled like excitement. "So?" she asked.

"She just couldn't resist fucking with me," I said. "She came in person this time, just so she could watch my face as she revealed your 'betrayal.' Then she sent the link."

"You watched it? Together?"

"Oh yeah," I said. "Of course I had to the first time, with Julia, and I've made sure to load it up every hour or so since. I know the bitch is capturing how many times."

"I'm sorry—"

"We talked about it. I'm okay. Really. And I noticed how you milked him dry of all his money."

Amanda seemed to relax a little, laughing softly. She glanced out the window. "A kick in the balls would have been better, but I'll settle for draining him of two grand."

"He'll feel the money more, trust me," I said.

"Do you really think your guy can trace that link?"

"If Javier's product is as good as he claims, yeah." I'd reached out to Javier Garcia, whose company specialized in digital forensics. I had remembered doing the paperwork for him, and how he bragged that he could trace things that the US government couldn't. I was hoping that he wasn't just blowing hot air. "We should know sometime tomorrow."

The plan was simple enough. We took advantage of the fact that Julia and whoever she was working with had a bug in our house. We'd made them think that we were arguing, letting them hear Amanda giving me an obvious lie. And we knew that Julia wouldn't be able to resist coming to me with proof. Now we just needed to trace it to its source.

"Did this nutball plan really just work without a hitch?" she mused aloud.

"Not completely without a hitch," I said. "You need to know something."

"Yes?"

My cheeks burned. "I I fucked Julia."

Amanda's mouth fell open. Guilt prickled along my scalp. Then my wife took a deep breath and nodded. "Okay. How did it happen?" Her tone was neutral, unreadable.

"She was taunting me about you. Calling you a whore. I wanted to shut her up."

"So you fucked her?"

"I'm sorry. It doesn't make any sense—"

"No, no, David. It makes total sense." Amanda took a deep breath. "And honestly? I'm *into* it."

"You're what?"

Amanda moved closer to me, as close as she could with her seatbelt still on. "I hope you showed that bitch how good I've got it."

"I did my best," I said, relief washing over me. "You're not upset?"

"I mean, I don't have much room to be upset?" she said.

"Doesn't mean you can't be. Our emotions aren't exactly rational."

"Pull over," she said.

"Hm?"

"Over there. Into the Whole Foods parking garage."

I snorted, but did as she asked. "New mission? Christen every parking garage in LA?"

Amanda laughed along with me. "It's a colossal task, but you know *I'm* in."

I drove us into the top level, the emptiest and most open. Amanda had already unbuckled her seat belt before I'd shut the car completely off, and was maneuvering over the console.

"Julia has been trying to fuck you since she learned that you didn't immediately bail when you found out about me. You are the kind of man that she wants, more than anyone—someone who loves me despite my flaws."

She started to grind her hips against my cock, the cotton of her cheerleader shorts so thin. "She hates what we have."

"So you're saying that she only fucked me to get back at you?" I said as I pushed my hand inside of her shorts. She wore a thong beneath, red like her top. "Awfully egocentric of you."

"Stop being reductionist," Amanda said, shifting around so she could slide her shorts and panties off. "We're complicated beings, and our motivations are never so simple. She hated me. She wanted you. Both of these things can be true."

With my dick out, she easily sank down onto my shaft with a grateful sigh.

"So how did that feel?" she asked. "To fuck her?"

"Felt good " So did Amanda's pussy on my dick. "Good the way hitting a punching bag can feel good. Not that I want to punch her," I quickly added.

"I get what you mean. That's how I felt with Brandon."

My dick swelled at the reminder that she'd fucked my douchebag colleague. I grasped her hips, forcing her to bounce harder. "Looked like you enjoyed that."

"Mmm I liked that you'd see," she whispered.

"Come on. It was more than that. You liked returning to the role, didn't you?"

Amanda didn't respond. She didn't have to. I could feel in her breathing and the way she rode me that she did.

As we neared our releases, she whispered. "You can't come in me. I'm going to see Kozlov."

"*Nick*," I corrected. "You're going to see your boyfriend, *Nick*."

"Uhhh!" With great effort, she hoisted herself out of my lap and dropped her head between my legs. I came just as she wrapped those lips around my shaft. Her cheeks hollowed out as she sucked down hard, and I filled her mouth with my spunk.

I was satisfied, but I wasn't going to send Amanda on her way to Nikolai Kozlov wanting. Before she could protest, I reached over, reclined her seat, and went down on her, feasting on her pussy. She gasped, running her fingers through my hair as I got her off in one swift and loud orgasm.

"Is that, like, a double reclamation or something?" Amanda sighed, wiping sweat from her brow. She remained reclined in her seat, but turned her head to smile over at me.

"I hadn't thought about that. The cuck and the cuckqueen," I said.

"Labels, labels." She reached for her shorts, pulling them on with her panties. "But I am starting to get what you felt. It's kind of shocking, but also "

"Electrifying," I said.

"Those two words mean exactly the same thing," Amanda said with a laugh.

"But they kind of don't. You know what I mean."

She nodded. "I do."

I straightened up my own pants as she returned her seat to the proper position. Around this time I caught sight of a stern looking security guard making his way towards our secluded car. "Uh oh," I said, turning the car on. "Time to go!"

"Oh shit!" Amanda laughed as I peeled out of the garage before the man made his way over to us.

"Next stop the marina?" I asked.

"I've got the rest of his money. Time to deliver."

"You know what his plan is?"

Amanda shrugged. "My guess is that he'll use the yacht that he's on to escape down to Mexico, but I honestly don't know. He seems really paranoid. More so than usual. And even more unpredictable."

"Are you going to be okay alone with him?"

Amanda nodded. "I can navigate him now. Are *you* going to be okay?"

"I'll be okay, as long as I hear the stories when I see you again."

"How did you become such a perv?" Amanda giggled.

"By learning what a dirty slut you became."

"Touchй."

We held hands as we drove south. After a bit I asked another thing that I'd been wondering. "By the way, who reopened the club?"

Amanda pulled the sun visor down and flipped open the mirror, studying her makeup in the reflection as she answered. "Not sure. No one is. The management has all been changed over, though, and you'll never guess where they're from."

"Chechnya."

"Bingo."

We arrived back at the marina, where Kozlov had disappeared a few days ago. It was also the location of what Kozlov had called the "party to end all parties" that would be happening Saturday night.

"Be careful in there, my love."

"You know I will, always." She kissed me. "I love you, babe. Remember that, no matter what."

"Of course. And I'll be parked right here, just in case "

"You know you don't have to do that," she said.

"And you know that I'm going to anyway."

She nuzzled my nose. "I do. I'll text when I can. You remember all of our codes?"

"Of course I do. We've gone over it so many times." We'd devised a set of emojis to mean different things: muscle arm meant all is clear, confetti was to get help, heart eyes for get the fuck out.

There were more, but these were the really important ones. I knew them better than the multiplication tables by this point. "I'll be here until you muscle arm me."

Amanda made a flex with her arm, then kissed her bicep. "Always, baby."

We laughed, then she slipped out of the car and I watched her go, her midriff bare, her white shorts thin enough that I could see her red thong beneath. She looked so different from the Columbia grad I'd fallen for, and yet I still saw that smart and capable woman beneath it all.

There were now guards stationed at the entrance to the marina. None looked openly armed, but they carried themselves as if they were. And they were definitely a new addition since Kozlov had arrived. He'd found some more muscle from somewhere.

They were all also clearly Eastern Europeans. Best bet? Chechens.

I drove just out of sight of the guards, parked along the street, and pulled out my Kindle. It wasn't even 7 yet, and I planned on sticking around as long as Amanda needed me. As night fell and I munched on a sandwich in the backseat, beneath a blanket, I stared up into the sky. Somewhere up there, there were stars beyond the light pollution, staring down at me and wondering what the hell I was doing.

THE RABBIT HOLE

I was tired as hell the next day. Sleep had come in fits, and whenever I woke up, I remembered that I was sleeping in my car. I got the all clear from Amanda sometime early the next morning, followed by another.

Muscle arm emoji.

Praying hands emoji.

Bed emoji.

The last wasn't on our code list, but I got the hint. I headed home and tried to get a few hours of decent sleep before the work day.

Now I was locked in my office as a Zoom call resolved on my monitor. I forced a smile. The irony wasn't lost on me that one of the most secure places to have a very NSFW conversation was on my business machine at work.

Javier Garcia's image resolved on the screen, his home office behind him, and his smile as ready as I remembered it. He still had the scruff, flecked with gray in a way that made him look older than he was. His hair was a bit disheveled as well, like he'd just rolled out of bed, but gave him an Old World charm.

"Hey, Javier," I greeted.

"*Hola*, my friend. It's good to see you again."

We exchanged pleasantries when all I wanted to do was ask him about the video. At last, I couldn't push it any longer. "So were you successful?"

Javier sat back in his chair, his hands in his lap, puffing up his cheeks as he blew air out through puckered lips. "Whoever is housing these links is good. Very good. They not only have it routing and redirecting all over the globe, they have set up so many traps and alarms that it's made it very difficult."

My heart sank.

"In truth, *aliado*, I have never encountered something like this outside of test simulations. It got me thinking about what could be hidden here, and that in turn got me very worried. You don't put this kind of security in front of just anything."

I nodded. "Thanks for trying, Javier. At the very least, it's good to know what we're up against."

"Hold up. Who said anything about just trying? I told you our software was good."

"You did it?"

"Full access. No one detected us. And best of all, we've installed a back door for easier access in the future."

I whistled, impressed. "All those safeguards in place and you already have full access?"

Javier beamed. "In matters such as this, I am *El Conejo*."

"The Rabbit?"

"*Si*, quick, like the bunny."

"You got around all that stuff, *and* installed a back door, too? Hell yes, you are. What did you find there?"

"I didn't open any files, but looking at the file types, there's a lot of video in there. A chaotic amount."

"Of what? Can you tell? Were they in folders or something?"

Javier chuckled. "Nothing like that, no. But I indexed the metadata. Lot of interesting things. A few names seemed to come up quite often."

This was it. This was the dirt that Agent Mia had talked about—the way they were all being kept in line. "Which names?" I asked.

"Yours, for one. Along with another with your last name—'Amanda Harrington, aka Raven.'" He looked back at the camera and grinned. "Wasn't that the stripper's name?"

"Yes," I felt hot and quickly moved us along. "What other names?"

"Time out is she your wife or your sister?"

"Wife."

"Interesting," he said, his smile even wider.

"Javier, can we move on?"

"Sure, sure. Other names that came up quite a number of times include 'Nikolai Kozlov '"

"Sure, makes sense."

"'Mia Moore, aka Misty'. Someone named 'Mike Aguilar'. No alias given."

Aguilar, the agent who'd gone along with Mia and tried to murder Kozlov. "Okay, got it."

I didn't recognize many of the other names he read, but I sure as hell recognized the last. "This one came up quite a lot, and some of the files associated with it are the oldest," he said. 'Julia Monroe'. She has many aliases. 'Gillian Downing', 'Ava Collins', 'Rachel Sinclair'..."

As Javier rattled off the names, I tried to process it all. Julia was in there? If that was the case, then she was as caught in this web as the rest of us. I'd been operating on the belief that she was in a partnership with the powers that be, but she was just a pawn.

"Could you back up, Javier? Could you read the other names, just after Aguilar?"

"Let me see " He clicked around. "There's a 'Laura Bennett', and I'm not sure I can pronounce these two. 'Rashid Makhmudov' and 'Dzhabrail Sokolov'? Something like that."

"Hold on." I pulled out a piece of paper and had him spell the names out. They seemed important.

"Meta-data also has location stamps," he went on. "Many are at the Gold Club, but there are some residences."

I gave him my address, asking if any of the files shared it. "Oh, yes," he said. "There are a few. All pretty recent, though. Audio files."

It wasn't a surprise. Not with Julia showing up to taunt me with that video. Still, it was disconcerting to know that my house was bugged. I gave him Ty's, holding my breath, only releasing it when there was nothing. "This is huge, Javier. Thank you so much."

"What this is is scary as shit, my friend. You need to be careful. There are very few organizations with access to this level of cyber security, and many of them go by three letter acronyms."

My blood went cold. "You think it's—"

"I don't even want you to say it over this Zoom, man. But you'd know better than me."

"And you didn't look at any of them?"

He chuckled. "I'm tempted, but I also don't want to expose myself anymore. Although that Raven file " He winced. "Sorry, forgot there for a minute that she was your wife."

"It's okay," I said. "If I'm honest, I'm curious about it, too. All of them." I groaned, knowing full well what the right thing to do was. "Can you destroy them?"

"Easy enough." He started clicking away. "I can burn them so bad that there would be no way to recover any of it."

"Hold up! Don't do it yet. They'll know once, right?"

"Oh, almost immediately. Alarms will be going off everywhere."

I nodded, my heart pounding. "Okay, can't have that. Not yet. Not until after Saturday."

"Like I said, I have a backdoor into their system now. All you need to do is say the when, but—"

"Thanks."

"*But* I'm going to need a little something from you, *amigo*. I like you, I appreciate you for getting me the contracts, this is just some freaky stuff man."

"How about, next time you visit the states, I arrange a special lapdance with 'Raven'?"

Javier processed what I was saying, then grinned and nodded. "In addition to those videos, there are references to offshore bank accounts in here that have quite a bit of money. I was just going to take that, but a lapdance with your wife works, too."

"Bank accounts? Know who they belong to?"

"Not the US Government," Javier said. "And that's pretty much all I *need* to know."

That, right there, was the financial backing behind whoever was pulling all of these strings. I may not have understood spycraft, but I did understand the nature of a bureaucracy enough to know that it all flows from money.

"Burn all of that, too. Or take it, I don't care. That's probably why there's so much security around those servers."

"You got it, *jefe*. I'll definitely 'burn' it all."

"Just make sure you wait until early Sunday morning, Pacific time."

"Early Sunday morning. Of course."

"*Muchas gracias, compinche*."

His ever-present grin widened. "*¿De nada, compa!*"

"Oh, and Javier?"

"*Si*, yes, my friend?"

"Thanks for the compliment, but *I* am not the *jefe*. You, *Secor*. *El Jefe*."

Javier's grin went crooked. "*El Jefe Conejo*. This I like very much. *¿Gracias!*"

I ended the call, my heart pounding, nearly sick to my stomach. Just what were we dealing with here? How high up did this go? Suddenly, it seemed like our ragtag bunch was way out of our league—even if Ty brought in the backing of the LAPD.

I sighed. I had one other card that I could play, although I didn't love it. Now, it was necessary. Picking up the phone, I made a call.

I LEFT WORK a little early after my call with Javier. It was Thursday, and Ty and I met up at a bar in Venice. While everyone else was sitting outside in the gorgeous LA weather, we were alone inside, the shadows feeling right for this talk. "So you have access?" Ty asked.

"My guy came through."

Ty did a fist pump. Then, turning to the bar, he called for a round of Maker's shots. "Videos?"

"Apparently a lot of them. Of a lot of people."

Ty licked his lips. "You watch any?"

For a voyeur like me, it was funny that it hadn't occurred to me to do that until Ty suggested it. "No, I don't actually have access. It seems wrong—"

"Fuck that, man. Remind me again which part of any of this is right." The drinks arrived.

He made a good point. It was like the time that I discovered Amanda was Raven. I went from blissful ignorance to all-consuming curiosity. Suddenly, I didn't think of that server and all those files as bits and bytes to be destroyed—although they certainly needed to be destroyed. They also became a treasure trove of porn, and like a teenaged boy hiding stolen copies of Playboy under my bed, I knew that while I had to get rid of it soon, I also kept on looking.

"You ready for Saturday?" Ty asked. Apparently he'd moved on.

I forced myself to maneuver past the possibilities of that server. "You mean do I think I'm ready for the 'party to end all parties'? I guess I'm going to have to be, but not really?"

We still didn't know what Saturday even entailed, other than some kind of debauchery, bred from Nikolai Kozlov's coked out mind.

The thought of that man felt like a fist closing over my rapidly beating heart and squeezing. "Amanda spent the night with him last night," I said.

Ty didn't react, his face neutral. "And how do you feel about that?"

"Jealous," I said honestly. "Worried." I shifted in my seat. I lowered my voice, ashamed. "Turned on."

"All healthy, reasonable emotions. Even that last one." He lifted his whiskey. "Maybe even especially that last one."

I raised my glass, too. "You know, I slept in the car outside the marina?" I stared at the amber liquid swirling in the small, faceted glass. "Not really sure what I was hoping to accomplish. If anything happened, it's not like I'd be able to do much, let alone even know. Best case, she gets out of there and I'm her getaway driver."

"I take it there weren't any incidents?"

"None. Got a text early this morning to head home. That all was good." Something cool and uncomfortable slithered through my gut. I didn't think I'd ever get used to this, which as Ty would say was also a good thing. "I'm pretty sure she's still with him."

For all his bluster, Ty could be surprisingly empathetic. His face softened. He said, "You're doing great, man. Not many guys would be able to."

I nodded. "It's not so much the sex. I guess I've changed, but that's now " I searched for a word. Ty helped.

"Hot as fuck?"

"It's certainly a kink I didn't know about. But it's Nikolai Kozlov. She's with *him*."

"You're still worried that she's in love?"

"No. Fuck no. But the man is unpredictable. He's crazy. And he's on TILT as his life crumbles around him."

Ty took it all in. "I've seen a few things in my years with the LAPD. Not all great. I've seen some pretty awful characters doing pretty fucked up things. You think crime is random, and a lot of times it is. But if you get to the heart of most things, the through line is pretty easy to follow."

"What the fuck are you saying?" I asked.

"Just you see Kozlov as unpredictable and wild. But he's not. He's acting on instinct now. This isn't some strategic mastermind. This is a once-charismatic drug dealer who's gotten high on his own supply and is lashing out. He's actually very predictable, because he's not thinking with this." Ty tapped his temple. "See him as a wild dog, sure, but he's also collared by his own fear."

"This is supposed to make me feel better about Amanda spending all night and all day with him?"

"In a way. Amanda knows him better than any of us. She's the one holding the leash. He just doesn't know it."

It helped. Some, anyway.

Ty raised his glass of Maker's. "I was going to toast to that nerdy bullshit about the servers and whatever, but here's to you, your wife, and your new pet dog."

"Thanks." I cracked a smile as we clacked our drinks together, tapped the table, and tipped the contents back. I coughed as the liquor hit the back of my throat

like fire. Ty drank it down like water.

The burn receded into a comfortable warmth in my chest. "So you and Mia, huh?"

"She's a great fuck," he said with a chuckle.

"You think we can trust her?"

"I think our goals are aligned right now. She doesn't like the threat of those videos anymore than Amanda would." He signaled for another round. "And we're her best bet to neutralize that threat."

"I don't think I can do another round, man."

Ty waved me off. "Dave the Muscle drinks."

"And David the Husband has to drive."

"Suit yourself." Ty tossed back both shots. "Then *David* can drive me home."

AMANDA CHECKED in with me with the burner phone throughout the day, letting me know that all was okay.

Muscle arm.

Didn't help with my nerves as I dropped an inebriated Ty at his place and went home to an empty house.

She called as I was warming up dinner.

"Hey," she said. Her voice sounded husky, but not like she was being intentionally sexy. It made me think about all the sex she may have been having, and that started stirring all those uncomfortable feelings again.

"Hey," I said back to her. "You still " I remembered the bugs that were listening—always listening. "...at your apartment?" I finished with a lie.

"Just leaving, actually," she said. It was almost 9 at night. She'd been with Kozlov for the past 24 hours. That sat like a stone in my gut. "And I only talked my way out of here because I told him I had to work the closing shift at the club."

I wanted to ask if she was okay, but was afraid that it would set off alarm bells for whoever was listening—if anyone was. I tried something different. "You're okay? With working the closing shift, I mean."

Amanda picked up on my real question. "Yeah, I am. He's like a teenager who's been sent to his room, all full of angst and grievance. Everything's unfair. He's mad at everyone. He's needy, which is better than him not."

It was only half of what I meant. I wanted to know if she had sex with him. I wanted to know if she enjoyed the sex with him. Whether she'd had to do more coke. But I couldn't ask.

"Did you hear back from Garcia?" she asked. At least she could speak her mind without worry.

"Yes. It's good. I think that contract is secure."

I heard her sigh of relief. A car door opened. She said, "Thank you," to someone before the door shut. "Hey, I just arrived at the club. I'll talk to you later, okay?"

"Okay."

"I love you, honey. Always remember that."

"I will." That I couldn't say it back to her, though, because we were supposed to be fighting, was tough. "See you when I see you."

Amanda working the closing shift meant that she wasn't going to be off until around four—way too late to stay up to wait. I wasn't even sure if she'd come home after.

I was left with my imagination running wild about all the things that may have happened over the last day at the marina, and all the things that may happen that night at the strip club.

That's when Ty's suggestion wiggled its way into my thoughts—I had access to hours and hours of sexy video on that server. All I had to do was ask for it.

Which was a terrible idea.

I loaded up the one link that did have—the one with Brandon that I both loved and hated—only to find that the connection was broken once again.

I got ready for bed, telling myself that I'd just go to sleep and ignore any temptation to contact Javier. Then, when I *did* contact Javier, I figured he'd be asleep back in Spain.

Could you send me an export of the metadata from those videos?

It was a harmless request anyway, meant for research purposes alone. I could pore over time stamps and locations and subjects, all to keep myself prepared for what came next.

When he responded right away, I knew I was in trouble.

Sure thing, compadre.

The spreadsheet was extensive. There was a lot of data: hundreds of clips of video, ranging from 30 seconds to close to an hour. The location stamps were all GPS coordinates, and I spent a lot of time on Google Maps transposing coordinates to the names of people onto a pad of paper. I learned where Kozlov lived—the house where Julia must have taken me—and a few other spots around the city that he frequented.

There were a few other locations in residential zones throughout the city. Based on the meta-data, I deduced where Julia lived. Amanda's apartment as Raven was also present—most of the video tagged with her name and Kozlov's, although I was in there as well.

I figured out where the Chechen guys must live, scribbling their addresses down on my notepad for future reference. They were also associated with a slip at the same marina where Kozlov was hiding out, although it was a different boat entirely.

Diving further, I started to put together a rough timeline of events. Mostly, I was drawn to Kozlov and Amanda, studying the times when they were present together. Many weren't video files at all, but audio. That made sense. They didn't have cameras everywhere—like Kozlov's house. I could still remember when Julia had brought me to Kozlov's house and we'd only listened.

There was one video from the club that predated all others. It was time-stamped at just after a month from when she'd begun—a month after what had to be the blowjob video Julia had sent. Was that the first ever encounter between the two of them? Was that the beginning of everything?

I needed to let this one lie. This close to the end, it was foolish to take risks. At the same time, in just a few days, these videos would be gone without a trace. The records would be wiped clean. How could I resist just a small peek?

What if I wanted to watch one of the videos? I wrote to Javier. *For research purposes.*

It was an excuse so thin that I didn't bother dressing it up more than that. Again, the security consultant wrote back within minutes.

Now that's trickier. There are risks.

That was exactly the response I needed. It kept me from doing what I really shouldn't do. It kept me on the tracks. Then, of course, he wrote a followup email.

I can't help myself, my friend. Tell me which file you want and give me a day. I love a good problem to solve.

And I sent him the file name.

SOMEHOW I GOT TO SLEEP. I'd spent most of the night refreshing my messaging app, hoping that Javier was faster at securing the file. But Javier went silent, and at some point I started to panic that maybe he'd gotten caught. That maybe he'd tripped an alarm and my request had fucked everything up.

I fell into a fitful slumber some time around 3am. Amanda was snuggled up against me in bed when I woke up the next morning. I wasn't expecting that, and nearly jumped out of bed when I became sensible of her warm body cuddling up to me.

"You're home," I whispered. She didn't wake up. She didn't even stir. I couldn't stop smiling as I crept out of the bedroom and went to make coffee. She was home. She was home.

Amanda emerged just as I was pouring the first cup out of our French press, looking rough around the edges. "Oh, yes please," she said, smelling the coffee.

I showed Amanda the post-it note I'd slapped on her cup as I handed it to her. It read: *They are definitely listening.*

"I don't remember you coming in," I said.

"It was late. Didn't want to wake you." She kept her voice neutral as she took the cup from me, taking in the aroma. She didn't sip it though. Not right away. Instead, she set it on the counter and quietly slipped up to me, touching my hip and nuzzling my nose. "And I had a long night."

I could almost read her thoughts. I could almost hear the words that she really wanted to share. *And if I did wake you, I'd probably jump your bones.*

"Is it going to be like this forever?" I asked, trying to sound disapproving.

In response, Amanda delivered her own sharp question. "You'd like that, wouldn't you?"

Only she was smiling as she asked it. It was funny, this game we were playing—where she looked down on me as a cuckold and I looked down on her as a cheating whore.

"My coworker make another appearance?"

"What's that supposed to mean?" She hadn't moved from her spot beside me, and her smile only grew. She leaned close, nipping at my lips as I drew my head back.

"Nothing," I muttered. If Julia was listening, I wondered how much it got under her skin that I didn't challenge Amanda on how she "cheated" and "lied."

"You're hard," she whispered, reaching between my legs. Now I wasn't sure if this was entirely play acting. She studied my lips before flicking her gaze up to meet mine. She was just as aroused as I was, despite probably only a few hours of sleep.

"I should get going to work," I stammered.

"Sure," she said.

"Some of us have real jobs."

Oh, good one, Amanda mouthed. "I'm actually meeting up with Julia later today. Trying to wrap this case up at last."

"I've heard that one before. Tell my 'wife' hello for me."

"In her dreams." She gave me a kiss before letting me go. I wanted to fuck her so badly, but resisted. Amanda added, "Oh, and tomorrow, I've got this big event at the Gold Club." This was the lie we'd discussed, that she'd feed me. "Some big VIPs are coming in. New management wants all the girls on staff."

"I thought you were mostly doing this as a ruse?" All of this was a ruse, of course, but I needed to sound like the suspicious husband. "Why do you have to do *anything* special for these new guys?"

"Because if I don't, they'll know something is up. Just leave it alone, okay, David?" Inches from my face, she grinned, enjoying this.

I shook my head, kissed her quietly, and whispered, "I love you."

She mouthed it back.

"Fine, whatever," I said for the mics. "So I'll see you tonight?"

"TBD," she said, but nodded that I would.

When I got out of there, stepping into my own car, I was smiling. I couldn't help it. All of these games were crazy. They were listening in. They were everywhere. It was dangerous. But I couldn't help feeling giddy. I was doing this with Amanda again. I was part of it all.

My phone buzzed as I pulled the Camry's door shut. At first I figured it was probably Javier calling me back. Or maybe it was Amanda, calling to tell me more about whatever was really going on.

Except that it wasn't the burner ringing. It was my regular phone.

A number I didn't recognize. I thumbed the connection open.

"Hello, David," came a man's voice, one that I'd heard plenty of times over the last few weeks, but always on television. "This is Bradley Hirsch. I work with your wife."

NO PLAN SURVIVES

“So you’re the husband,” Hirsch said.

We weren’t sitting in the LA field office downtown like I’d expected.

Rather, Hirsch met me down at the San Pedro docks, in the overflow lot for the fish market—exactly the kind of place where people go to do clandestine things, like exchange information or commit murder. Not that Bradley Hirsch would murder me. According to everything that I’d read, he was too by the book to do something like that.

I wanted to tell him that I was so much more than just “the husband”. I wanted to be offended by the minimization, like I was just one piece of many that he was moving around the board. But I also didn’t have the guts. “Yes, I’m the husband.”

We were both outside of our cars. He was leaning on the hood of his—a glossy black Mercedes EQE SUV—wearing a gray suit and a conservative dark blue tie. It was overcast today, and his aviators were pushed up into his graying hair to reveal a pair of pale blue eyes that seemed to see all my darkest secrets.

“Why did you want to speak to me, sir?” *Sir?* I couldn’t remember the last time that I’d called anyone ‘sir’, and yet it seemed fitting for Hirsch.

“I need an outsider’s perspective,” he said.

“Okay, sure,” I agreed.

He didn’t immediately follow-up with a question, though, and for a second, I wondered if I’d missed something. I started to sweat, searching for something to say to fill the void when he finally asked, “Speaking broadly, how do you think the investigation was handled?”

“Honestly? Not well.”

I winced as Hirsch narrowed his eyes.

“Don’t sugarcoat this, David. That only leads to cavities. Speak plainly. I have a suspicion about something, but need ”

“An outsider’s perspective,” I finished for him. I took a deep breath. Here goes. “I think some of the people on your team are compromised.” I licked my lips. I

thought I could do this, but now that I was in front of this man, my levels of apprehension were screaming in the red. If I were a machine, alerts would be bleating *danger, danger*.

What was worse, Hirsch didn't prod or coax. He didn't say anything. He didn't even ask who. He remained quiet, waiting for me to continue.

"Amanda is pretty sure that Julia is at the heart of it. Also, two other agents. Moore and Aguilar? Something like that."

Finally, I got a reaction from Hirsch—a slight flicker in his eyes and intake of breath at the names. "That's troubling."

"You don't seem surprised."

At first I wasn't sure if Hirsch would even respond. Then he said, "This confirms what I've suspected for a while, but I thought it might be limited to just Agent Monroe." Julia. "Has she tried to turn your wife?"

"Wait a second. You suspected one of the primary agents running this case, and didn't do anything about it?"

Hirsch's lips formed a tight line before he said, "Sometimes the best traps aren't the ones that come spring loaded. A mouse who brings the poisoned cheese back to its nest is more effective than the one with a broken neck."

"So this whole thing has been some kind of what? Sting operation? What about jazz and Kozlov and all that?"

"Also important things to root out," Hirsch said. "But you didn't answer me earlier. Has Julia tried to turn your wife?"

"Not that I'm aware of."

"Then how did you come upon this information?"

This conversation was getting easier, although I was still freaking the fuck out. "Too many alarm bells going off for Amanda to ignore. The operation was too unconventional." I sighed. "Can you pull her from the case? I'm I'm worried about her."

Hirsch studied me like an animal trainer studies a new performing seal that was just brought in. We weren't equals. "That's fair. And I'm working to try and get her extracted."

"She said that she's meeting with Julia today," I offered.

"Interesting." The way he said it, I wasn't sure if he knew about the meeting or not. "Has Kozlov tried to reach out to Amanda?"

This was the question that I'd been dreading. "What? Uh, no. Why would he?"

Good one, David. Really smooth.

Hirsch stared me down with that unrelenting gaze. I understood why he was so good at his job. He'd perfected the art of interrogation. "I need to know what I'm dealing with here if you want me to get her out safely."

"She's worried that Julia, or whoever, is trying to kill him," I blurted. "To cover up some bigger conspiracy."

"I see. So she knows where he is right now."

"Yes."

"And do you?"

"If I tell you, you can't raid it. Not right now. Not until tomorrow night. There's there's something happening."

Hirsch weighed my plea. He didn't look like a man who appreciated anything out of his control, so this whole situation must have been bothering the hell out of him. "I'll consider it, but this has gone on for too long."

"Just one more day. Give us until Sunday morning."

"What is happening tomorrow night?" he asked.

"There's a gathering. Kozlov is inviting some people, I guess. From his network. It's some kind of truce. A negotiation."

"A gathering."

"Amanda doesn't know much about it, other than that he'll be there, and potentially, so will all the people behind the jazz trade. All in one place for the first time."

"All in one place," Hirsch said, more to himself than to me. "Yes, I can see the merits of that. But she should have told me about this."

"She didn't know who to trust. She couldn't trust anyone."

Hirsch nodded, seeing the obvious wisdom in that.

"She was going to call it in, but only at the last second. Broadcast on all channels. The idea was that not everyone was dirty, so everyone would have to be on their best behavior. Or something. I don't really know."

"Sloppy, but effective. Okay, this is good. This is all very good, despite the means." He pulled out a notebook. "Now tell me, where is this party going to happen?"

"I NEARLY THREW UP. Right on his wing-tipped shoes. That dude is fucking intense."

"Look at you, casually dropping the F-bomb," Ty said. "We'll make a man out of you yet."

"Mostly, I'd rather have my life back."

We were chatting on burner phones. I was back at work, tucked away in yet another conference room by myself. Amanda wasn't answering her phone, but I needed to get that conversation off my chest. Which left Ty.

"You told him what was going on?"

"I did."

Ty was munching on something on the other end of the phone. I could hear the crunching over the line. He said, "Okay, good. In a couple days, you'll either get some version of your life back, or you'll possibly be dead."

"You know that's not reassuring, right?"

"Didn't intend it to be. Just laying out the stakes."

"Does Hirsch change anything?" I asked, moving beyond my friend's complete lack of empathy.

"He doesn't. You go aboard the yacht tomorrow night with Amanda. I'll be outside with the cavalry, waiting for your signal. You delay as long as possible, until all the players are aboard the ship. We rush in, extract you two, and get all the bad guys."

"Simple as that." My sarcasm bled through the phone. "What could possibly go wrong?"

As if in response to the question, my phone buzzed. I was beginning to hate incoming texts. This one was on the burner, which gave it a particularly heady charge.

Timeline's moved up. Party's tonight.

It was Amanda, and the text was to both me and Ty.

Can't talk now. At the boat.

Flexing arm.

"You see that?" Ty asked.

"Yeah."

"No plan survives—"

"First contact with the enemy," I finished. "We took that class together, remember? I just wasn't expecting it to fall apart *this* quickly."

"I'm surprised it lasted this long," he said. I could almost hear the shrug in his response. "Okay, dude, I need to jump off. Need to get hustling in order to be your backup."

"Get going, but remember to stay on standby. Wait for the signal. Not before."

"Copy that. You can count on me not to prematurely ejaculate all over your big operation."

I groaned. "Thanks for that image."

"Anytime. And if you end up riding on the sidelines, you can hang out with Mia and me."

"Just try to stay focused," I warned.

"You just told me not to prematurely—"

"I definitely didn't tell you anything that begins with that sentence. Now go. I need to take care of a few things, too."

I hung up, opened my laptop, and sent a message off to Javier. *Deletion needs to happen late tonight.*

I sat back, waiting for his response as I tried to sort through all the things that were going on—all our schemes, all of Kozlov's schemes. There was Julia to consider. Now there was Hirsch. At one point, Saturday had felt like a lifetime away—a lifetime to sort, a lifetime to get my act together. Now it was here, a day early.

Javier's message came through.

[Javier]: Sure thing, jefe. Oh, and I got that vid you wanted. Inc.

It wasn't a link, which I'd learned was dangerous, but a full on mp3.

[Me]: This safe? I responded.

[Javier]: Untraceable. Download it and watch.

[Me]: Did you?

[Javier]: Out of respect to you, I didn't. I saw the meta-data, too.

[Me]: Take care. Be safe. I'll be in touch when this is all over.

It was a hopeful thing to say, and I needed a little hope.

Looking at my watch, it was already nearly quitting time. The end game was measured in hours now. Soon, it would be minutes. I didn't have time to watch this video. I needed to get ready.

But come on, how could I resist?

THE FIRST VIDEO

The perspective was elevated, something hidden high in the recesses of Kozlov's office. I recognized the room from the first video that I'd ever watched—the maroon walls, the antique furniture, the Old World Soviet vibe. Only the angle was new. It was fixed.

Kozlov sat behind a large, dark wooden desk. He wore a blue shirt with one too many buttons undone, and a tailored sport coat. This was back when his hair was still long and full, loose curls of gray twisting around behind his ears. This was back when the world served him.

But the person sitting opposite him wasn't Amanda, as I was expecting. It was a younger guy that I didn't recognize. He was built like a boxer, with a thick neck and nose that looked shaped by another man's fist rather than nature. Despite that, he appeared to be Kozlov's equal, rather than an underling. Something in the way he carried himself, in the way the two spoke, in the way he leaned forward and tapped Kozlov's desk with an index finger the size of my thumb.

They were arguing in a language that I didn't recognize, but thought it was Russian. Definitely something Slavic, by the sound of it. Kozlov didn't look happy, and the man speaking with him seemed to have the upper hand. I scrubbed forward, stopping only as the man got up. He tugged at the lapels of his own expensive suit jacket. I heard Kozlov refer to the man as Ilyas, and then heard him say in English, "Enjoy the girls. They are at your disposal."

Ilyas didn't even bother to say goodbye. He strolled out of the office like it was his. Maybe it was. I still wasn't clear who really owned and operated The Gold Club, although clearly there were many threads that connected Kozlov to a greater network.

Once the door had shut, Kozlov made a fist and started to slam it onto his desk, stopping himself just short of the wood. He gnashed his teeth and muttered something in Russian before reaching into his desk. There, he slid out a round, mirrored plate and a baggie of now familiar white powder. I bet that Ilyas either didn't know about Kozlov's problem, or he did and was using it as leverage.

Kozlov glared at the door, made a rude gesture towards it, then started to cut up his lines.

A knock came just as he was snorting his first line. "Come," he said without bothering to hide the drugs.

That's when Amanda slipped inside. My breath caught, seeing her, despite the distance and the time. Her dress was transparent white lace that did nothing to cover the warm blue push-up bra or the matching thong.

She quickly glanced at the coke, then back at Kozlov, and said, "You wanted to see me, sir?"

"Come in, come in," he said, rubbing his nose and shaking his head as the chemical buzz hit him. The agitation he'd shown just a few minutes before sleuthed away, although the air still felt charged as I watched. "You are Raven, yes?"

"Yeah."

"And do you know who I am?"

"You're the boss."

That seemed to please Kozlov. This was their first meeting, I realized. "That is right. But please, call me Nick." He stood up, circling the desk until he was on her side of it. "You are very popular, Raven. I can see why."

He took a slow accounting of her scantily clad body before finishing on her face. "I just love the dark hair and blue eyes look."

"Thank you."

"You are being shy," he said. "This is not what I have heard about you."

Amanda actually blushed. I didn't know how she was able to do that so convincingly. "What have you heard about me?"

"That you are ambitious," he said, slowly approaching her. "That you are a fantastic dancer." Amanda didn't shy away as he moved up beside her. "That you know what it takes to get ahead."

The demure persona melted away. She reached out and ran a finger along his shirt, toying with the top button. "Is that my reputation?"

"You would like to dance VIP, yes?"

Her eyes were wide and vivid blue as she stared at him. "I would."

"It must be earned."

Watching it all, my heart raced. I knew what came next, and yet I was still on the edge of my chair with anticipation.

"I'm a hard worker," Amanda whispered, her voice breathy. She ran a hand down Kozlov's body, over the crotch of his pants. Her lips curled up into a smile. "Looks like you're also a hard worker."

Kozlov chuckled. He ran his hand up her back and into her long, silky hair. "Now that is more like it," he said. "Shy is not what I want. Shy is not what I need." He tightened his fist in her hair and yanked her head back. Amanda hissed, but didn't recoil. "Shy is boring."

"I'm not shy," she said. Her voice was strained as Kozlov kept pulling her hair. "Promise."

"Oh, I know." At last, he released her hair. When he did, she nearly stumbled forward. Kozlov turned, stalking back to his desk, where he threw himself into his

leather chair. "You've been turning tricks with some of the clientele here. You know we run a respectable establishment here."

Amanda sauntered over to the desk, perching on the edge of it, opposite Kozlov. She glanced at the coke and raised a brow. "Respectable, huh? This a bakery and that's the flour?"

Kozlov grinned at her. He picked up the short straw and spun it in his fingers before holding it out to her. "See for yourself."

"I'm still on my shift," Amanda said.

Kozlov continued to hold the straw out. "So?"

I could feel the hesitation, and if I could feel it, so could Kozlov. He'd lose interest. She'd lose her in. I saw the calculations she was making. I saw this final decision made, the line being crossed. This was the moment. Not the sex before. Not the lies that she told herself. It was this moment, right here, when she went too far, too deep. This was when she lost herself.

"You're the boss," she said, taking the straw from him.

Kozlov sat back in this chair, watching as Amanda carefully pulled her long, dark hair back so that he could watch her. I thought about how she'd told me that she'd done her best to minimize her exposure, to hide herself with her hair. There was no hiding here.

"I must confess," Kozlov said as Amanda lowered her face to the mirror and pushed the straw into her nostril. "I love beautiful women doing very bad things."

Amanda snorted the line of coke quickly, lifting her head up and away, her eyes closed as she touches her nose. It's an image that she would never be able to escape—FBI agent very clearly indulging in narcotics. They had her, if they wanted her. They had her when they *needed* her.

Kozlov had his cock out before the drug even hit her. "Do another," he ordered, starting to stroke his erection. I could just hear Amanda gasp and whisper, "Uh, fuck "

"It's good, yes?" His cock seemed to grow as he watched the corruption. "Now do another."

Amanda glanced at his dick and how he so unabashedly played with himself. "I can be your bad girl," she said. "I can be your fuck toy." She smirked, lowering back down to the coke. "I can be whoever you want me to be."

She snorted up the second line a little slower this time, letting Kozlov witness the moment.

"Well," he said, "you are not a narc."

"Maybe I'm a dirty one," Amanda responded.

Kozlov reached into his desk drawer and removed a pair of handcuffs. "Then you must be restrained."

"Kinky," Amanda said. Even with her back to the hidden camera, I knew she was smiling.

"Take off your clothes."

Kozlov continued to play with himself as Amanda shimmied out of the transparent dress. The bra went next, placed on the desk. When she doffed the thong, she bent at the waist as she pushed it down her long, shapely legs. I could see her smooth pussy peek out from between her thighs before she straightened.

He said something in Russian that I took to mean something like, "Exquisite." Then he held up the cuffs, and beckoned her over. She traipsed forward and turned her back to him, giving me an unobstructed view of her full-frontal beauty.

Kozlov rose behind her, and the cuffs went on with a loud ratchet. He pulled her hair to the side so he could kiss her neck, his hands reaching around to grope her from behind. Amanda sighed at his touch—not out of disgust, but out of desire.

He was gentle at first, palming her full tits in his hands, running his thumbs along her hardening nipples. Then he pinched them, twisting sharply. Amanda hissed in pain, but as before, remained standing in place.

"This is hard for you, yes?" he said. "You do not seem like someone who likes to be restrained."

"You hardly know me," Amanda said, glancing over her shoulder at him.

"You see? That is the kind of thing someone who does not like to be restrained would say." He trained his right hand down her flat stomach, teasing her mound. "You have never done cocaine before."

The non-sequitur threw her for a moment—but only a moment. "You don't know that. You don't know anything about me."

"This is true, I do not know you. But I know users. I can always tell someone's first time." He pressed his fingers to her clit, and she gasped. "There's nothing like the first time."

Amanda started to squirm. This had begun as a seduction, just like she'd done with the manager, Mark. She made it seem like her target was in control, but she never relinquished it. For the first time, watching her with Nikolai Kozlov, I saw the power dynamics shift.

"Feels good, yes? Your heart is racing. Everything around you feels more alive. More vivid." He pressed a finger inside of her. Amanda gasped, shutting her eyes and pulling against the cuffs. "Feel the hard metal of the handcuffs. Feel my hard cock press against your back."

Kozlov bent her over his desk, and without her hands to brace herself, she nearly collapsed, face-first.

I knew that this was in the past. I knew that so much had changed since this transgressive moment. Yet even still, my stomach knotted in jealousy. I felt bile rise. And, as always, those sensations were swiftly followed by shameful, white hot arousal.

"You want me to fuck you?"

"Yes," she hissed.

"You *expect* me to fuck you, yes?"

"Yes—"

He swatted her ass. "I think that you are a woman who is just now understanding how hot you are." He caressed the red mark where he'd spanked her. "I can tell this, too. It's all over your body language."

He touched her ass, tracing the raven tattoo on her lower back. Then he reached into his drawer again and removed a condom.

"Tear this open with your teeth," he said, holding the packet in front of her. She did as she was told. "Smell it. The latex. The spermicide. The promise of pleasure."

Amanda shuddered as she did it.

"Do you know why shy is boring?"

Amanda shook her head.

Kozlov rolled the condom down his length. "Too easy to break. Too easy to mold. And where's the fun in that, for either of us?"

As he pressed his cock into her, I swear that I saw something change in her eyes. This wasn't just a means to an end. This was a profound moment for her. This was her giving in to a journey that she hadn't known she was embarking on. It was a through line, right up to the present. She might not be Kozlov's cokewhore anymore, but she wasn't the same Amanda who had taken this UC assignment, either.

"You and I are going to have so much fun."

I sat there watching the rest of the video in a trance. There wasn't much more. Kozlov fucked her over his desk, finished in the condom. He then dismissed her with a casual cruelty that was most certainly intentional.

Afterward, alone in his office once more, he just sat at his desk and smiled to himself. His encounter with Ilyas was forgotten.

Or so I thought. The video kept rolling. I would have stopped it, but I was too busy: half-stunned, half-reflecting on Amanda's transformation.

There couldn't be any question that Amanda was, indeed, no longer the all-business, straight arrow, by-the-book agent she had been when she took this damned assignment. And whoever she had been in the weeks when she lost herself completely as "Raven," diving head-first into the role, into the debauchery it called for, she was clearly no longer living *that* "role," either.

And that was just it: "Raven" once again seemed to be a role Amanda played. One she excelled at. One she clearly enjoyed. But just that: a role. An aspect of her emerging self, not the foundation.

If anything those lost weeks seemed to have proven to be a chrysalis stage: transitional, chaotic, wherein "Old Amanda"—the parts of her that she had outgrown, were burned away, sloughed off, and transcended. And yet, "Raven," once arrived at, had been a stopping place, not a destination.

Thoughts of me, of our marriage, of our life together, even of Amanda's bedrock values, could be avoided, ignored under the roaring onslaught of transgressive overload, but only for a while.

Eventually, the core Amanda had emerged—no longer the person who followed rules for their own sake, nor the transgressive whore who gloried in public depravity for its own sake. Newborn and yet not so new. Changed and yet at her very center, not at all changed.

The Core Amanda.

Equal parts protector of the weak and exhibitionist sex goddess. Both my loving, devoted wife and a rampaging hedonist who loved showing off, especially for me. No longer the Old Amanda. No longer "Raven."

But now, and forever, irrevocably and unbreakably, still all *mine*.

Just as I remained every bit *hers*.

After all, my wife might have begun this journey of self-discovery alone, but she had readily made room for me, and together we had come so far—

The slam of a door jerked me out of my reverie. On the screen, Ilyas was back in the room, wagging a big finger at Kozlov. He pointed at the coke. He waved all about the room. I leaned in, turning the volume up as I listened to the men start to argue. I caught snippets—they mentioned jazz, they mentioned cocaine, they mentioned LA.

Unlike before, Kozlov was no longer agitated. He was more in control. He smirked at Ilyas and reached for the coke straw again, knowing it would set the man off. It did. The big man swept the mirror from the desk, sending a cloud of powder everywhere. The glass shattered. At last, Kozlov looked angry.

He said something I didn't understand. Ilyas responded, pointing his finger right at Kozlov, then moving it to his neck in the universal gesture of, *You are a dead man*.

Then, with cool and fluid precision, Kozlov pulled a pistol out of his drawer and pointed it at Ilyas's head.

"You wouldn't—"

He didn't even finish the sentence. The gun's muzzle flashed and Ilyas was falling backwards, his face an unrecognizable mess.

Kozlov stood up, rounded the desk, and prodded the big man with his foot. He didn't move. Then, as if remembering his own security footage, he glanced right at me. I knew he wasn't looking *at* me, of course, but seeing those cold eyes was frightening. This man had just murdered someone, and didn't seem scared or guilty. He was all business.

A moment later, he reached up behind the camera, and the video finally came to an end.

A LIFETIME IN MINUTES

She wore a short, denim jacket and a pair of tight jeans the first time she walked into Torts class. She surveyed the lecture hall, and when her eyes passed over me, my heart beat just a little faster. Her hair was shorter back then, dark and curling around her ears, just reaching her chin, but it was those bright, blue eyes that froze me. She was cool. I wanted to know more about her.

"Dibs," Ty said beside me.

No, she's too good for you, I thought to myself.

The brunette settled into the front of the class, alone, and pulled her laptop out of her bag.

"Good luck," I said instead.

Ty just laughed and patted my shoulder. "When did I ever need that?"

He got up and approached her. I envied that he could just do that.

"DEFENSE RESTS," Amanda said. Her gaze drifted over to me, full of challenge and competition. It was just a mock trial. It didn't mean anything. But I knew that I'd lost. Not just lost, but been completely humiliated. She'd anticipated every argument that I'd prepared, dismantling each one with references to case numbers and law.

Our professor turned to me and shrugged. He didn't even have to announce who'd won. I just laughed to myself, looked back across at Amanda, and nodded.

I had already fallen hard for her.

"ARE YOU ASKING ME OUT?"

"If I was, would you say yes?"

"I'd give you a chance, sure."

It felt like stepping into sunshine for the first time in my life.

I EMERGED FROM THE BATHROOM, pushing through the crowded bar, searching for Amanda. We'd just moved into our apartment in Northern Virginia, and we're still enjoying exploring the local bars and restaurants.

Amanda was still at the bar where I'd left her, but she wasn't alone anymore. The guy looked like a modern Viking—blond top knot, hair shaved on either side, beard. He was like Thor from that movie, and he was hitting on Amanda.

It wasn't the first time that I'd seen men hit on her. It had happened all the time before we'd started dating, and a few times since, when guys didn't think that we were together.

My chest tightened, just as it always did. Insecurity and jealousy rose up through me like wood smoke from my own funeral pyre.

And then she looked at me, sensing me out there. Turning, Amanda found me across the room and smiled. The guy continued trying to chat her up, but she wasn't listening. She picked up her beer—and mine—and left him there at the bar, mid-sentence. She was smiling at me the whole way.

"WE DON'T HAVE to talk about it anymore—" I began, but Amanda pulled back and stopped me.

She was smiling. Her tears weren't ones of sadness or regret. "Yes," she said.

"What?"

"Yes, I'll marry you."

It was like hearing a choir of angels. I went from the depths of despair to being lifted up to the heavens. Tears sprang to my own eyes. "Really?"

Amanda had gotten herself under control. She wiped her tears away and fixed her eyes on me. "Really, if you're *really* sure."

"I will always support you, Amanda. I will always be there for you."

"You know what?" She sniffled and laughed all at once. "I believe you. That's what scares me."

"Don't be scared." I smiled, kissing her lips. "Like I said, you can be happy "

"THEY WANT ME TO GO UNDERCOVER." Amanda looked nervous. Really nervous. Nervous like she was going to be sick. Here was a woman who'd been through some hard times and had seen her share of horrors. She wasn't easily shaken.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. A new assignment that came up here, in L.A. And it's it's for a while." She rarely spoke like this. Rarely spoke in halted, stilted sentences. I was worried.

"What's a while mean?"

"Three months. Maybe. Could be less."

My heart fell. That would be the longest time we'd been apart since we got together. But she wouldn't be bringing this up if it wasn't important. "You want to do it."

She nodded. "I can't let Miami happen again. Or "

Her mother. She didn't need to say it, and rarely brought it up. "You need to follow it all the way through."

Amanda winced. I didn't know what that meant at the time, but even in hindsight, after all that I knew, I would have said the same thing.

"Then do it. I'll always be here for you."

AMANDA REACHED out and traced the line of my collarbone. When I didn't instantly dissolve under her touch, but rather, leaned into it, she began running her hands along my body, like she was still expecting me to vanish.

"Guess that's the thing about dreams—we can't control them, as much as we try. You know I never wanted to get married?" Amanda touched me as she spoke, a reminder that I was still there.

We were in her apartment—*Raven's* apartment. I was spinning.

"Ouch. What a thing to say—"

"I never wanted to get married until I met *you*. You didn't figure into my plans." She laughed at herself. "And I'm so glad that I decided to take that detour."

"So is that what this is? A detour?" I asked.

"Yes." She rose over me, straddling my body. I wasn't hard, but I wasn't soft, either, and her smooth mound felt wonderful against my cock. "I will come back to you. And I cannot wait to tell you all the naughty things I've been up to with Raven."

"You'll tell me everything?"

"Everything."

"Do what you need to do. Fuck who you need to fuck. Just remember that I'm here, I'm your partner."

She bounced on my cock.

"And you don't need to do any of this alone. Okay?"

When the heat of the moment passed, Amanda was still there, snuggling close. "I cannot predict the future, and this whole assignment, like dreams, cannot

always be controlled. But remember this moment, whenever you're having doubts. Okay?"

"Okay."

I STOOD before the mirror and barely recognized myself. My hair was still tightly cropped, and my scruff had grown into something thicker. I'd never had a beard, and while it itched like hell, it definitely fit my tough guy look. So did the tight, black t-shirt and black jeans.

I had to admit that all the time I'd spent in the gym these last few months, killing time and trying not to think about whatever Amanda was doing undercover, had paid off. My arms were larger than they'd ever been, stretching the short sleeves of my shirt, and my pecs filled out my chest.

I could almost imagine Amanda coming up behind me, running her hands up under my shirt and teasing my pecs. *Can I keep you?* I imagined her saying.

Always. Always.

But Amanda wasn't here. She was on that coked-out, murdering psychopath's yacht. And there, she was Raven.

"Time to go," I said to myself. "Time to finish this."

PARTY TO END ALL PARTIES

A month ago, I'd never been inside a strip club before. I'd entered the Gold Club wide-eyed and blushing, a country tourist walking through the streets of a glitzy, towering city. I was awkward. I was out of my element.

As I stepped into the main cabin of *Dominion*, the massive, two-level yacht in slip 69, I was no longer that awkward tourist. The lights were low. Hip hop infused the charged atmosphere. Smoke swirled in the glittering lights. Plush leather chairs clustered through the space, each occupied but a man getting a lap dance from a different stripper.

It felt like stepping into a den of sin. My senses were overloaded with it—the sounds, the smells, the visuals. “Champagne?” someone asked.

When I turned to her and lifted a flute of bubbly from the silver platter, I realized that she was wearing a leather, BDSM mask, only her mouth and eyes visible. Beyond that, she wore nothing but leather straps that left her breasts bare and just barely concealed her slit.

The old David would have been left with his mouth open and his heart racing. Now, I grinned at the server, raised the flute in a toast, and said, “Thank you,” with a wink and a lingering gaze over her chest.

“Find me if you want another,” she said, rubbing her hand along my chest before moving on.

All the servers were dressed in some version of that, men and women alike—the gimp masks, the bondage gear, the near nudity. It gave the makeshift strip club a fetishy vibe that Nikolai must have been going for.

Speaking of the man, though, I didn't see him in my quick scan. I did recognize a few others. Sammy 9Pole was there with a few others from his gang, including his buddy Deion. The DJ spinning records worked at the Gold Club, and I recognized some of the dancers.

I spotted Irina through the crowd, grinding on some Slavic looking guy who was all neck and shoulders. The platinum blond stripper was dressed as a “mermaid”—aquamarine sequin bra top, a pair of skin-tight, sequined pants that

flared into bell bottoms—her tail, presumably. The pants were so thin I could easily see her thong through them, and even as I watched, she laid back on her man, bridged her tight little body up, and shimmied out of those close-fitting pants.

I didn't gawk. I didn't stand frozen at the entrance. I entered smoothly, nodding at people I didn't know, as if I belonged. They nodded back. I let the music flow through me, fueling the swagger in my shoulders and my step. I sipped the champagne. I pulled a bacon-wrapped date off of a passing platter—this one wielded by a man in a mask, a collar, and a leather thong.

Windows flanked either side of the luxury cabin, and for one disorienting moment, I wondered if I'd been drugged. The yachts on either side started to shift and move. The deck beneath me lurched. Then it dawned on me. We were moving. The *Dominion* was casting off.

That wasn't part of the plan.

"Jasmine?" a familiar female voice asked. I turned. Despite the mask obscuring her pretty features, I knew that voice. Mia and her dark, alluring eyes were staring back at me, her lips painted red. Her mask only covered the top half of her face, like a cowl, leaving her long, dark hair flowing around her shoulders.

I started to say her name, but she spoke over me before I could. "It's the latest synthetic variation," she explained. "JazzX. Those here on the boat are the lucky ones who get to try it first."

She picked one of the little pills off the platter. It was a deeper shade of purple than those I'd seen Brandon flash. "Stronger than the original. More addictive, too." She handed it to me, leaning close to whisper, "Do not, under any circumstances, take it."

Before I could respond, the music spun down into a low, bass-heavy drone. Every head in the place turned toward the front of the cabin, where a spiral stairwell led down from the upper decks. There he was, Nikolai Kozlov holding court. He was no longer the smug criminal with the nice hair that I'd seen in the video just a few hours earlier. But he wasn't the desperate, hunted fugitive from Del Ray's Motor Lodge, either.

He'd cleaned himself up. He still sported a graying scruff where his beard once was, but it looked more manicured than before. His shaved head glistened under the lights. In his tailored gray suit, he looked the part of a man forged anew.

And just behind him walked Amanda.

My heart skipped a beat. She wore a short, skin tight vinyl dress, the kind of dress that was completely unforgiving of any flaws. As the lights caught in the glossy, black vinyl, I couldn't see any. Not outward. It plunged so low that half of her breasts were exposed, full, juicy swells of tanned flesh, and was short enough that it didn't conceal the dark bands at the tops of her black stockings, or the garter straps that held them in place.

But it was the collar that drew and held my attention. Black leather, cinched around her neck, with a leash that drooped lazily between Amanda and Kozlov. She followed obediently now, but would have to follow even if she didn't want to.

Kozlov paused at the bottom of the stairs. Amanda stopped just short of him, standing with her hands behind her back and her head lowered in subservience. It was a strange thing to see on her.

"Thank you all for coming," Kozlov said, his accent thick and his confidence apparently fully back. "Rumors of my demise have been " He couldn't seem to remember the end of the saying. "...whatever the fuck. I am still *fucking* here!" Okay, so that sounded a little unhinged. "This is my peace offering." He gestured to either side, as the marina gave way to the bay beyond. "Literally water underneath us, yes? After all, we have money to make."

I looked over at Sammy and his crew. They didn't look abashed or worried about the shifting of the winds. Sammy just leaned back in his chair, puffing at a cigarette as the guys around him grinned and nodded.

But it also wasn't Sammy that Kozlov seemed to direct most of his attention to. That was reserved for a small cluster of well-dressed men sitting a bit apart, off to Kozlov's left.

These guys were a varied lot. Some with short hair, a couple of shaven heads, yet to a man olive skinned, deep-set eyes, everyone sporting a beard of some length.

And not a smiling face among them.

The Chechens were in attendance. And the tension that ran between them and Kozlov was positively palpable.

"It is so rare to have everyone here in one place, no? A family reunion. Why do we gather?"

He glanced at one of the servers, who carried a platter of the purple pills. She hustled over to him, bare breasts bouncing. He plucked a pill off the platter and held it up. "We gather for this. A new dawn. The last few months were an experiment. This is the result. It is not just some party drug. It is not just something for stupid kids and clubs. This is the next big thing."

Mia, still near me, whispered, "It's also addictive as fuck."

"With this, with Jazz X the fun does not stop," he said. He tugged at the leash, and Amanda stepped up next to him. He lifted the pill before her, and she opened her mouth and stuck her tongue out, like a patient ready for an examination. He placed the pill on her tongue. "And why the fuck would we want the fun to stop?"

Their eyes were locked on one another, like for those two, nothing else mattered in that moment. It was a hard thing to watch. Amanda closed her mouth, and I wondered if she was swallowing the drug—had she already done some? Kozlov dragged her closer with the leash, pulling her in for a deep, passionate kiss. She welcomed it, kissing him back, pressing her curves against him.

We all watched the two. Some grinned and murmured appreciation. Others shifted. No one spoke. Kozlov, for all his faults, knew how to command a room.

When the kiss ended, Kozlov looked up. "What is everybody staring at? This is a party. Time to party!"

That broke the tension. The DJ cranked the volume. The sultry lyrics of Cardi B flooded the space as the dancers started to twist and grind in mens' laps. Kozlov whispered something into Amanda's ear. I followed their eyes over to the Chechens. The connection? The greater network?

Everyone was here. It was time to call in the cavalry. Only one problem: that cavalry couldn't cross water, and when I looked out those windows, the marina was now just a glittering blur of lights on the far, dark shore. Fuck.

Irina appeared at the foot of the stairs. She hadn't bothered putting her mermaid pants back on, but wore the scale-patterned thong and bra. Kozlov handed the leash to her and whispered something to her. Irina flicked her platinum locks away from her face and grinned before literally leading Amanda over to the knot of Chechens.

I turned to look at Mia, but she was already gone, circulating through the crowd. Apparently after the big reveal, everyone wanted to try the next big thing.

That's when I started to lose my cool. I'd thought that I had it all under control. I'd expected this to be over by now, to be sitting in a police car as bad men were arrested and taken away all around us. Now, I didn't know what to do other than watch Amanda and hope that she had some plan.

Despite the danger, despite all the fear racing through my veins, it was still nauseatingly hot to watch her step with such confidence into the ring of men. I was too far away to hear anything that was said, but she greeted them all with a seductive openness that would have looked surprising on Old Amanda, but was part of who she was now.

One of the guys said something. The others laughed. Irina pulled on the leash, drawing Amanda close to her. *"This what you want to see?"* I'm pretty sure Amanda asked them.

There were nods. I almost nodded. And then, in slow motion, Amanda turned to Irina, rested her hands on the other woman's hips, and turned her head in for a kiss. Before their lips even touched, their mouths were parted, tongues unfurling, ready to tangle.

I wondered if Irina was involved somehow. I didn't remember seeing her name in any of the meta data, but that just meant that she wasn't a person of interest. Kozlov's criminal network spanned more than what was in those files.

The guy sitting in the center of the group stood up. He looked like a rugby player, his wavy dark hair and short beard nondescript, thick with muscle and a comfortable lifestyle. He was probably around our age, no older than early thirties. He had a ring on every finger except for his thumbs.

He moved up behind Amanda as she continued her girl-on-girl makeout session with Irina. His fingers glided over her vinyl dress, a jeweler appraising a fine diamond. He kissed her long neck, causing her to pull away from Irina long enough to turn and meet his mouth over her shoulder. Irina watched from inches away, her eyes glittering. She pulled the top of Amanda's dress aside, exposing an erect nipple, and dipped low to capture it in her mouth.

For a moment, I thought they were going to have sex right there in the room. It wouldn't have been too crazy. Looking around, it seemed like the JazzX was already permeating the scene. The strippers were mostly naked now. Some were on their knees between men's legs. Others were just outright fucking.

Amanda's group didn't join them in the public exhibition. Instead, Irina passed the leash to the guy with the rings. She gave Amanda one last kiss before disappearing back into the crowd. The men all rose, and as one, led Amanda towards the stairs that led into the cabins above.

"They are a bunch of motherfuckers." Kozlov's voice startled me, as did the arm that he immediately draped over my shoulder.

"Who are they?" I asked.

"Dogs who think that they are the masters." Clearly, Kozlov didn't like the bunch much. "They should be the ones wearing the leash."

I fought to get my breathing back down to something normal. "So why aren't they?"

"Because the trap only works when they think that they are in charge." His arm over my shoulder tightened. "You know something about this, don't you David?"

My heart caught when he used my full name—not that the alias was ever all that good.

"I what?"

"Good. You did not scream like frightened child. I admire you, Dave the Muscle." He chuckled. "Or is it Davey? What do you prefer?"

Fuck. Fuck! Everything tunneled around me. I wondered if I'd taken that drug after all. I wondered if I was going to pass out. My heart felt like it was trying to rip itself out of my chest. I heard him talking, but I couldn't make sense of it.

"...really had me convinced, but I knew that I recognized you." He gave me one last, tight squeeze, then let me go. "Come, this, down here, is not where the real party is. For you, David, I will give you the tour, yes? Let us go and check in on your wife, if that is really who she is."

He gestured towards the stairs. I looked around, wondering in my panic if I could run. But where would I run? We were in the middle of the fucking ocean now. I looked for Mia, trying to identify her in the swath of black leather hoods and taut flesh. No luck.

So I did my best to square my shoulders and went, stumbling towards the circular stairwell like ascending the gallows. Was that what this was? Were these my final steps in this life?

"What's going on?" I managed to ask, in an effort to buy myself some time.

"Your wife tells me that you like to watch. You and I are similar in that way."

"We are nothing alike." If this was to be my last act, I wasn't going to go down being debased like this.

"Now, now, *David*, there is no sense in denying it. It is nothing to be ashamed of. It does not make you less of a man." He pounded his chest. "It is no different than showing off a new car, or wearing an expensive suit."

"She's not a possession."

"All women are. All *people* can be. Your wife, in fact, *wants* to be."

As I stepped up into the top deck of the yacht, I briefly considered turning around and kicking him hard, sending him rolling backwards. But the ladder led onto the bridge, where men in black piloted the yacht through the dark waters. They turned to look at me. All of them were armed with angry looking SMGs. My brief thought to resist died as quickly as it was born.

"I knew you looked familiar that day you came to the motel. I thought to myself, 'There is no way this man is bodyguard,' but I was not of right mind then."

Like you are now? I thought to myself.

"But then, when I learned about your wife, of who she really was, it all clicked." He snapped his fingers behind me. I flinched at the sound. It was

unnerving, having him behind me. He prodded me towards the stern. A short passageway extended the length of the ship, all the doors closed.

"When I confronted her, she did not deny it, or who you were. This is how I know we are the same. You are smart. You are strong. And you like watching your woman being filthy."

The passway was bathed in red light, and behind at least one of those doors, I could hear the sounds of sex.

"I know it was you in the Living Room. You watched your own wife do some very unfaithful things—things she continues to do. Things that she will *always* do. There is no going back from this, *David*."

Despite everything, his words insinuated themselves into the dark recesses of my mind, where my fears and insecurities whispered. This was what kept me up at night. This was what I worried about when the dust of these past few months finally settled.

Kozlov paused at the last door on the hall—the main bedroom suite of the yacht. He slapped me on the back, but left his hand there, gripping my shoulder. "Maybe you are right, *David*. You and I are *not* alike. You are sheep. I am wolf. Isn't that how you Americans say it?"

"I am not a sheep."

"We shall see."

I could hear a woman's moan behind that door, and more than a few men, foreign voices, a rhythmic creaking. "Go on," Kozlov said, eager to inflict more humiliation. "See for yourself."

I pushed open the door, and the scene was already in full swing. A wall of sex and sound hit me—the moans, the grunts, the driving beat of angry death metal.

The captain's cabin was all polished wood and gold fixtures, and like the hallway behind us, was filled with soft, ambient red light, like a brothel. The horizon slid by outside. It opened into an aft balcony, where the frothing wake was just visible in the dark waters beyond.

My wife was there, but her dress wasn't. She was now completely naked save for a black leather garter belt, stockings, heels, and that collar. She was sitting on the edge of the bed, surrounded by naked men, servicing one of them as she jerked off another two. The raven tattoo danced. My breath caught.

Just behind her, on the bed, was a tangle of bouncing body parts, another mini-scene of bondage and domination. Bound to the bed, her wrists strapped to the posts, her legs splayed wide open, was Julia. The man with the rings was pounding her hard. Another was straddling her face, ramming his cock down her throat.

I was confused until Kozlov said, "Say hello to Gillian? Or do you call your wife Julia at home?"

The guy with his cock buried down Julia's throat pulled out, letting her gasp and breath and moan for air. "You made it, my *husband*," she said, her voice hoarse.

"Julia " My shock didn't need to be feigned. Kozlov thought that *we* were the couple, not my wife.

My eyes flicked over to Amanda. The man at the center had taken hold of her leash and was forcing her to move from cock to cock, taking a single thrust down

the throat from each one. Her gags were both hot and jarring all at once.

"Told you she loved it," Kozlov said. Before I knew it, I was being guided into a chair in the corner. Kozlov didn't even bother restraining me. He just left me there, stunned, as he started to get undressed. "I have not had her yet," he said to me. "I was saving that particular experience for when you got to watch. Fun, yes?"

The man fucking Julia bucked one last time and seemed to come, grunting loudly, uttering something I couldn't understand. He pulled free and flopped onto the bed, facing the ceiling, his dick still sheathed in the now overloaded condom.

"Clean him," Kozlov said.

Amanda pulled away from the blowbang, although her hands continued to stroke the two cocks as the third man tapped his dick against her cheek. "Nicky, you made it." Her eyes didn't look glazed or drugged. If anything, she seemed on fire. She glanced at me and smiled. "And you brought David."

"I thought it would be a nice gesture, letting him say goodbye to his loving wife."

Amanda snickered at that. "I'd like to say goodbye to him," she said. "Will you let me?"

Glancing at Kozlov, I watched his jaw set, his eyes flare, his chest swell just so. I knew that sensation. I'd been living it for weeks now. I'd probably live with it for the rest of my life. Jealous angst. Cuckold angst. Angst that I'd begun to crave. With an addict like Kozlov, he couldn't resist. This was how Amanda had controlled him so well.

"I will, pet," he said. "But first, clean him."

The "him" in question was the man with the rings, and Amanda did so without further question. She crawled over to the Chechen, who was lounging with a tattooed arm behind his head and a smile stretched across his face.

"You know who gave you up, right?" Kozlov said. "Have you figured it out?"

"No " I was a man who didn't want to believe the truth.

Except that I did know the truth. We'd discussed it. Kozlov had said it himself: *the trap only works when they think that they are in charge*. If he thought that Amanda had betrayed everyone, he would never suspect that he was the one being betrayed.

We watched the action—Amanda pulling off the condom and sucking one man's flagging dick as another rolled a condom on and mounted Julia's splayed legs.

Kozlov continued, slowly stroking his own semi-hard dick as he watched. "At first I was very upset. I trusted her. How could she be one of *them*. But then I realized something. It was the ultimate form of trust—of her in me, and me in her. She gave herself up to me. She *chose* me, this lifestyle, this world."

"Mmm, yes, I did," Amanda purred, lifting her head from the man's cock. All the other men had condoms on now. Things were about to get even more spicy. To one, Amanda said, "Are you going to just stand there? Or are you go to fuck me?"

All the guys chuckled. My stomach churned and that cuckold angst flared. Two guys had to fight to move into place behind her. She gasped as the winner rammed home.

"You see, why get paid a government wage and toil away, day after day, when they could have this?" Kozlov finished by taking a snort at a vial of white powder that he'd picked up from the sideboard. The man fucking Julia came hard, and was quickly replaced by a third. "I'll fuck her after everyone else has her at least once. More fun that way, yes? Then, *maybe* you can reclaim her."

He chuckled at the word, picking up on at least one of the layers of irony here.

I could have left. No one was stopping me. There was no guard at the door. I wasn't bound to the chair. Not by anything physical. But I *couldn't* leave, and the Russian *knew* that I couldn't. He just didn't realize who I was there to watch.

The man inside of Amanda yanked on her leash, pulling her head back. She gasped, lifting off and away from the man with the rings, who was once again hard. He sat up, attacking Amanda's tits as the guy behind her choke-fucked her. I wanted to rush to her rescue, but her moans told me that she was into it.

Kozlov moved to her side, getting a closer look as she fucked these two men. I burned with envy as he leaned in and kissed her like he owned her.

"These two come as package deal," Kozlov said to me. "But did you know that they hate each other?" He whispered something to Amanda, who giggled and nodded. Kozlov took her leash and guided her to Julia, who was in the throes of yet another orgasm. "Sometimes, hate is the ultimate aphrodisiac."

Amanda leaned down, grabbed a handful of Julia's blond hair, and dragged her in for a wild kiss. The man fucking Julia went hard at the sight of the two women going at it. He didn't last long. When he finished and pulled free, Amanda climbed over and started to gyrate her pussy against Julia's face.

I could see Julia's tongue dance along Amanda's smooth slit before Amanda leaned forward and started to return the favor.

Kozlov grinned at the lesbian show. He was moving up to the headboard, behind Amanda, stroking his cock, now at full length. "Yes, Ray, smother her. Make her work for it." To me: "When this is all over, I am going to enjoy these two. There's nothing like a little competition."

In position, Kozlov thrust forward. Amanda gasped, lifting off of Julia's pussy. Her chin was glistened. Her eyes fluttered shut. The fourth man of the group waddled in between Julia's open legs, sheathed dick hard and ready. That's when I realized that Kozlov wasn't wearing one. He was fucking Amanda bare.

I hissed, clutching the armrests of the chair as the room around me sweltered and smeared. I suspected that he was using her like that, wanting the skin on skin, but here, at last, was proof, and it burned through me like phosphorus.

The man fucking Julia didn't last long. Not with Amanda right there, tugging at his balls, or raising up and kissing him hard on the mouth.

"Fuck me in the ass," she said to Kozlov as the fifth man swapped in. "I want to feel it again."

I want to feel it one last time? Was that what she really was asking? The thought further inflamed me. I tugged at my pants, unleashing my dick. Kozlov grinned. "Now you're getting into the spirit."

The orgy continued. Men crowded around Amanda and Julia. "Oh, fuck!" Amanda gasped as Kozlov pressed into her asshole. "Fuck, that's so mmm "

Even distracted by the anal sex, Amanda was aware of the men around her. She reached out, grabbing dicks, stroking them. They groped her tits, and played with Julia's. The women were swallowed up in a pile of sweating, pumping, grunting men.

I sat and watched, slowly jerking off and hating myself for loving this scene.

Through the haze, through the sea of men, I'd catch a flash of Amanda staring back at me like some kind of majestic, woodland creature glimpsed through the trees. She may have been fucking these other men, Kozlov may have thought that she was his, but we both knew that she was there with me.

Things shifted a final time. Julia's wrists were finally unbound. She was flipped onto her hands and knees as Kozlov moved behind her. He looked over at me, triumphant. He still didn't get it. He never would.

"Watch me. Know what you are losing." He rammed into Julia, who moaned.

I caught sight of Amanda again, pushing a damp strand of hair over her ear. She disengaged from the group and approached me, swinging her hips and smiling. She was drenched in sweat. Red marks covered her body where she'd been pinched and slapped. Beneath the collar, her skin was pink. But she owned it all. She was here, in control.

"Hope you're enjoying yourself, David," she said. "Hope you're not too upset to see your woman get gangbanged."

I looked behind her. Someone had a fist of Julia's hair in his hand, yanking her towards his dick.

"Not upset at all."

Amanda dropped to her knees before me. "Yeah, kind of satisfying, isn't it?"

With her blue eyes never leaving mine, she started to blow me. I'd held out too long. I wouldn't last much longer. Amanda knew. She produced a condom and rolled it on with her mouth. Even watching that made me pop.

"You need to fuck her," she said, rising over me again. "You need to make that bitch scream."

But Julia was already screaming—as much as she could with *two* dicks stuffed in her mouth. Kozlov spanked her as she climaxed, emptying his balls into her used pussy.

He pulled out with a flourish, finger in the air, dick swinging between his thighs. "Cuck's turn!"

"Go," Amanda mouthed.

Julia waited for me, face down, ass up, panting hard. The men parted around me. I could feel their pity. I didn't share it. Amanda also watched, riveted, her breathing shallow. If she could do this for me, I could do it for her.

"Uh!" Julia gasped.

"Try and reclaim her," Kozlov taunted. "She will never be yours again."

I tried to block him out, but he was there, stoking my fears all over again. I looked for Amanda, watching her move in the periphery of the room. She crouched down beside Kozlov's discarded clothing, retrieved his pistol, and released the clip. She was so slick about it, popping the one in the chamber without a sound.

"She is my toy now, David. Let this be your final thought."

I could feel my climax building in my balls, lights flashing in a blaze all around me. I shut my eyes, seeing not Julia, but Amanda—dancing at the club, seducing other men, going to their beds and not leaving until morning. I realized that maybe I didn't want it to end here. That was my final thought.

Reality rushed up around me. I pulled out of Julia, ripped off the condom, and exploded all over her back. Amanda was there, finished with whatever she'd been doing. No one was the wiser.

"Hope you enjoyed that," Kozlov said.

"Really?"

"No, not really." He threw my clothes at me. "Get dressed. We continue your tour."

I glanced back at the room, the orgy. It wasn't over now that we were leaving. No, Amanda was now being cuffed to the bed by Julia, and fear sizzled through me. If she was restrained, it meant that I was truly on my own.

"Tick tick, David," Kozlov said. "We have much less time than you realize."

I got dressed.

FINALE

“I’d like to show you something fun,” Kozlov said. He led me down a service ladder, the tight quarters descending two decks below, into the bowels of the yacht. I could hear the thrum of the engines down here, loud and unmuffled.

“Where are we going?” The hairs were beginning to stand up on the back of my neck. This was it. This was the end.

Kozlov prodded me downward, and now I could feel the muzzle of his gun pressed between my shoulders. Games were over. “You know what I think is bullshit?” he said.

“Integrity in US law enforcement organizations?”

He didn’t even bother laughing at my own nervous joke. “Second chances.”

“But I thought what about your speech about water under the bridge and all that?”

“This is a yacht, David. This is not a fucking bridge.” When I glanced back at him, it was like glancing into a maelstrom of madness. “Also, I fucking lied. All these fuckers are dead to me.”

We’d arrived at the lower deck. The space was small. Sounds of the ship creaked around us.

“Dead? What?”

“Open the hatch.”

The hatch was designed to be watertight, needing a large wheel to open. I turned it. It swung open smoothly. The engine noises roared louder.

“Go on in.”

I entered. Kozlov followed, but only to the entrance of the engine room, where he remained, framed in the hatchway, gun casually pointed at me from his hip.

At first, I didn’t know what I was looking at. There was machinery everywhere, humming and chugging as the yacht pushed out into the water. It smelled of diesel and oil. Something else I couldn’t place. There were large oil drums everywhere, and on each, a box with flashing lights and wires running to the drum below.

It dawned on me what I was seeing. Bombs. So many bombs.

"This isn't a party to celebrate the new drug, or your return to this world " I said. "This is revenge."

"Can't it be both, David?" Kozlov said, leaning on the steel edge of the hatchway. "There certainly is a new drug—"

"But how? Oleg is in prison."

Kozlov only looked mildly put out at the interruption. He was taking more delight in the explanation. "You didn't hear? Oleg Kuznetsov has been released on a technicality. Something to do with inept paperwork."

That didn't sound likely. Not under Hirsch.

"But Oleg has been working on this new strain for some time now. More addicting than the original, yet less out of control." He smiled. "Like the new me."

"If you kill everyone on board, you kill your network."

Kozlov sighed. "A 'network' that tried to eliminate me? A 'network' that will turn on me as soon as they have the chance? A 'network' of fools who seems to think that *I* am the problem just because of a little cocaine habit?!"

He was screaming by the end, spittle on his lips, his anger ricocheting off the metal walls around us.

"You know what's great about this? Once I kill all of these people " He opened his free hand, palm up like the statement was a simple offering. "...I can build a new group, peopled with more compliant types, who will think twice when it comes to crossing me."

His logic didn't quite line up, but this man was also coked out of his skull. In his world, he was the mastermind.

I took a deep breath. The bombs around me were unnerving. Their lights blinked in unison, a slow, threatening reminder of how close I was to fiery death. Glancing beyond Kozlov, I said, "You get all that?"

"Yeah, I got it." Hirsch's voice emerged from the darkness of the passageway behind Kozlov.

Startled, the Russian half-turned in the direction of the new voice, only to be met by the butt of a pistol crashing down on his head. He fell to the deck like a ragdoll, his gun clattering away from him as he fell.

The sudden violence took me by surprise. I began to back away as Bradley Hirsch stepped over Kozlov's unconscious body.

"What the fuck?" I said, staring at Mr. FBI, Mr. By-the-Book, who'd just brained an unaware man.

Hirsch looked as pristine and unruffled as he always did on television. He even wore a dark suit and a tie like he was about to step in front of some cameras, even here in the bowels of this ship. Not a single stray strand of graying hair escaped the prison of his well-combed demeanor.

"You did well, David. I couldn't have asked for better with any of my other agents. You got the perfect confession for this crime. Something I can use when I leak it to the news agencies later this week. Something that will explain the tragic explosion aboard the *Dominion*. Unfortunately, there were no survivors, and Nikolai Kozlov himself got caught in the blast."

"How what? But your agents?"

"All served their country with honor and integrity. They died to make the world a safer place. We were just too late with the tactical teams. The explosion happened prematurely."

"You did this?"

"You really think that *Nikolai Kozlov*," he said the man's name with such derision, "had the wherewithal to scare up all of this?" He gestured to the drums. "The man was out-of-control, and had outlived his usefulness. All of you have. He did do one really excellent thing, though." Hirsch placed a hand on the wheel lock and began to pull on the hatch. "He managed to get all the relevant players together in one place. Well, with some help from me."

"You ordered the agents to go undercover as wait staff."

"The bondage hoods were a nice touch, don't you think?" He chuckled. "Kozlov wanted revenge. I just want a clean slate."

"What about your career? This many agents getting snuffed on one of your exercises, and you take the fall."

"Yeah," Hirsch shook his head in mock sorrow. "I'll fall on my sword, take early retirement. Promise to spend the rest of my days mourning all of you and celebrating your sacrifice." He could look awfully sincere, even when I knew he was being false.

"Just kidding!" He brightened. "About the 'mourning' thing, not the 'retirement'. Besides, I'll be too busy for fieldwork. Me and good old Oleg are going to make a metric *fuckton* of cash." He glanced at Kozlov, prostrate on the deck, and now bleeding from his ear. "And as for *this* useful idiot, he was right about one thing. Networks are so easy to rebuild. All it takes is money."

He started to close the hatch when I held up my hand. "One problem," I said. "I'm sorry, but maybe you didn't hear yet."

Hirsch cocked his head at me, looking, for the first time, confused. "Hear what?"

"Oh, that your money's gone?"

"What are you talking about?"

I glanced at my watch. "Yup, all gone. So are the videos, actually. Obliterated."

Watching the realization of what he had just suffered—and at the hands of a lowly civilian such as "The Husband," no less—wash over Hirsch's face was delightful. Almost made me forget about the gun he held at his side. "What are you—"

"You get that?" I asked for the second time, directing my attention over his shoulder.

"Got it," Amanda said.

"Crystal clear," Julia added as she pressed the muzzle of her Glock purposefully against the spot on Hirsch where his spinal column met the base of his brain. Hirsch slowly raised his hands, letting his own pistol dangle from his forefinger by its trigger guard. After disarming him Julia made quick work of slamming her erstwhile boss and rolling him up against the bulkhead. "God, I want to choke him out so badly."

"Yeah, probably better not," Amanda said.

I only half-registered what they were saying. All of the adrenaline pumping through my veins finally gave out. I nearly fell like a marionette whose strings

had been suddenly cut.

"We need him—oh, watch it there, my husband." Amanda was there, catching me before I fell, holding me in a tight, strong embrace. "I'm here, I'm here," she was saying, holding me close, smoothing her hands through my hair. "And you did so well, baby. So fucking well."

"I don't know how you do this," I said. "I feel like puking."

Amanda giggled. "You don't think that's how I feel, like, 90 percent of the time?"

"You do?"

"Nah. I mostly try not to think too much about it."

Somewhere above decks, there came a loud *WHOOMP*. I cringed, thinking that the bombs were going off. The sound was followed by shouting, a commotion. Julia had a walkie out. "Down below. Engine room. Situation is contained, but requesting backup and medical staff."

I glanced at the bombs. "What about those?"

"They're not real." Amanda paced over to one of them, reached out, and yanked on the wires. It happened so fast that I didn't even have time to flinch. The lights all blinked one last time, then went dark. "We weren't going to bring a literal ton of explosives aboard a ship filled with civilians."

"I thought we said no more secrets?" I asked, but I was smiling in relief.

"That was my idea," Julia said. "Thought it would be more authentic if you believed they were real."

Ty arrived on the scene, dressed in SWAT gear, his weapon out. "Jesus H. Christ!" he barked, taking in the scene. Behind him were a couple of Coast Guard Rapid Response Team agents in the stairwell, although the space was too small for them to enter.

Julia passed Hirsch to Ty. Amanda retrieved both Hirsch's and Kozlov's dropped weapons. "Things secured above?"

"Just as planned," Ty said with a nod. "You know there's a room full of naked, unconscious bearded dudes in the master cabin?"

"The pretty boys just couldn't keep up," Julia said.

"Never trust this one," I said to Ty.

"And yet you trusted me enough to call me." Julia winked. She moved over to Kozlov, feeling for a pulse. "He's alive, but with all this blood, likely concussed." To Hirsch: "You should have hit him harder, boss. Murder would go quite nicely with well, the long list of charges that you're about to face."

"You fucking bitch!" Hirsch surprised everyone when he spun, twisted Ty's Glock from his hand, and pointed it towards me.

I waited for the end. Three thunderous cracks rang in my ears, coming in quick succession. I swear I felt the bullets tear through my chest. I swooned, touching my breastbone, my heart, expecting to find blood. Instead, it was Hirsch who found the blood, staring down in disbelief as his crisp, white shirt blossomed with red, right square center mass. Beside me, gun poised over my shoulder, was Amanda. The barrel was smoking. Her chest was heaving.

My wife looked at me, her eyes wide, just as stunned as I was.

Then, I passed out.

LOOSE ENDS

I could only hear the seagulls through my left ear. My right was still ringing, even after three days, and I was beginning to wonder if I'd ever get my hearing back. Still, I was alive and for the first time, felt like I could move on.

I looked out past the beach, out at the blue water of the ocean. It was clear today, nothing but blue skies all the way to the distant horizon. I sucked in air, tasting the salty ocean breeze, smelling the brine of the water. Closing my eyes, I could feel the sun on my face. I couldn't help smiling.

"David " Her voice sounded like it was coming up through water. "David." Or a dream.

"There you are, David." She spoke into my good ear, and like that, I snapped to.

"Oh, hey."

Amanda looked like a new person. She actually wore a pant-suit today, her dark blue blazer cinched at her waist by a single, golden button. Beneath, her collared shirt was crisp white, unbuttoned enough to hint at cleavage in a way that she never would have in the past. Her hair was twisted up in a bun.

"Hey, back," she said, snuggling up behind me and nuzzling my neck.

The FBI had moved us out of our apartment, into a safehouse way up the coast, far from the hustle of LA. Far from all the noise.

And there was a lot of noise. LA was a shitshow, and the media didn't even cover the full extent of it. Nikolai Kozlov had been taken into custody by the FBI. The evidence against him was immense. His network had been so conveniently gathered into one place by Bradley Hirsch, and while they weren't all murdered, they were now also in custody.

"How did it go?" I asked.

"I'm tired of debriefing. Talking to all the suits."

I turned, leaning against the balcony and pulling her close to me. I ran a hand up the lapel of her blazer. "Don't judge me, but I'm liking *you* in a suit."

"Mmm, or me getting out of my suit?"

"That, too." I pulled her in for a kiss, warm and familiar—yet still not totally familiar. "So tell me what you learned? There's still so little news that I can believe."

"And that's by design," she said. "After a spectacular shootout aboard a fancy yacht, we got the bad guys. There were casualties."

"One of which was the Regional Deputy Director of the LA office of the FBI, shot by his own agent. Don't tell me that they're going to exonerate him post-mortem or something."

"Oh, no," Amanda said with a laugh. "No, he's taking the fall. This one's too big to cover up."

I went a little cold at the implications. "And what about you?"

"Me? I'm nobody. Just a cog in the machine. That's the company line, anyway. That's the case for all of us in his little rogue operation."

"Everyone?"

She knew who I was referring to specifically. "Yes, even Julia."

"What about that guy who tried to kill Kozlov?"

"Aguilar? He's being reassigned to North Dakota, pretty sure. Something like that. Desk job for life."

"And us? A desk job for life will be a very slow and painful death for you."

"Yeah " Amanda said, her expression pensive. "I've been thinking about that."

"About us?" A bubble of worry throbbed through me. I wondered if that would always be there. We'd come a long way since I realized that she was working at the Gold Club—and having sex while she was—but some things were still raw. That kind of thing took time to heal.

Amanda seemed to realize where my head was going. "What? No, honey, not like that." She didn't make excuses or try to invalidate my feelings. She'd even suggested counseling to help us move together into the future. I appreciated the effort. "I I think I'm going to quit my job."

"Quit? But this has been what you've been working towards your whole life. You sacrificed so much. You "

"I went to a dark place because I thought it was what I had to do to get the bad guys," she completed.

"And you got them."

"I did."

"Jazz is off the streets."

"It is," she agreed, then qualified it, as she always did: "For now, anyway."

"You even took down a rogue cell within the FBI."

"Bonus points for me." She was suffused with quietly sarcastic exuberance. "Yay," she whispered. "But also, I lost my way. I almost lost you. I'm not doing that again."

"Well, then, what are you going to do?"

"I was thinking of exotic dancing." When my eyes went wide, she laughed. "Kidding, kidding."

"I have a feeling you'd be pretty good at it." I pulled her into my arms. "You don't have to do this for me, you know."

"And I'm not." She ran her hands up my chest, fixing her blue eyes on me. "I promise you, I'm not going to wake up some day and have regrets. These past few

months, they've been an awakening, in a sense. I know that sometimes the price paid is too much. Even for justice."

"Hanging up your spurs?"

The sun had begun to set, turning all that azure blue into a deep, endless orange. She smiled. "Ride into the sunset with me?"

"Is that a euphemism?"

Amanda cracked up. "Can be." She took my hand and dragged me towards the house. "Come on, let's make it one."

I TRACED my hand along Amanda's lower back. Her skin was still damp from our vigorous "ride into the sunset." It was dark outside now, and while we needed to get up and get something to eat, we both were content to just lie in bed naked together.

"So this'll start fading in a few weeks?" I asked, my fingers following the swirls of Amanda's fake raven tattoo.

"I think so. I've never let it go that long."

"You should have it inked permanently." Even I was shocked by the words that came out of my mouth. Amanda rolled onto her side to stare up at me, eyes wide.

"What?"

"She's a part of you now. The raven. It would be almost wrong to say goodbye."

"A part of me, but she isn't actually me."

I ran my eyes over her naked body. "What about something more subtle then. Like raven wings on your shoulder blades."

We cracked up together. "I'm not sure you know what 'subtle' actually means." As our laughter faded, though, she was thoughtful. "I'll think about it. I don't hate the idea "

We rearranged ourselves, the cover half-on, half-off. The door to the beach was still open, and I could hear the surf outside despite the ringing in my ear. "What happened on the boat, leading up to Friday night? You were with Kozlov with Nick for a few days."

"Yeah. On that big, beautiful boat of his."

"I'm guessing you didn't just play Scrabble and get caught up on *Castaway*."

"How did you know? I still can't believe Chelsea didn't win." She was nervous, and that made me nervous. But also so turned on. I wondered if *I* would be able to give up this life on the edge.

"It's okay, Amanda. You can tell me."

"We fucked. We we made up for some lost time. We couldn't leave the boat, so there wasn't a whole lot to do, other than do it."

My hair felt like it was on fire. "And you liked it?"

"I didn't hate it."

"You *liked* it," I insisted. No more dithering.

"I did. He he made me put on that collar you saw me wearing the last night. He made me wear it the whole time. Sometimes, I was naked. Sometimes, I was out on the yacht's deck in a bikini. But the collar was always on."

I was hard now. The more she spoke, the more I swelled. "What did he make you do?"

"As his confidence grew, he started to bring people over. Irina was one of the first."

"She was in on it?"

"No, but she was a loyal employee at the Gold Club, and I guess they had that Russian bond thing. He tied me up and made her edge me all night long. By the time they finally let me come, I would have done anything."

"Did you?"

"Well kind of."

"Who?"

Amanda pushed me onto my back and mounted me. She wasn't at all surprised that I was erect. "Couple financiers that Kozlov knew."

"You still want to call him Nick."

"Habit. I don't have feelings for him."

"I know." I did know. She hadn't rushed to check on him when she'd come down into the engine room. She hadn't gone to see him in prison. I knew that she didn't have feelings for him, but what I wondered was how she felt about the world that he gave her access to, and the woman that he unlocked inside of her. "'Financiers,' huh?"

"I 'knew' one already, and got to know the other pretty intimately, too. Remember how Julia was tied up to the bed in the end? I tested those bonds out first."

"Wish I saw that."

"Maybe we can try it again. I didn't think I'd like being restrained, but there was something freeing about giving up control." She rode me faster, as if demonstrating that while she sometimes liked giving up control, she wasn't about to make it a regular thing.

"They took turns using me." She rocked her hips faster, eyes glazing as she relived the moment. "Then they stopped taking turns and did me together. They strapped a ball gag on me when they DPed me." She fucked me harder.

"Still tied to the bed?"

"Yes. It was fucking crazy." She moaned. "Fuck, fuck "

"And then did you come?"

"Only when Nick climbed over my face and rammed his dick down my throat. He told me that I couldn't. He told me that he'd punish me if I did. But I couldn't uhhh couldn't hold back any longer."

"Don't hold back, Amanda," I said, hands on her hips, helping her bounce.

I joined with her, thoughts of her airtight tryst blazing behind my eyes. She knew how my mind worked now, and how much the idea of her being bad both haunted and excited me.

Amanda collapsed next to me. This time, I was truly spent. "What happened to the financiers?"

"Indicted. Money laundering charges mostly, tied to the flow of jazz money."

That reminded me: "I watched your very first encounter with him," It was funny how I still hadn't told her about that. "You in his office. He made you do coke."

"He liked making me do drugs. It was one of his fetishes."

"And do you?"

I appreciated that she didn't immediately tell me no. "It was a part of the experience," she said slowly. "I can see why people lose their lives to it. The rush, the euphoria, feeling untouchable. It's seductive, and so scary how easily you can get sucked in. Jazz was particularly insidious, especially the latest version of it. But I never took it home with me, and I only ever did any of it when I absolutely had to. Like I said before, I picked up a few tricks to minimize it, but it wasn't always possible."

"How about Friday night at the party? I saw Irina pass you that pill."

"Yeah, I didn't swallow that. Another thing I've gotten good at are things that involve my tongue." The joke broke the tension, but Amanda wasn't going to let it go. "I'm going into rehab later this week, and I'm taking it seriously, David. I'm familiar enough with the industry to know that some things can't be done on their own."

"And you don't have to." I pulled her close and kissed her. "You're never on your own, okay?"

She nodded. "I'm sorry I didn't tell you about the bombs. I found them when I was snooping around early Friday morning. I nearly aborted the whole thing before Julia informed me that the triggering devices were fakes. Nice job bringing her in, by the way. I hate to say it, but I don't think we could have done it without her."

"It's funny how terrifying an abused dog can be when it slips the leash."

"Hirsch was setting her up to take the fall, should things go south. She was his contingency plan. It's making things pretty fucking hard now. If Hirsch was anything, he knew how to navigate government bureaucracy."

"Should I feel sorry for her?" I asked.

"That bitch? No." But after a laugh, Amanda added, "But I suppose we do owe her a little for actually confirming that it was Hirsch pulling the strings. But no, don't feel *sorry* for her. She's not going to jail. She'll be fine."

"You know what's not fine?"

"What?" Amanda asked, those big blue eyes filled with concern.

"My stomach. It's very empty."

"Oh." Amanda mock-frowned and hit me gently.

"Jumpy much?"

"Probably for the rest of my life."

I SAW Julia just one more time after that. I was picking Amanda up at the rehab facility in Anaheim, waiting for her in the parking lot when Julia emerged. She

was dressed for work—blue pantsuit, aviators, her long, blond hair falling loosely around her shoulders.

At first I didn't think she saw me standing there, leaning on my Camry. I was almost okay with that. I still had mixed feelings about the woman, despite our shaky alliance. But then again, we'd been through some shit together.

I waved at her, catching her attention. When she looked my way, the stern and disapproving woman that I was so used to just wasn't there. She actually smiled. "David," she said, walking over to me. "Here to pick up Amanda?"

"That's the plan."

She pushed her sunglasses into her hair so we could see each other. "Lucky her." I couldn't tell if she meant to say it aloud.

"You had to go through it, too?" I asked, nodding at her duffle.

"We all did. Mandatory, you know, but also it was quite a scene on that yacht."

"Ah, yeah. Glad um, glad you made it?" Jesus, this was awkward.

Julia felt it, too, but was more amused by it than put off. "Hey, I'm sorry that I fucked you. In your office, I mean."

"Really?" That was surprising.

"No, not really. But it seemed like a thing you wanted to hear." She had this way of smiling at me that made me feel like an awkward kid all over again. But I wasn't. Amanda had changed, and so had I.

"Hey, I do want to know one thing," I said as she started to wheel away. "One thing that's bugging me."

"Just one? Go for it."

"Why did you send the video? The first one, I mean. It was a huge risk with some pretty dire consequences. You had no idea how I'd react."

"Ah, the video." Julia nodded, as if expecting this one. She set her bag upright and leaned against the car beside me. "It's pretty simple, really. As I explained earlier, you put us in some real shit. Amanda was close to getting into Kozlov's good graces, but when you showed up on the scene, she lost her mojo, and you, Dave the Muscle, were the only one who could give it back."

"But how did you know I'd react that way to that video? Plenty of other men would say, 'Fuck this, I'm changing the locks and finding a divorce lawyer.' In fact, nine times out of ten, that's probably the end result of a stunt like that."

"Sure, fine, if we were taking a random sample. But none of this was random. You don't think the FBI did a psych eval on you, too, before deciding to send your wife under? And I don't mean just Hirsch's band of merry men, but the legitimate ones? We had a general idea of the level of your devotion, who you were. The rest was just intuition."

She straightened up and slipped her sunglasses back down over her eyes.

"Plus, I think your sense of risk and consequence is different from mine. Worst case, you get your wife killed and live out the rest of your days burdened with guilt. Or maybe not. Maybe you hate her and are happy it ended that way. Maybe you just never speak to her again." I wondered how much of this was autobiographical. "For what it's worth, I wouldn't have let it happen, even if the powers that be—may he rest in fucking hell—didn't care much about that kind of collateral damage."

"Thanks for that?"

"You don't mean that, and that's okay. I'm at peace with things now. I did some bad shit—some really bad shit. Part of it was because I had to. Part of it is stuff that I'm working on. But look, I hope you have a great life. I'm happy for you and Amanda."

It sounded like it was a hard thing to admit, but as odd as that, it also sounded sincere.

"I hope you find someone else one day," I said. I even sort of believed it.

Julia surprised me by grabbing me and pulling me into a bear hug. I ended up hugging her back, and despite all of my complicated feelings for this woman, it felt good. "I hope I do, too," she whispered. She stepped back, looked me in the eyes, and smiled. I couldn't see her eyes behind her mirrored aviators. "Goodbye, David."

She was gone before Amanda emerged, although I got the feeling that my wife had been waiting inside until all was clear because the first thing she did was give me the same firm bear hug as Julia. She nearly squeezed all of the air out of me. Then, she said, "You two work things out?"

I didn't find the jealousy that I was expecting. Amanda was smiling.

"Uh, yeah. I think?"

"Never can tell with that one," Amanda agreed. "For what it's worth, after spending a week with her, I think—I *think*—that I'm sort of kind of okay with her, too. I at least understand her more. Despite being the right hand of the worst traitor to work in the Bureau since Robert fucking Hanssen, she's actually always been straight with the people she works with."

"She wants what we have."

Amanda drew me into her arms. "I know, and I'm done taking you for granted."

"You do any thinking about what you're going to do next while you were in there doing yoga and meditation or whatever?"

"I thought a lot about it," she said.

"And?"

"And I still don't know, and that's kind of exciting. While I was in there, I realized just how much of my life I've planned and plotted out. I was supposed to be special-agent-in-charge in some branch office after this. This was my big break. But it all feels hollow." Unshed tears glistened in her eyes, threatening to spill over at any moment. Her voice wavered. "Except except for you."

My heart ached for her. "Oh, Amanda."

She tried to smile away the tears, but the more she attempted to wipe them away, the faster they flowed—here was a woman finally learning to be truly vulnerable.

Her watery eyes locked onto mine. "I'm done planning my life out." She shook her head resolutely, a single tear trailing down her cheek. "Whatever comes next, all that's important is that it's with you."

EPILOGUE

“What are we celebrating?” I didn’t recognize the dancer, but like all of them here, she was hot as hell—red hair, pale, unblemished skin, a tight body.

“My buddy’s promotion,” I said, raising a glass in Ty’s direction. The dancer turned her charm on him, bending over at the waist to give him a view down the front of her tight top.

“Well, congratulations, big man.” To me, she said, “You should buy your friend a dance.”

Ty raised his brows at me, nodding in agreement. I fished out my wallet.

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She sauntered up onto the stage wearing a pair of silver hot pants and a matching silver halter. The *deja vu* was real. This was the same stage that I’d first watched Raven spin on. She was wearing the same outfit. And when she clutched the brass stripper pole and spun around it, she moved with the grace and experience of Raven.

There were differences now, though. She’d kept the deep tan. Her hair was cut a little shorter. Her tailbone tattoo was gone.

The redhead flipped her hair as she climbed into Ty’s lap, glancing towards the stage. “I don’t mind you looking,” she said. “I think she’s pretty hot, too.”

Ty was *definitely* looking. My gut tightened at that—just as it always did when I even thought about my wife and best friend hooking up back in school. It was funny to think that despite all that had happened over the last six months, Ty still hadn’t seen Amanda naked since back then.

That was about to change now.

"I heard she used to dance here," said the redhead. "Back when it was The Gold Club."

"Oh?" I said. Amanda glanced over at us, grinning as she reached behind her and unclasped the halter top. Her full breasts sprang free. I could hear the murmur of approval over the driving bass of the music. "You didn't work here back then?"

"No. I came over when the Orchid Lounge people took over the space. Most of the girls here are from other locations around the country."

"And where are you from?" Ty asked.

Amanda, topless and in her element, crawled across the stage, teasing a trio of college-age guys, who were showering her with dollar bills. I was only half paying attention to Ty and the stripper, and my heart started to beat faster as she casually took what appeared to be a twenty from one of the boys and slipped it into a garter that was already overloaded with cash.

"I'm from all over," I heard the stripper say behind me. "I'm happy to chat more in private, if you'd like."

Amanda straightened, sliding her thumbs into her tight, silver shorts. She turned her back to the guys—and me—and swung her hips as she eased them down, revealing a silver g-string. The guys went crazy, nudging each other as they stared at her perfect, heart-shaped ass.

"I'd like to watch this," I heard Ty say behind me. "She's she's a friend."

"Ooo, like, a *friend* friend?"

"No. Just a friend. She's actually his wife."

"Even more intriguing," the stripper said. "I have so many questions."

"Happy to answer them all in private."

They laughed together.

Amanda was back at the pole now, hoisting herself up, legs above her. Suspended from above, she hung upside down, her dark hair pooling around the stage, her body flexing and exquisite. In this pose I could see the new tattoo she had on the back of her neck—a black bird with its wings spread, taking flight.

The set ended. Another dancer took the stage. I watched Amanda slip into the crowd, naked except for the g-string, flirting as she moved into the dressing rooms again. She paid special attention to the three college guys, who, like me, watched her the whole way through the room. I was so hard, my heart racing so fast.

The redhead whispered something to Ty. She was naked now, I noticed, stripped down to just her thong. Her nipples were hard. With a sly smile, she slipped out of his lap, gathered her things, and sauntered away.

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"Tell me that's not why you sent that redhead away. You're not getting a lapdance from her."

"You're no fun, you know that, David?"

"I think I'm a lot of fun. Just maybe not for you."

Ty chuckled. "Don't worry. Angelica there is going up on stage soon, but promised to take me back after."

"That's more like it." We watched the dancer on stage, sipping our beers. The three college guys actually moved into the table next to us, and I could hear them

chatting about 'Raven'. "You see how she looked at me? She wanted it fuckin' bad."

"She looked at everyone like that."

"Naw, man. I've been to a million of these things. You can tell. She's not like the others."

I looked at Ty, and we shared a grin. "What happened with you and Mia?" I asked. "I thought things were going well."

"Things were fun, but neither of us were really looking for anything long-term. She took a job in France somewhere, and that was it."

"Yeah, I heard she left the bureau," I said.

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"Not yet. She's taking her time."

"Good thing. No need to rush it, and she's been through a lot." He sipped his beer. "How are *you* doing?"

"Me? I'm good, actually. More than good."

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I never took my eyes off of Amanda surrounded by those three guys. "I've got a few ideas."

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He was probably right, but because he was Ty, he ruined his sound advice by adding, "Why don't you try the same tactic on me. I'll be more open to it."

Amanda snorted. I just grinned and shook my head.

LATER THAT NIGHT, in bed, just the two of us, I asked the question that had been on both of our minds lately. "So was that really the last time we'll see Raven?"

"Yeah, tonight, we say goodbye to her. No more dances. No more teases."

That's when I remembered Javier and my promise. Amanda saw it in my face, too. "What?" she asked.

"Well, don't get mad, but remember that guy who ran the traces for us? The guy from Spain?"

"Sure," she said slowly, planting her hands on my chest.

"Maybe Raven comes out of retirement for one more lap dance?"

"Oh, Amanda gives them out, too," she said with faux seriousness.

I laughed softly. "Well, I hope Amanda isn't upset that I promised him one for the help."

"For what he did? Why don't you grab your phone and send him a sneak peek at what he'll be getting."

"Naughty." But I did as instructed, reaching for the nightstand and grabbing my phone. She rose up over me, posing with her head tipped to one side, using her hands to cover her breasts. As sweaty as she looked, there was no doubt that she'd just had sex.

I snapped the photo, asking her once again if she was sure before sending it off. "I'm sure," she insisted, squeezing my cock.

Off it went with a woosh.

His response was almost instantaneous, but it wasn't what I was expecting.

I've been meaning to get in touch with you. Don't want to chat over messages. Too insecure. Call me when you're free. But David? Remember how I was going to take my OTHER payment? Turns out, I may have stirred up the hornet's nest.

My blood went cold.

"What?" Amanda asked.

Another message slid into view before I could turn the phone to her.

Also, your wife is hot!

And one final message.

And I think I may need her help. Sorry!

Extended Epilogue (for patrons only)

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"Don't listen to this A-hole. He can't be trusted."

I vaguely recognized the guy, but couldn't place him—fit, rough in a working man kind of way, muscles straining against his black t-shirt. Apparently he knew Ty, although that didn't immediately put me at ease.

"Hey, man," Ty said. "What are you doing here?"

The guy gestured towards the stage, and then the rest of the room. "Same thing we're all doing here. Enjoying some artisanal cocktails with my buddies." He glanced at me and Amanda. "I didn't want to eavesdrop, but I couldn't help it. Those three boys wouldn't know where to begin with you."

Amanda's breath caught in her throat, her cheeks flushing a delicate pink as the stranger's gaze raked over her body. That, in turn, caused my own blood pressure to rise. The college boys had been mere playthings, easily dismissed and forgotten. But this man...he commanded her attention. There was a hunger in her eyes, a flicker of genuine desire that set my nerves on edge. She quickly found her composure. "And you would?"

"Oh, me and my friend over there definitely would," he said, nodding to an even more fit man lounging at the table just behind us. "If you're up for the challenge."

He seemed to direct the question to both of us, which I found surprising.

"You're Todd, right?" Amanda asked. My turn to look at her, surprised. Did she know this guy through the case?

"Guilty as charged."

"Now you're just pumping his head up some more," Ty said. Seeing me clearly confused, Ty helped me out. "Todd was on the last season of *Castaway*, and honestly, Todd, if you'd been police, and not LA fire, maybe you would have won."

Todd ignored Ty. "Go on, ask me," he said to Amanda.

She giggled. "Did you fuck Chelsea?"

His buddy had risen from the chair to join him, putting a hand over Todd's shoulder. This man, I'm sure that I don't recognize. Taller than Todd with huge, brawny shoulders, pierced ears, and ink that wound up his left arm, his physique was more gym-hewn than his friend's, more polished. "He won't even tell me the answer to that," the guy said. "Which is answer enough."

"This is AJ," Todd introduced. "AJ, this is my buddy Ty, and his friends "

"David."

"...Raven," Amanda responded with a sly wink at me.

"So what were you whispering that chased those guys off?" AJ said.

"I asked them if they wanted to get out of here and fuck me while my husband watched."

AJ didn't even flinch. Neither did Todd.

"I've got a place just around the corner," AJ said.

Amanda looked from one to the other, then back to me. "Shall we?"

"OH, FUCK FUCK!"

Watching Amanda get taken by two virile and hard bodied guys would have been unthinkable before the UC assignment. It was thrilling now.

"Fuck me! Fuck it into me!"

She glistened with sweat. They all did, like athletes performing at the highest caliber. Amanda was in amazing shape, but it turned out that AJ owned a fucking gym, and Todd took his fire fighter training very seriously. Their hewn bodies proof alone, but it was their stamina that left me speechless and Amanda screaming.

I sat in a chair in the corner of the room, slowly jerking myself, edging close to my limits before backing off. It didn't feel passive or wimpy. I didn't feel excluded. This was a show for one, and they were amazing athletes.

We'd gone back to AJ's house after the strip club, another thing that once would have made me nervous once upon a time. But he knew Todd, who knew Ty. Also, naked and unarmed Amanda and Julia had subdued a group of five professional criminals without any help. Amanda could hold her own, should we need it.

"Fuuuuck, I'm coming!" she practically sobbed with pleasure.

We weren't going to need it.

AJ had handcuffed Amanda to the slatted headboard of his brass bed, and blindfolded her. He had her on her back, driving into her at a punishing pace. Each snap of his hips sent shockwaves rippling through her body, her tits rippling

and her moans matching time with his thrusts. Todd knelt by her side, stroking his dick, waiting his turn. When her orgasm washed through her, he climbed over her face, rubbing his cockhead along her lips. She opened them, accepted his dick without hesitation.

The two men had already come once, taking turns with her at first as I watched. I'd lost count of how many times Amanda had cried out. Now that they were satisfied, these guys really turned things up, and Amanda was there for all of it.

"Suck that cock, baby," AJ said as he watched her take Todd into her throat. He teased her nipples, slowing the pace of his thrusts as she choked on the dick.

When Todd pulled free, Amanda gasped for air. "Where are you going?" she asked huskily. "I was just getting used to—ngh!"

This time, they didn't relent. Todd plunged into her throat, filling the room with her gagging chokes for air. AJ went back to jackhammer mode. And I sat and watched my personal pornographic movie, starring the sexiest woman in the world.

But as good as all of that was, my favorite part was the end—it always was, and it always would be. I crawled up onto the bed as AJ and Todd left us alone, going for water. She was face down at that point, sweating and panting hard. I kissed her ass, and somehow, she knew it was me almost immediately, despite the blindfold.

"It's you," she sighed.

"It's me."

"Did you enjoy the show?" she asked.

I kissed up her body, tasting the salt of her sweat, my nose filling with the tang of sex. I kissed her beneath the blindfold, caressing her overheated body. She returned the kiss with passion. "I loved the show."

"Make me yours again?"

I pushed the blindfold up so that I could meet her eyes, so large and vibrant, so blue. "Did I ever lose you?"

She grinned. "No."

I reached up and unsnapped the cuff on one of her wrists. "Then how about I just fuck you instead."

I leaned onto my back as she mounted me. "Sounds just about perfect."

"So was that really the last time we'll see Raven?"

"Yeah, tonight, we say goodbye to her. No more dances. No more teases."

That's when I remembered Javier and my promise. Amanda saw it in my face, too. "What?" she asked.

"Well, don't get mad, but remember that guy who ran the traces for us? The guy from Spain?"

"Sure," she said slowly, planting her hands on my chest. Her hair fell around her smooth cheeks.

"Maybe Raven comes out of retirement for one more lap dance?"

"Oh, Amanda gives them out, too," she said with faux seriousness.

I laughed softly. "Well, I hope Amanda isn't upset that I promised him one for the help."

"For what he did? Why don't you grab your phone and send him a sneak peek at what he'll be getting."

"Naughty." But I did as instructed, reaching for the nightstand and grabbing my phone. She rose up over me, posing with her head tipped to one side, using her hands to cover her breasts. As sweaty as she looked, there was no doubt that she was having sex.

I snapped the photo, asking her once again if she was sure before sending it off. "I'm sure," she reassured, squeezing my cock.

Off it went with a woosh.

His response was almost instantaneous, but it wasn't what I was expecting.

So I've been meaning to get in touch with you. Don't want to chat over messages. Too insecure. Call me when you're free. But David? Remember how I was going to take my OTHER payment? Turns out, I may have stirred up the hornet's nest.

My blood went cold.

"What?"

Another message slid into view before I could turn the phone to Amanda.

Also, your wife is hot!

And one final message.

And I think I may need her help. Sorry!

THE END (for now)